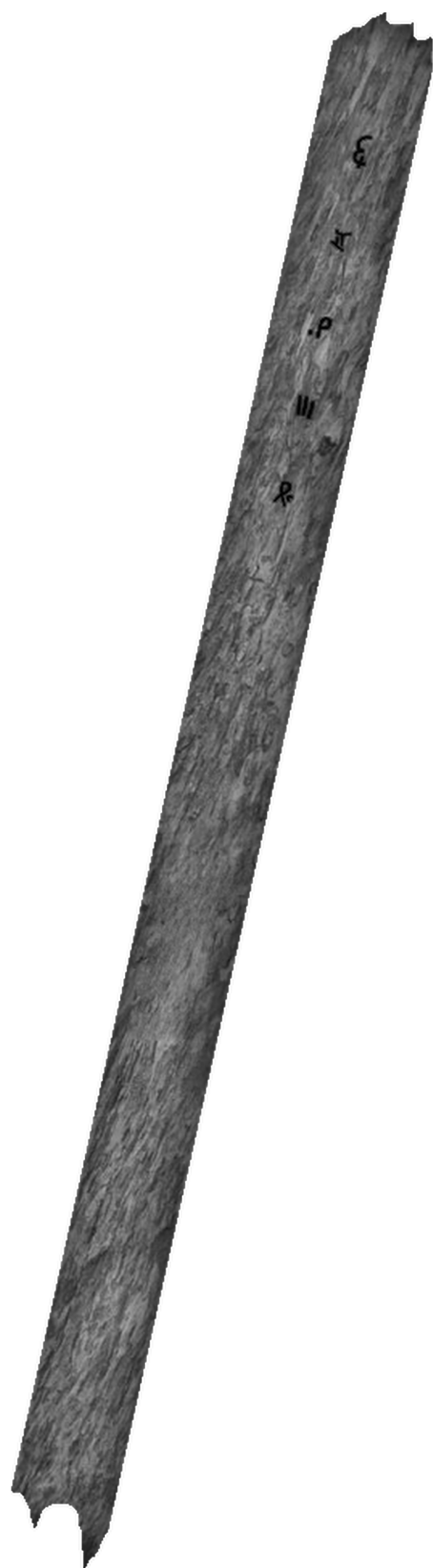




Tyzmon: The Last BladeHunter
Tales From Archangel Valley
"This is Book One"

A Fantasy Novel
by r wesley edwards

~

Tyzmon: The Last BladeHunter

Copyright © 2013 by R Wesley Edwards ALL RIGHTS RESERVED

Cover art courtesy of **dominicVFX** *Thank You Very Much!*

Publication date: Oct 31, 2014 (6"x9" Complete 2014 Edits)

Layout and 'preview' (ebook ToC) © 2013 Robert Edwards
Publishing Cottage – Altadena, California

ISBN-13: 978-1493719075

ISBN-10: 1493719076



The publisher and author ask that you not participate in or encourage piracy of this copyrighted work. Please don't scan, reproduce or distribute this book except to use short excerpts for the purposes of critical reviews.

This book is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental except where permission was sought and granted. Also, the San Gabriel Valley is a real place in Los Angeles County.

Additional copyright-related information

Google search, Wikipedia and Google maps have been extraordinary tools and invaluable references throughout the conception and composition of this narrative. These three sources comprise the bulk of my research.

I'll be in your debt for half a billion years.

A debt is owed to the authors, contributors and editors of FutureTimeline.net specifically this page:

<http://www.futuretimeline.net/beyond.htm>
...accessed 12:18 PM on Thursday, October 24, 2013 for
this acknowledgment.

500 Million Thanks!

Copyright page derived from the internet here:

<http://www.judechapman.com/format-your-ebook-manuscript-for-kindle-or-nook>
...and was accessed at 11:35 AM on Sunday, September 8,
2013.

You have my gratitude.

~

Dedications/Public Humiliations

Readers: without whom, I'm simply *an old bastard with a beautiful pen and too much ink.*

When the sands of time run down, down through to the bottom of the hourglass, just flip it over and start anew!

–Macmillan The Unenviable

Visit our forum:

<http://tyzmonbladehunter.freeforums.net/>

Twitter personalities: [@LastBladeHunter](#)
[@IconTheFireman](#) [@RadulfUnlucky](#) [@OldYellowDragon](#)

~

TABLE OF MILESTONES

1st Half: Mysteries of the Valley

Act 1

Introduction

He could hear his own breathing...

This branch is a part of me, thought Tyzmon.

A sigh and a gasp for breath and the man sat up.

The man was breathing ... again.

I imagine, at this point, Tyzmon just wanted company. Or was he acting out of morbid curiosity?

But the man did not speak a word.

"Do you have a name?"

"Don't die on me, John."

The skeleton said nothing.

(Are you my brother?)

"I cannot die?"

Tyzmon realized he was hungry; then he wasn't.

There was a rustling off in the distance...

Voices swirled in the air around his head and clung to his face...

Chapter I: The Soldier

Chapter II: The Large Ones

"Don't worry, man."

Chapter III: A Lonely Episode

Maybe it could get worse after all...

Act 2

Chapter IV: A Return to the Valley

"Does anyone know what happened here?"

"Master, why did you leave us?"

"I was eaten by a dragon!"

"You, sir!"

Who expects giants and dragons?

"Don't worry, man."

Tyzmon turned, suddenly embarrassed, barefoot in the grass.

"You attempted to sharpen it?!"

"Min livmoder bliver frastødt af mænds krige."

"What do you want!" It was the prisoner, he was screaming.

Tyzmon, impatient, said, "Dig a hole, put him in it."

Chapter V: Reunion

"Ralph? What the hell happened here?"

Act 3

Chapter VI: A Loss In the Night

"No, Sir, it's not that he's missing, he is dead, vaporized or something."

This is either a terrible weapon or a soldering tool.

No one else saw any of this.

There was an almost soft brushing noise as he fell.

Jens recovered instantaneously with an audible inhale of breath.

Having nothing to lose, the soldier brought her the ball.

Chapter VII: Reunions

Nothing happened. Nothing happened at all.

The more one thought about it, the more otherworldly they seemed, the more superficial the similarities!

Clarke deliberately injected himself with the fluid he removed from Icon.

Chapter VIII: Technological Marvels

It did work.

~~ Intermission ~~

2nd Half: The Inclusion Zone

Act 1

Chapter IX: The Large Ones Redux

It was Radulf and he had a sword.

Chapter X: Mark V Humanity

"What do you see?"

Why? How?

The room got spooky quiet again.

Radulf said, "Now I'm going to be sick."

She had tears on her cheeks.

He'd have to remember to ask Tyzmon about this sometime.

Icon pushed a contact behind his ear.

Icon shook his head with frustration.

Ralph said, "Who or what is religion?"

Tyzmon thought about the Moon.

Chapter XI: Gisela's Mission

Nothing happened. Nothing at all.

Lt. Kanin was alive.

Act 2

Chapter XII: Among the Alphas

It wasn't a facsimile.

"The hell?!" She said.

Nothing happened. Nothing happened at all.

Seeing is believing and not everyone saw.

The door opened and Radulf was standing before him.

There were noises outside, voices.

"And we've had this conversation before."

Chapter XIII: Reunions

Guess I'm going to work.

Tomika barked: "Are you south and west of my location?"

Twenty-three minutes and five seconds later...

Chapter XIV: Orcpocalypse!

The purple titan bellowed, "Ahhhh!"

They didn't see any orcs.

Soon, though, it was raining.

Chapter XV: Armageddon!

And-but-so the orcs were revived!

And then it was over.

Act 3

Chapter XVI: Genesis

Be sure to be buried in the Archangel Valley.

Gonna install more powerful lasers, thought Tomika.

Tyzlane Staff all but abandoned on the landing above.

And he just sat there!

"Iānuξ"

Chapter XVII: A Return to the Valley

I believe it's the kind of thing ya call a win-win.

A happy child covered with tiny, dense dark green, almost blue, scales.

And the ground shook and shook some more.

Both women shook his hand. And the deal was done.

...And they spent the night like that.

...And the inkwell is far from empty.

For tomorrow a parting of ways.

Tonight you could hear crickets if you were awake to do so.

Of course Tomika could stay!

Chapter XVIII: Exodus and Revelation

The water slowly subsided.

They had a long wait.

A soldier.

This was going to take three days, easily.

Icon came running over, said, "What happened?"

And he was gone!

But this was a problem, because there was a fork in the road.

Epilogue

Afterword

Curtain Call

What more could a man want?

"Never look a gift horse in the mouth." Is one.

So my guess is he's worm food.

Perhaps Apollonia learned her lesson.

...but she had her bio-bot army.

Uta. Uta and Clarke.

"Out there, they're out there."

Who knows?

And sometimes those people are revived and take their revenge.

1ST HALF: MYSTERIES OF THE VALLEY

All the players shall be brought to the stage...

Introduction

Sol hung in the sky, more than half-way down, a promise of night, and to confirm it, Luna rushed ahead acquiring the nightly hue of midnight blue. 'Twas early evening, some stars twinkling, and Venus, of course. Later, Mars would make his crimson self known, a rusty, distant light...

Tyzmon took a deep breath. He was alive and you knew he was alive. Alive. Alive and breathing. He decided to try to get a look around. The pain in his abdomen was receding to a dull throb and he no longer felt he was nailed, through his guts, to the ground.

How bad was the wound, he wondered. Apparently not bad enough: he was conscious. He could hear nothing but flinched, twice – bending to look – once for the pain, and once for fear that he'd made a loud noise and would bring an enemy to finish the job.

Did he cry out in pain? He couldn't be sure. But still, nothing, no movement, no other sounds. In his own head the surf was banging against him and carrying him partially out and back and dropping him again upon the shore to writhe in agony.

But the reality was much simpler. He was barely moving and alone in an empty field. Alone, that is, except for the bodies. Later, he'd stumble over them as he made his way out of the field, out of the past and into the present, and into a new kind of war. We may think he was dreaming; we may think he was hallucinating; we may even go so far as to think, or say we think, he was lying – and maybe he was – but the tale, so bold and full of action, demands to be repeated. And if I fail to keep your

attention, if I fail to give a full account, if I fail you, dear reader, the failing is mine and mine alone: because the way these events made their way into my head, so that I could relay them to you, does not excuse a retelling that lacks polish and fails to keep the interest of the audience – or indeed, annoys the audience and turns it against the storyteller himself and forces a new kind of embellishment: The lie that I do not know the story at all.

He could hear his own breathing...

He could hear his own breathing, now that was something. It was the first sensation after what felt like the mid-point between a kind of nauseous whirling in a giant oil-topped coffee cup and oblivion, nothingness itself; an unpleasant dream without any real shapes or sounds.

As he stood, he felt better and was surprised to find there was no blood on him. He'd fallen onto a tree branch and that, I suppose, explained the pain earlier. Still, Tyzmon opened his cloaking robe from the hidden clasp at the front and began a self-inspection for injuries which apparently ended satisfactorily, as he next closed the clasp, adjusted his clothing and began to look around for his gear.

This is a problem, because he was suddenly confused and his memory was blank. He was a child in the teachings and was raising his hand eagerly as the wizard perused the towheaded students and finally settled upon the young Tyzmon who couldn't remember what he was going to say. At all. Or even what the question had been. Now, half a billion years later and a few billion steps taken on older legs, he could remember that question, but his own current circumstances evaded him, swam like shiny, dazzling fish, avoiding his grasp, but worse, even confusing his very eyes as he tried to catch the merest glimpse of them.

He straightened, blinked his eyes and tried to get a fix on his position. "Start fresh." he said aloud. A battlefield, it was a thought. "I am in the middle of a battlefield." "I am uninjured." "There are no people or animals near."

Then, bewildered, he looked at his feet. He was wearing some fine boots finished with what appeared to be fish scales, there was a shimmer about them and in his head, a similar shimmer. The 'branch' he'd earlier blamed for the pain, was a weapon of some kind, his weapon.

Tyzmon bent to recover the branch and in that moment heard what could only be construed as a human call. A shouted word or more, off in the distance. His fingertips were upon the branch and the fish were in his hands and he remembered all.

The sounds were ... memories? Momentarily, he moved his fingers away from the Tyzlane Staff (!) and the quiet returned, the muddled feeling of being lost and waking in an empty field filled with pain and confusion returned; and with it a new feeling of having abandoned, betrayed an old, beloved friend – the smack of a soft woman turned hard by a careless betrayal. "This branch is a ..."

This branch is a part of me, thought Tyzmon.

It was a little unsettling, to be unmanned, as it were, by the simple act of lifting a finger from a piece of wood. To feel like a brain-damaged child taunted by older children because his uncle, his guardian, was a drunk who slunk along in the ...

"What's this?" *He may have said it aloud.*

He wasn't touching the branch and yet a memory surfaced. Tyzmon watched the memory unfold the way one watches puppies play on a

ledge, amusement, fascination and, naturally, terror.

A young Tyz. Again, after a day in class being plagued by forgetfulness, nausea and headaches and the mocking of his classmates and the confusion of an elder wizard: The scratching of head and beard, he even removed his hood temporarily and rubbed the back of his neck. "Tyzmon, you were so eager, and yet now you are so quiet," Macmillan had said. Now outside Tyzmon, almost in tears, remembered the look upon Old Mac's face. He wasn't concerned. He'd been surprised, yes, but angry, no, not even frustrated. Who was it that was watching puppies now: Macmillan seemed genuinely interested in Tyz's confusion. Was there a trace of amusement? The older Tyzmon in the field, bent over a branch couldn't be sure he wasn't adding details to the old man's face. In any case, the old wizard recovered himself and continued the lesson as though nothing had happened and did not give Tyzzie another look nor speak of it to him after class. "Dumbass" and "What the fuck is wrong with you today, you moron drama-queen," the children were saying as they scattered to the winds after class. Even though Mac and Tyz were alone in the room, the elder did not treat him in any way different than on any other day and Tyz whispered "I'm sorry." But Macmillan did not hear or pretended not to hear and Tyzian left the room, the suite and the building a befuddled, fuzzy version of himself.

Tyzmon heard a noise and almost stood to look, not quite pulled from his reverie. He crouched, he was inches from the branch and the memory would continue whether he was going to watch it or not. He sat on the ground.

Tyzian was outside the schoolhouse but was facing it. He was several meters away – had he lifted a hand, it would have completely covered the antique icon to academia and it would have seemed he was looking down into an empty valley. He was leaning on a tree and eating an

apple. His sack was under his knees and you or I would have thought the young Tyzian was comfortable there. He wasn't eating the apple – he was staring at it. The tree was an apple tree, this apple was on the ground when he got here and in one motion, he lifted the apple, turned, dropped the sack and sat on it, back to the tree. He let go of the apple and a strange thing occurred. It did not fall into his lap. And then it did.

First blanking in class and now hallucinating, what the fuck is wrong with me, thought Tyzian. "I remember," thought the elder Tyzmon, "I remember." Long-story-short, the youthful, not quite pubescent Tyz climbed the tree, broke off a branch and it was this very branch.

Tyzmon placed his hand upon the branch and suddenly felt whole, suddenly felt powerful, the pain? A memory. The memories, painful, filling his mind, his head like a soup cup filled with a bowl's worth of soup, threatening to spill, but then ... not spilling but getting larger. The fish swam around him and ready to take orders or just be pretty or settle for a nap in his hands.

For your edification, I'll tell you this: The younger Tyz took the branch to his uncle's sister who helped him trim, wash, braze and finish it with oil. She marked it with the family's runes and then used a wood-burning tool to sear them, tattooing the branch forever using mint leaves and clover to avoid putting fire to the bark. It was odd, though, Mary was usually such a bitch. Odd: that he'd go to her in the first place.

There was a hawk in the distance and Tyzmon began to walk, Tyzlane Staff in hand, toward it. He could see mountains and it was not lost on him that this 'battlefield' was quite similar to the place where he liberated this branch and could see the old school in the valley. With every step, though, he became stronger, in mind, especially, but in body as well and was struck with the notion that it was a beautiful day. He laughed, he

even began to sing ...

Then he stepped over the first body and decided to—at the very least—not be too joyful. After three more steps, he went back to that first body and rolled it onto its side. Someone or something had removed most of this man's belongings. Tyzmon had expected to find someone such as himself with the only imagined difference that this person had succumbed to the permanent unconsciousness.

It was now that Tyzmon gave his own clothing a critical look. He seemed to be dressed, though, not for war, but for, perhaps, a meeting with league acquaintances or perhaps he was going to guide apprentices in meditation. This man, however, this body belonged to a man who had been severely humbled, humiliated before being badly beaten and ... and murdered.

It was true. The throat had been cut. It was deliberate and would not have happened to an active, struggling man—a very thin, but deep cut. Tyzmon could smell herbs in the man's mouth. There was a rustling behind him and Tyzmon turned to look, already the master of his immediate surroundings. When he returned to the body (the distraction: a lizard under dry leaves, something like that?) it was fucking breathing!

A sigh and a gasp for breath and the man sat up.

It occurred to Tyzmon that this guy resembled Macmillan, a young and slightly sickly, gaunt, pale Macmillan. Don't worry, reader, it wasn't Macmillan, Tyzmon was being crazed and would have recognized his own face in a bowl of custard. The eyes were at once hard and dead. "Are you ... there?" Said Tyzmon. And the man choked out an exhale and fell, lifeless, to the ground.

Tyzmon stared at the body in disbelief and mild shock. The amusement

and giddy happiness a distant memory, though, not of the fish variety. Something serious had happened and Tyzmon didn't know what it was. Was he hallucinating – again? – was this all some kind of drunken dream? Was he the subject of a bizarre stream-of-consciousness story written by an old bastard with a beautiful pen and too much ink? Tyz shook his head. He placed the staff onto the ground and began to examine the body in a less superficial way. Clues to the man's identity before he owned nothing, not even his own body, clues to what had happened to him, and who had done it.

The man was breathing ... again.

This time, Tyzmon did not react at all. If anything changed, he knew, he had to notice it, document it, at least temporarily, in his mind. He had to know the mechanism that caused the yo-yo to go up and down, dipping into life and raising into severe disenfranchisement. "I'm fucking touching his skin." Tyzmon said aloud.

Tyzmon grabbed his staff and stood, bending slightly over the body which, breathing slowed, climbed into the higher reaches of invisible trees and was dead again.

What am I? But he knew damn well what he was. One doesn't go to a school taught by warlocks, witches and wizards for the amusement of theatre audiences, no, for that, you'd go to dramatics and learn by doing, learn by portraying a child on stage because at that age, it's the only thing you know.

"If I bring you to life, can you promise you won't be a mindless automaton and try to eat my brains?" He said aloud, apparently, to the corpse. "I suppose I can just kill you – again – if I don't like what you become."

I imagine, at this point, Tyzmon just wanted company.

Or was he acting out of morbid curiosity?

He leaned his staff firmly upon the man's gut and took the face in his own hands and realized he'd done this very motion before, perhaps many times before. Was he a necromancer? Or was he some kind of healer. Was there a rule he couldn't be both? Somehow, even though he apparently had his memories back, he couldn't even stab at the notion of his own benevolence. Am I a man or a monster? An angel or a demon? How much power do I have: am I a god? ... his thoughts continued along these lines as he watched the color return to the man's face, felt his breathing and, indeed, heartbeat through the staff, kind of cocked between his own cheek and his shoulder, ready to hold the man down if necessary.

The corpse, now not a corpse, did not move except for the signs of life. How low could this particular yo-yo go? If it would run out of string, if it'd only dangle at the end of its string, the man would be alive; he'd be stable. Maybe he'd say something. Perhaps they'd walk, traveling companions and discuss the resettlement of the ... *the thought was cut off.*

The yo-yo was now a heavy stone and the string was taut and the stone was spinning, but the man would not die if Tyzmon released him, so he did. From a step and a half away, Tyz held his staff in a gesture that was protective and, hopefully, non-threatening, wrapping a hand and part of an arm around it as though for support.

He watched the man recover as perhaps someone may have watched him recover at the beginning of this narrative.

But the man did not speak a word.

Tyzmon watched and did not speak a word. This man was apparently confused and barely seemed to notice Tyz was anything other than a distant bird harkening the sight of a rodent in the dense, dry, mountain grass. The corpse arose, stood upon his own feet and began looking about in the area where it had been laying, lifeless, decaying, only moments ago. Tyzmon became curious, tilting his head to the side, lowering his own hood to rub his neck, "What're ya looking fer?"

The man, apparently suddenly aware of him, stood and half-turned, "Thief?"

"Not I."

"... looking for a gem."

"Do you not want to know what happened?"

"The gem first."

"If I help you, will you agree I am not a thief as I could have just gone?"

"... agree."

Tyzmon and the man searched the area; Tyzmon didn't really know what he was looking for and, I'm sorry to say, was mostly making a show of it, using his staff to turn over rocks and clear the dry, broken grass to the bare earth or stone beneath. Fortunately the matter was settled when the other apparently found what he was looking for.

"What happened," the former-corpse said; a somewhat airy voice.

"You were dead. You don't seem dead now." Tyzmon's voice was that of an older man and it occurred to him that he didn't know his own

benevolence but he didn't know his own age. Now was not the time for the experiment, but it began to dawn on him that the memories were not his own and the branch could only do so much. "You have your trinket, I take it?" Tyz's own disregard of the other man's treasure came as a small surprise to him.

"Yes." The man returned to Tyzmon with two strong, steady strides. "Are you the Father of Heart?" *It was a gentle way of asking if he was a necromancer.*

"I did return you to the ground, but I believe you put your own feet beneath you. You stand and walk on your own. Your words are new to me. I do not believe you are my puppet. Does this convince you?"

"No, but it'll have to do." The man said nothing for an embarrassing amount of time. Then he said, "... you know what happened here?"

"I awoke as you have woken. I stood over there, using this humble branch for support, and thought an apple would taste especially good. I walked here overcome with joy which was almost shattered by sadness upon the sight of your body. I learned moments before you did that I could revive you, and I did so." Tyzmon's tone of voice was so commanding he felt it was he who was the puppet. He did not feel anywhere near as strong as he sounded but, too, made no effort to sound like anything.

"You lie, but it is a small lie; mostly you tell the truth." – A higher pitch, speaking faster.

"And you think I'm magic." *He emphasized the pronouns.* "What are you if I am a necromancer?"

"You may call me John. I have The Wisdom. I do not mind if you lie to me, I'll empathize with your insecurities and will know the truth behind

your words, I am not offended." *Someone telling you to call them 'John' in this context, is not the same as giving you his name. He was preferring to stay anonymous or perhaps he didn't have a name.*

"Do you have a name?"

"To tell the truth," – *he paused as though for theatrical effect; Tyz found it charming* – "I do not know. But I am not trying to be ironic."

"Yes. That is what I'll call you."

Tyzmon and *Ironic Truth* shook hands and the other's strength was notably different from the empty vessel Tyzmon nearly tripped over earlier. "My name is Tyz, strangers call me Tyzmon, you may call me John or nothing at all at your option. Tyz is the family name. You were correct, the staff was a gift from my aunt and a tree when I began puberty, left school and became a magician. I do not know that anyone on the planet is as strong as me and have ceased looking. Earlier, I awoke, as I said, as if from a drink-induced slumber, ungracefully bent over my own Tyzlane Staff which I, at the time, did not recognize. I was dazed, nauseated, my mind empty, no, blank. It may still be blank. The memories of my past, before ... this place ... may be what the magic staff gives me and nothing more ..." He was quite verbose, he decided.

"You speak a lot. Do you enjoy the –" ... "– Oh, you haven't spoken to another person and you think ... I am one of them." Truth stopped speaking again. The pause was becoming uncomfortable to Tyz, like when you have to piss but someone wants something from you, some token, or proof, that you won't urinate all over the walls of their mud-room. "You may speak if you like. But I do not require it."

Something occurred to Tyzmon (through influence of the staff? – who knows?) and he whirled and knocked the other man, *Ironic Truth* to the

ground, his staff humming with electric energy, his cloaking robe warm and orange with licking flames.

"You intend to return me to my high-shelf, Tyzlad?"

"Perhaps." ... but then again ... "Perhaps not." Tyzmon took his time now, he could look at the man and through him at the same time. He was wounded and perhaps could not stand on his own, probably wouldn't. "If you know, all this, why don't you know I'll strike you? Why don't you know whether I intend to shelf you?"

"That *is* a question, isn't it?"

Tyzmon's experiment had ambiguous results and-but-so he decided it was uncool. He was deciding on how to offer the other man his hand when Ironic Truth began to ... well, to fade. "How badly injured are you, John?" *In this context, Tyzmon was using 'John' in a submissive, almost overly-polite way; part of his decision to convince the man he meant no further harm, because he meant no further harm.*

"You are not a necromancer, as you, yourself seem aware. You seem to have both power of the elements and of the charge from the sky, the weather. Do you feel the wind, have you noticed the light has faded behind clouds?"

"Don't die on me, John."

"Cannot you just unspool the string again?"

"That *is* a question." He decided to echo the man himself as a further convincing gesture of his neutrality, possibly even benevolence toward him. *I'd rather not take the risk. I'd rather not damage you in a way that permanently strains our relationship, as you are the only one here besides me and I am not sure where we are, though, I believe my*

preschool was once located here. The other man – who could read Tyz's thoughts – seemed calmed, though not quite as calm as he'd hoped. "I have an idea," Tyzmon said aloud, "Take the Tyzlane Staff." He abruptly tossed the branch to the fallen man who managed to catch it rather than be crushed beneath it.

Tyzmon suddenly felt far away, homesick, and remembered choosing and cutting the branch, but the memory was fading. Before it faded completely, the perspective shifted and the branch chose him.

Tyzmon, the newcomer, sat down as though on the opposite side of a cooking fire from Truth who studied him in a way that most people would rather not be studied. Truth knew all and his magic empathy soon brought tears to his own eyes. The man across from him assumed a look of concern and began to stand.

When Tyzmon stood up the wind and his own dizziness brought his ass back to the ground; better to have stayed put, he was back on his seat only now it was a sore sitting.

"Do not stand. You cannot see, Shadow, can you?"

"I can see you ... ?"

Half a smile sneaked across Irony Truth's face. "Someone with far inferior magic has done this to you, perhaps as a last effort before dying. I can remove the damage, possibly the curse as well. But ..."

"Master?"

"But do not stand. I am not your master."

"Elder Macmillan?"

"Yes, you thought I was he when you first saw me. It is impossible, we

are far away from there, far away in time, I mean. I see in your mind this valley when you were a student and there have been changes that take eons."

"Master, what has happened to me. Why did I forget my answers? Why don't I remember my life? What was the question." Echos of prepubescent school-children laughing filled his benumbed, besotted head. His mind was again filled with ...

"... with shadows; Your name is 'Shadow'. You are the last KnifeHunter, or anyway, you were before Old Mac decided to make you into the most powerful magician alive. You should keep your staff, your aunt put all her love for you into it that it would keep you out of trouble. People had plans for you and you were unaware, it'd be amusing if it wasn't so tragic. Do you even know how long ago that must have been?"

"Tyzman ... ?"

"Is your uncle's name, or, more accurately, 'Tyz' is the family name of those who adopted you. 'Your uncle' had been damaged, it appears and was permanently a child. Now you have crossed the ages to revive me and seek your answers. Move your head if you can understand, Shadow."

"Why do you call me Shadow," Tyzman said as he nodded his head.

"I want you to carefully crawl over here and take your 'branch', yes, this thing I am holding out to you. It will ground you, you'll be happier and, frankly, less dangerous."

"No one has ever called me Shadow; you are the only one."

"I am unique in a lot of things. I have died here, but it wasn't moments or days before you found me. Do you not see?" Tyzman suddenly noticed the claw marks upon the dirt, other markings made from a stick,

the other man's clothes, what there were of them, were tattered, yes, but they were also smeared with dirt. One of the fish that he couldn't catch was a broken, incomplete skeleton at the bottom of a hole that he, himself had dug.

"I ... I dug you out of the ground?"

"You will not remember, you will only have to believe what you see with your eyes." Truth was at this time gingerly touching the long, gnarled tree branch in his arms, he stopped when he noticed the strange green scorched carvings. He traced them, hovering a finger several centimeters in the air above them. Then he nodded, apparently making a decision, and traced a line of markings that were not there, above and below those that were.

"What are you doing, Master?"

"I am not your master, Shadow; I'm not sure anyone could be your master. To say so would be to claim to be the power that is puppeteer of the skies, eager engineer of earthquakes, chief chef of nature itself." And, after a pause that seemed to last for hours, he began to actually rub the branch, then vigorously and then to cut into it with fingertips which were, in fact, finger bones, and presumably as hard. Suddenly, not four, but nine runes were upon the branch and it was returned to Tyzmon who had, by this time, taken Truth's advice and more squirmed than crawled over to take it.

"Why did you call me 'Shadow', Truth," Tyzmon said when he had returned to himself. He stood up, over a long-dead corpse, still partially buried in the rock-hard ground.

The skeleton said nothing.

Taking the Tyzlane Staff in both hands Tyzmon held it above the skull. Sparks began to come from the sky, the ground rumbled beneath him. A gust of wind almost took Tyz off his feet. Then the rain.

The runes began to glow. Truth's additions changed color but Tyzmon's aunt's kept their leafy green. The ground which trapped the skeleton began to succumb to the rain and soon Tyzmon was standing ankle-deep in water. He held the staff in ever stronger, more determined hands, lifting it above a skeleton he could only barely see.

... And a moment later he was sitting on the ground, Tyzlane Staff across his lap, burning fire close enough he could kick it. A well-dressed man of gaunt features stood on the other side of the fire, tending it.

"You are awake, I see," assessed the fireman.

"You called me *Shadow*," complained Tyzmon.

"If I did, it was because you were in a place where you only awkwardly fit. You cannot be fully there but as long as you try, you cannot be fully here, either. I assume you decided to take me off the shelf after all this time, my brother?"

(Are you my brother?)

Tyzmon suddenly recognized himself again. And uttered involuntarily, "Macmillan was my father." But why was I adopted by Tyzman and his sister?

"Come, man, I cannot read your mind, I can only see that you have something you wish to say." The fireman stood, turned to face Tyzmon squarely.

"You are a fireman."

"Yes, and you, brother, would know this from when we were tadpoles ... *if* the fire burned your face but left me unscathed." And then, confusingly, "Our mother's dying blood has touched you, but not I. Have you asked yourself why you know what you look like, yet everything else is new?"

"The branch, the Tyzlane Staff, it is a vessel for memories, for the forgetting, it has been charmed ..."

"Yes, by your aunt, actually, our neighbor." There was a long pause as the fireman tended the fire. Tyzmon closed his eyes and tried in vain to recall. "Don't worry about remembering," his brother called past the fire. "Pretend this: Pretend you were placed in a basket and floated down a river in your infancy. Our mother accused me of your murder and our distant neighbors found you. However later, realizing what had happened, they approached our father at his work, our school, he advised them to adopt you and say nothing. Our mother had already been made to forget. These neighbors lived far enough away that you were lost and she never found you. After your aunt magicked this branch, or, more accurately, after you were brought to your aunt by this living branch, she imbued it with everything she knew as an offering to nature and sent you to your mother out of fear of what you'd become to her if you learned the truth through the staff."

Tyzmon opened his eyes when the other was quiet. He watched the man poke at the fire like an amused child. "You do love the flames, don't you brother?"

"I am sorry for what I did to you."

"The basket story isn't a story except that you tell it as such, it is myth

based on your own actions?"

"You are the only one I've ever told. And this, because you are involved. And because ... I suppose, you deserve to know the truth."

"... and because I can kill you?"

"You wouldn't want to kill me after you worked so hard to take me off the high shelf. How did you find me, anyway?"

"I returned to the valley, that is all I can say, and that ... is a guess, a half guess, perhaps I'm reconstructing my memories as our teacher, your father, once told us we do."

"He was our father. Your arcane knowledge a gift from him, and guilty reward for what I, we, did to you. He did not make you what you are, but it was a first step. You can never take these stairs to your own permanent unconsciousness." He sighed, then continued, "*you shall never sleep upstairs.*"

"I cannot die?"

"More accurate it is to say, 'you will not' die. Tell me, brother, how many times do you think we've had this conversation?"

"We've had this conversation before?"

"Think, man! It has been hundreds of *millions* of fucking years! Look at the wear upon these mountaintops! When we were saplings, these were *young mountains*; this was *a new valley*. You come here, you dig my old broken ass up, we have *this conversation*, you say 'huh' and you leave through," he indicated, "that pass and I ..."

"Yes, what will you do?"

"I? I do the same thing every time! I scorch the earth, dig a foundation, build a hut, where I live years and years! Sometimes other people happen by and we have our little dramas or we have no drama, just conversation and øl and I spend most of the time alone. Eventually, I am frail, I cannot feed myself and I die, usually by a fire—most times by a fire; a fire I made myself, one like this, only usually within a fireplace with a mantle. And on that mantle," the fireman's voice rose to a shout, but there was music there, "... on that mantle is a drawing of the runes carved into your staff and a wood-burning of you, your face which resembles my face enough that it likely passes for a rough self-portrait in the minds of any visitors I may have."

"I just ... leave you here?"

"Sometimes I ask, sometimes I beg, even, for you to take me with you; the first few times I refused to go with you, but you *did* offer. Now you refuse me. Now you refuse me every time. And I'll tell you why, if you want to know: you leave me here so you may return and revive me so we can re-play this little fucking drama when you forget yourself because you have always been a fucking twit where your penis is involved and the witches like to suck your memories out with the gasping, enthralled breaths that accompany your damned orgasms."

"What? I?"

"Yes, you, a man who is more powerful than the gods of the savages who think themselves so civilized, but are savages none the less for no other reason than their childish belief in those gods, *you* succumb to the charms of women who turn out to be witches – *or at least when you bitch to me about it, you **call them witches*** – and you leave me here in this little bookmarked valley to live as a perpetual hermit until you need me. It is my penance for one day, long long ago, putting your little

fucking pink body into a basket. It is my lot in life for betraying you out of jealousy, you may as well call me 'Envy'."

"I call you 'Truth'."

"It is irony for you to call me that and by now you know it." He turned away from Tyzmon. When he turned back, his face had regained its calm, its amusement. "But I am not as angry as I sound. I'm happy that you've returned, my brother and I'm glad to see you. I suppose it's good you can't catch syphilis or whatever from your whores, so that I can see you again and we can hang out and discuss life, mostly yours, by this fire."

"What is your real name?"

"Tyz? *You don't **even** remember my name!*"

"What did I call you at school?"

"We didn't go to school together, I was ... much older than you, I was seven when I placed you in that basket, you were ... days? Months, maybe? ... but, you were *quite* young. You didn't know me in school, I would have studied in solitude on one of the higher floors. I would have long forgotten what I'd done to you."

"What is your name?"

"My name is *John*."

"I'm serious."

The fireman seemed as though he could barely stand and, in fact, leaned and sat himself. A noise like sobbing came to Tyzmon from the other side of the fire. The other man was crying. All his anger, in fact, all his amusement and ... and surprise was whipped up, and then reduced as in

a pot above a flame and everything was boiled off, leaving some new, raw sorrow.

"Is this part of the drama we enact, Brother?"

"No, these things are different. You're not going to just leave me here this time, are you?"

"As you say, you are the older brother, I do not think I can tell you where you can or cannot go." Tyzmon allowed his voice to resume its deeper bellow.

"My name is *Icon*," his brother sobbed.

"Like a small picture?"

"It is the only answer to your question. Perhaps the language has changed on the other side of these mountains, but our parents called me Icon."

"Do you remember ..." Tyzmon thought of knocking the dead man to the ground what felt like only a few minutes ago. "Did we fight? I swung the staff at your legs...?"

"No. You dug me up. I assume you used rain and earthquakes to crack the ground, either to find me or to retrieve me or perhaps a little of both for both."

"How do I know you are not a dream?"

"Me?" His brother laughed, "How do I know *you're* not a dream?"

"How much of this is reality and how much of it am I to weave from loose strands of memory later?"

Icon looked up, tears catching firelight on his cheeks, "Something has

changed, Tyz?"

"I am certainly not the right person to ask."

"Naturally; or, perhaps, *unnaturally*," he winked. "OK, I'll continue tending the fire. You just hug your little friend there; I'll get some food and make a knife for you. I see you no longer have yours. Take a nap, do some thinking. Do not worry about me; I'm used to being alone." Thoughtfully, then, "if you think of anything to tell me, it's not like I'm going anywhere."

Later, ...and Tyz may even have dozed off; the Moon was alone in the sky, pin-pricks twinkled, one of them sparkly crimson, called Mars, the rest, most of the rest anyway, stars. Icon returned. He carried several small, charred bird carcasses.

Tyzmon realized he was hungry; then he wasn't.

"May I have one," Tyz's voice changed tone as though he'd aged in the middle of the request.

"You may, but I'll toss it to you; I have no mind to consume live quail." The brother laughed, but his face was serious.

"You've done this before, Icon?"

"Attempted to feed you? Yes, of course."

Tyzmon caught a shiny dark rock tossed from the other side of the fire. He only saw a flicker of firelight upon a roasted bird before the thing moved suddenly, turned its head, opened and flapped its wings and took to the air with a squawk. "I told you that would happen," said Icon going about his business, and out of sight on the other side of the flames.

"How am I to eat?"

"Maybe you're a vegetarian, my brother."

"I am *not* a vegetarian, Fireman."

"Perhaps it best to become one." Icon smiled, one could hear it in his voice. "Come Tyzmon, focus. Tell me that you still feel hungry?"

"Before I asked... I no longer felt hungry, I thought it was... I don't know. I thought I was... hungry— I'm confused."

"That will pass," said the brother. "...Or perhaps it won't; but it always has before."

There was a rustling off in the distance...

Icon turned to listen and Tyzmon began to stand, but was motioned to motionlessness by his brother. "Listen," he said.

Tyzmon listened and heard footsteps approaching, slow, possibly confused, unsteady footsteps. "Have you seen anyone else in this valley?" Icon was mouthing the words.

"Just ..." — *Tyzmon was confused—again—and as he was about to answer, a figure stepped into view, firelight and shadows animated his face.* — "... a soldier," he spoke aloud.

Tyzmon felt his legs wobble and his head spun. He felt his face strike dirt, rocks. As he lost consciousness, he heard muffled voices.

"Helloa!" Icon called and waved to the newcomer. "Come, join our little family reunion." He opened his arms—wide—in a gesture of welcoming benevolence. The other took another step, then two and was in clear view.

It was the soldier Tyzmon went back for. Icon, naturally, could not have recognized him. What could Icon have to fear anyway, probably he would have welcomed a marauder, a vampire or the devil himself to dine this night.

"This man here, on the ground." The soldier indicated Tyzmon's pathetic husk. "Is he a necromancer?"

"He is my brother," Icon said, as if that answered anything. "Things don't ... things don't die ... or stay dead ... around him ... if this is what you mean."

"He helped me earlier. I'm sorry to interrupt, if I could just have some water...?"

"Please, have a seat. I'll see what I can do."

The newcomer tilted his head slightly, "Why are you nude?"

"Oh, that could be a long story. You know part of it already, our mutual friend found me and revived me. I fear my clothing has rotted long ago. If you are offended, I apologize. When I find your water, perhaps I'll find something to wear."

The soldier said nothing, he did sit. He chose a place close to Tyzmon and began to examine him. Icon disappeared from view as he walked away from the fire.

Tyzmon's body shook, his eyes flickered and he retched, heaved. His eyes snapped open, then glazed over and blinked shut again, his body convulsing, legs straightening, arms flailing.

"If you can hear me, your brother is having some kind of seizure." The soldier called in the direction Icon had gone. There were several seconds of spasms, but finally, Tyzmon's body ceased movement and appeared

inert again. "I wonder if I can help you," the soldier said.

Voices swirled in the air around his head and clung to his face...

...and Tyzmon was conscious again. He opened his eyes and felt warmth upon his cheek and forehead. Someone familiar was touching his face. Water was splashed onto his lips. He blinked several times and the blur slowly focused to his brother, Icon and a strange man wearing rags. They were discussing something, Tyzmon couldn't decipher what; they were tending to him.

"I think I'm OK now," Tyzmon said sitting up. "What happened?"

The other two glanced at each other momentarily, then Icon said, "you had a seizure. I've never seen this before, Tyz. Your body has never seemed unfit, however strange your behavior."

"Am I dying, do you think?"

"You? I doubt it. I've seen ... things. I don't think you can die. But perhaps you are still under whatever sorcery brought you back to this valley in the first place." He paused, then continued, "not that I'm not happy to see you, of course."

Tyzmon nodded, then focused on the other man. "I recognize you ... (?)" His voice airy, this possibly a question, possibly a statement of fact.

The soldier's voice was solid, a tree in a marsh, "You revived me, I believe, this afternoon."

"Oh yes. Truth!"

"I am telling you facts as I know them." The soldier wasn't privy to

Tyzmon's hallucinations from a few hours earlier. Only we have this, um, honor.

"I mean your name. Your name is 'Truth'." Tyzmon's mind: completely closed off to the possibility that his daydreams are so realistic that he cannot tell them from reality.

"No, my name is *Radulf*," he paused between the syllables, *ray-dolf*. The man suddenly became animated and blurted, "Earlier, you helped me find an heirloom and then you began wandering, I thought you were chanting something and left you alone. I couldn't find water, and becoming desperate, I tracked you here. I didn't mean to intrude, but I was very thirsty. Your brother here," he glanced over, "has brought me some meat and water. If I can help you, either of you, I will do so." He caught his breath, returned his focus to Tyzmon. "I began to think the whole thing was a dream, but I, too, stepped over bodies and then the Sun went down, I heard coyotes—or wolves—howling. Then I heard what I thought were distant voices, then saw this fire. Thank you. And thank you—again—for helping me."

Icon and Tyzmon stared at Ralph in disbelief. Icon spoke for them both, "you are welcome as long as you wish. Other than answers, we require very little from you. If you don't mind answering questions..." Radulf was still focused on Tyzmon who shrugged slightly and nodded agreement with his brother.

"It occurs to me," Radulf started, and paused, then continued, "...that if I'm dead, there is nowhere I need to be." – *He was quiet again. Like 20 seconds.* – "But I am a little confused myself."

First, tell us your story, start at the beginning...

Chapter I: The Soldier

I was the youngest of seven children, all boys. My father was the ninth child, but also the seventh son. The significance wasn't lost on my him; he joked about it and made me feel more important than the small lad I was. Until I was seven, I'd always been one of the smaller children in any group. But then I, I don't know, I sprouted, is how my mother put it.

My mother was her parents' third daughter and she had always wanted girls. I was the youngest and she used to put me in dresses to have tea parties with me as the guest of honor. This, I was told by my brothers when I was older, if it is true, she must have stopped doing it around the time I was four. She did, though, sometimes seem to call me 'Rachel' and other feminine names, but I ignored it for the most part.

When I was fourteen, a girl who lived on a neighboring farm became pregnant and we were forced to leave our hamlet of three dozen souls. We were taken in by a company of soldiers who had been advised by a certain order of monks that charitable works would pave the way to some sort of glittery afterlife. Lucy miscarried, contracted an infection and died.

I was sick for weeks, fever and mourning, I do not recommend it. Before I fell ill, I'd intended to return home to tell Lucy's parents her fate; I felt they deserved to know, in spite of how they'd treated her. The soldiers brought me to a monastery where several monks took an interest in my well-being. I was visited by many of these soldiers whenever they were in the area. Everyone felt very bad about what happened to Lucy, to us. They were very charitable, quite kind.

Anyway, when I was strong enough that I would be in the way should I

have stayed longer with the monks, I re-joined the soldiers and became a soldier myself.

In spite of my auspicious beginnings, the company, save the captain and myself, were wiped out the very next day; they being ambushed and murdered by thieving marauders. We were spared—but only because he stayed behind to train me in hand-to-hand combat with knives and swords.

We decided the best course of action would be revenge, aye, this is not the first time I've been thought dead and become free as a consequence.

I called the captain 'Earl', though I never really knew if that was his name. We managed to hunt down and murder the thieves one by one over the next dozen years. We lived as gypsies, camping in the open at night, questioning and sleuthing in the early morning, killing in the afternoon. ...When there was a target, of course.

But we also took odd jobs here and there; revenge doesn't pay well enough to impress the ladies. Always a coin to grease palms and impress wenches. Certainly we made our share of mistakes, but justice wasn't exactly my goal and I cannot speak for Captain Earl.

Somehow in all this, we became well-known mercenaries, well-paid assassins. We were summoned by the Earl of Brechyn where we were made to wait in an octagonal, domed anteroom of unusual dimensions.

Earl and I had been discussing business while we waited. Suddenly, my throat was quite dry and he began gasping. A green, grainy haze seemed to be filling the room and I was aware of a low-volume hiss from above.

We hadn't been separated from our weapons—*as would have been customary, to tell the truth*—so were able to exit the room and the

building. We stepped over the bodies of our host and his bodyguards on the way to fresh air. We didn't know ... anything.

Were we the targets? Was Brechyn? Did someone want both parties dead, the Earl, his house, staff, bodyguards, and the Captain and I? Was the whole sordid affair an accident?

The truth is, I still don't know. Earl and I decided to be much more careful after that, let me tell you one thing. We hired prostitutes and street urchins to deliver or retrieve our work orders, we used encoded messages and drops. It all became very complicated, like the stories of lying children.

We became somewhat rich and by this time had a staff of our own soldiers. It had been over a dozen years since Brechyn, and another ten still after the demise of our company. We were still nominally indentured to the royalty and made our survival known. The captain made a donation to the crown, was given a duchy, and retired, settling down in a modest home with a round-faced wench who had a sharp tongue.

I still felt young and left Sommarsward – *the captain's duchy* – with my coin, and a promise that “*Mit hus er dit hus.*”

I joined the first collection of motley soldiers I could find and the very next day we met our fate in this valley, coming under a hail of huge round river stones, some the size of boulders. Before I awoke in your presence, I swear I saw giants and large green birds in the distance.

The gem? It belonged to Lucy. She wore it around her neck. As she lay dying, she told me her grandmother had given it to her on her own deathbed. That's when I came into possession of it.

Look at it! Ah how it glints, glows, even. If this fire wasn't here, I swear it would be a beacon in the night, a bright orange, studded with gleaming

yellow rays.

By the way, you haven't seen any giants? Or any mysteriously huge, green birds? I'm sure it was just the last dream of a dying mind, but I swear I heard the screams of my comrades and ... it's not important.

What is important is that we're here, enjoying this meat, this fire and we're alive.

Oh, but there really were giants...

Chapter II: The Large Ones

The two men ate quail fireside, discussing Radulf's story. Tyzmon, of course, participated in the discussion, however, he avoided the food. Radulf and Icon, being human, were soon tired in spite of the excitement. They left Tyzmon to his own thoughts as the conversations trailed off and they slumbered.

Tyzmon, who couldn't tell dream from reality, memory from story, sat in a position of meditation, the light from the fire dancing in his eyes and Ralph's story dancing in his imagination. He thought of Lucy, the Captain, the Earl, the locations, Brechyn, Sommarsward, the Hamlet of Helgen Ynez... He almost didn't notice the earthquakes.

There *was* a slight rumbling in the ground...

Tyzmon shook his head and thought about Ralph's injuries when Tyz first stepped over him. He'd been beaten, yes, this could be the result of large stones finding his body home; however his throat had been cut. Whoever did it did not take the gem. Perhaps he wasn't dead... *the thought was interrupted.*

The rumbling in the ground was strong enough now that the others were reacting, slightly moving, turning in their sleep. Tyzmon placed both hands on the ground and the quaking did seem to stop, but only briefly.

"I think it's a tremor," he said this aloud, but probably didn't mean to. Tyzmon closed his eyes and concentrated. All he could conjure were the figures of men walking. But they walked funny, not quite a march, but not a run. Also, their heads were out of proportion to their bodies. Tyzmon shook his head, opened his eyes, closed them and concentrated, harder this time. He brought his hands together slightly, lifting his

thumbs.

"They're not human at all," a whisper, a thought so loud it could be heard. The faces were grotesque—round mouths with pointy teeth at the wrong angles, the feet bulbous, bizarre, short arms, long, thin hands containing longer, thinner fingers with black, knife-like, nails coming out perpendicular to expectations. Also they were ash-gray with shiny, black hair.

Some of the figures in his mind began picking up rocks which they proceeded to toss into the air.

A great hiss, a soft whistle ... is what Tyzmon would have heard if he wasn't concentrating on the ground.

Several rocks hit near their encampment and Icon was smashed beneath a large boulder, killed instantly. Radulf got quickly to his feet and, grabbing Tyzmon, began to run.

Tyzmon pulled Radulf, gesturing wildly while shouting, "we need to go against or toward, but not away from, the barrage!"

"What?!"

"We cannot outrun them, we need to hide!"

Tyzmon drew Ralph to one side, in the direction of some low foothills, more trees. They reached them in minutes, minutes that felt like mountains. When the trees were dense enough, they stopped and leaned on trunks, gasping for breath and trying to be quiet, failing.

"What the fuck was that?!" Radulf was panting, but he knew the answer already. "Didn't I say there were giants?"

"Do you know your throat had been cut?" Tyzmon was supernaturally

calm.

"What? What are you talking about? When?"

"When I first found you, it looked like you'd been beaten, but ultimately, you died from having your throat cut." Tyzmon was still putting things together. "You told us you saw rocks, but you didn't mention any enemies who wanted you dead in this way."

"Shouldn't we talk about this later? I mean, aren't we in danger?"

"I'm not." Tyzmon sighed. "Why did the giants come back?"

"You think they're related?" Radulf began to realize that Tyzmon may be a little crazy. "But I *was* dead; unless they saw our fire, I cannot understand it myself."

"They could just be coming back from something, I suppose," said Tyzmon. "Maybe they saw the fire and started tossing those rocks." Suddenly Tyzmon realized something. "I didn't notice boulders near your body or, for that matter, anywhere."

"Maybe they pick them up en route and use them as ammunition?"

"Have you ever seen these creatures before?" – Tyzmon gestured against his hands, *long fingers*. He gestured at his mouth, *monstrous mouth*. ... &c.

"No, I barely saw them before, and couldn't say anything about that. Someone yelled, 'Giants!' and we all were running and then, well, then *you*."

Tyzmon sat down, placing his branch across his lap. Trying to maintain calm, Radulf did the same, their backs against tree trunks. They could still hear the rocks flying through the air, could still feel the rumbling of

them striking the ground, but a deeper rumbling as the giants' footfalls came closer.

"You have to stay here. I have to go back for Icon." Tyzmon was examining his staff and speaking as though describing it, no urgency in his voice at all. "He was asleep, so probably didn't feel ... you know."

"He was smashed under a boulder!" Radulf's horror, his shock, was palpable.

"We have to let them pass, it's true." Tyzmon took a deep breath, closed his eyes momentarily, turned his face toward Ralph:

"Don't worry, man."

There was a loud screeching, a great crack, a sudden feeling of being in the middle of a wind-storm *and Tyzmon was gone*. Branches and leaves fell where he had been sitting an instant before.

Radulf collapsed—face down—to the ground, grabbed Tyzmon's staff, wished for invisibility and tried to keep his breathing as quiet as humanly possible. Something had reached through the trees, grabbed Tyzmon and just *took him*. Radulf barely saw anything, there wasn't much light, the Moon wasn't even half full.

"*Tyzmon?*" Radulf said, somewhere between a sob and a worried whisper.

It couldn't possibly get worse

Chapter III: A Lonely Episode

The rumbling was much worse, louder than it had been before Tyzmon disappeared, Radulf spent the next several moments in mortal fear, trembling against the darkness. Sometimes the wind—or the creature that consumed Tyzmon—returned. Eventually it was quiet but for the rumbling in the ground and that, too, ceased before the first chirps and the light of morning.

Sometime after Sol made her reappearance, Ralph must have dozed off. He woke around noon and was very thirsty. He could hear the shrieking of frightful animals somewhere, in the distance, or at least that's what he thought.

He couldn't lay here forever. Slowly, he turned, he sat up. Radulf looked around, there didn't seem to be any movement. The valley beyond the trees was bathed in the Sun's noontime light. Using Tyzmon's rune-marked sceptre, Ralph struggled, unsteadily, to his feet.

He looked at the tree Tyzmon was leaning against last night, a meter of normal tree trunk, then a splintered mess. Branches were everywhere, as though a tornado had blown through. Several nearby trees had had a similar fate befall them.

Radulf, leaning heavily upon Tyzmon's staff, took a deep breath. He began to approach the edge of the clearing. There was no motion, and it was more quiet than he thought it should be. As he came closer to the open area, he moved ever slower, possibly unconsciously slowing his pace.

When the—sparsely treed—main section of the valley was in view, he started thinking the entire episode had been some kind of dream.

Nothing unusual was happening in the valley and he could hear birds chirping. But this two-meter-long gnarled and rune-painted staff was real ...

Ralph decided to return to the location of the camp fire, perhaps Icon wasn't dead, he could have been mistaken. It was difficult, still, to leave the—admittedly—weak cover of the trees. He took a few trembling steps, regaining fractional courage with every successful foot-fall.

Radulf was less than a hundred steps out and away from any possible cover from trees. Something moved. He noticed it in his peripheral vision. Radulf slowly turned his head and could see a large creature among the trees in the distance. Whatever it was, it was taller than the trees, a dark yellow, maybe even a green in color. It had four large, tree-trunk-thick legs, a long animated tail, and the long neck and nose you'd associate with a snake.

"Dragons." He said this word out loud. And, then, as though, he believed in magic, wished he hadn't summoned them by speaking the word. He could not return to the cover of the trees, the dragon he could see appeared to be searching among them. He continued—crouching slightly—in a straight line away from the trees. Moving slowly, he tried not to kick up dust or make any noise or disturb small animals.

It took a few hours, until middle afternoon, before he was within sight of last night's camp-site. *Compared to last nights run of a few fear-fueled minutes.*

Radulf, who hadn't passed any boulders on the walk here, first saw the gigantic rock that had crushed Icon the night before and then the remains of the fire with what appeared to be a 3-meter-long toe-print in soot several more meters away—a giant black dent in the valley floor, near four more, non-blackened dents and the large globular foot mark

adjacent.

He was examining the rock and trying to decide if he should try to recover Icon's body, finish burying it, or walk away, when he could feel, then hear, wind—hot wind—on his back, the backs of his arms. In spite of the heat of the day, the Sun above, the warm gust behind him, Radulf was chilled to the core; he couldn't move.

Maybe it could get worse after all...

Ralph grasped the rune-covered sceptre, turned slowly and noticed he was within 4 meters of a large dark yellow dragon. It looked at him, turned its nose, lifted its head; half-turned away and, with a shriek to wake the dead, began blowing fire.

Ralph turned in a panic, struck his head on the boulder, held himself up by the staff which broke, splintered, he staggered; desperate to put the boulder between himself and the creature.

The staff was ablaze—burning, becoming powdered charcoal in his hands—he let it go. Radulf skittered, fell to his knees, was engulfed in flames, consumed by dragon-fire.

The dragon continued blasting the side of the rock until it was blackened, then turned, took a couple rumbling steps, sped up, took three more, unfolded great wings, jumped and *flap-flap-flap*, took to the air.

If you knew what you were looking for, you could possibly see a silhouette of Radulf in the soot on the side of the boulder. Or maybe that's just your imagination.

...and everyone's dead.

Chapter IV: A Return to the Valley

En: What ate Tyzmon

A few days later, but perhaps months later, but not many months, at that, Tyzmon returned to the valley and found himself stepping over bodies (again).

It was a wonderful Spring day, the birds were chirping, the morning was glorious. Tyzmon occupied himself with a steady pace and nary a look into the faces of the dead, some of whom, having rotted, were completely skeletal.

At around noon, he saw a particularly rugged specimen laying across his path and Tyz did stop for a closer look. Tyzmon leaned upon the Tyzlane Staff, gazing down at the once vibrant, muscular body of this deceased soldier. Someone this beautiful was worth preserving, surely.

He leaned down, rested the rune-marked sceptre against some apparently disappointing armor, took the head in both his hands and breathed life into the man. ...and continued walking. At about a hundred paces, he realized that he may have done this very thing before and the more he thought about it, the more he was sure he had.

Tyzmon stopped walking, turned around, lifted a hand to shade his eyes from the Sun and ... saw nothing, no movement whatsoever. He shook his head, looked again, saw nothing. But he was sure. Well, he was pretty sure. OK, *maybe* 50-50, but it was enough to drive him in the opposite direction for another two hundred paces or so, passing would-be resting places along the way. Then he noticed movement.

"Helloa!" Tyzmon called. "Hello, what brings you to this valley?" He was still using a loud volume because the people he could see were not reacting as though they'd heard him. There were at least four soldiers in various stages of dress, but possibly more. "Come here, men!" He tried to sound official and soon enough, they were walking toward him.

Tyzmon waved his arms, "Gather your things and come here at once!"
Continue giving orders? Why not?

There were more than four. Within the hour, there were thirteen soldiers in their late teens and early twenties gathered around him. They were mostly silent, they did not address him directly. Tyzmon decided to try the direct approach:

"Does anyone know what happened here?"

None of them seemed to react to Tyzmon directly, but they looked at each other and then, as though an unspoken vote had been taken, one of the soldiers turned and stepped forward.

"There were hideous monsters, there were orcs." He gestured grandly with his arms. "It ... it rained gigantic stones and ..."

Another soldier took a step, placed a hand on the first soldier's shoulder, and took another half-step:

"Those were dragons and giants, they were giant orcs, I saw one, taller than the tallest trees! And they threw rocks the size of houses. I could only run, run and hear the screams. The burning of men, the crushing of bodies beneath stone and giant-boot." While he was talking five more men joined them.

The first soldier waited for his companion to finish then continued:

"I am the highest-ranking of us gathered here. Are we the only survivors?"

Tyzmon decided it would be impolite to laugh. "You did not survive." He held up his staff, the markings glowed softly. The ground began to tremble. He lowered the staff and the ground quieted. The accumulated men began dropping to one knee. "I did revive you, but I do not require anything from you."

As Tyzmon spoke to this group, another group of soldiers approached, there were easily another dozen in their ranks. He watched them as they assembled their motley selves among the original group. One of their number, his rags more clothing than the rest, came forward and began to speak:

"Master, why did you leave us?"

"I am no one's master. I barely remember any of you. Did you see any survivors?"

"There could be no survivors, anyone who did survive should have fled among the trees and then only to be eaten or burned to ash by dragons."

Tyzmon felt a strong affinity for the valley, this particular valley, but couldn't say why. "Did any of you have any luck against the giants or their pets?" No one reacted, some of the newcomers bent to one knee as the first group had done. "Were there any giant corpses?"

"You want to restore a giant, you want to bring a dead giant back to life?" The soldier who first spoke was speaking again and sounding more and more normal with every word. "Why in the fuck would you want to do that? If a giant fell, it would be a hard-won death, there are some trees that should stay down, some things should never come back down from

their shelves!"

"We could tie it up or something, couldn't we? We could really use some answers, wouldn't you agree?" Tyzmon suddenly had a thought, "unless one of you knows what brought them here." None of the soldiers said a word, the remaining soldiers bent a knee and all 60 eyes were on Tyzmon. Tyz decided something, "if you'd like to follow me, I can use the company, I cannot guarantee your safety, then again, you were already dead when I found you. If you don't follow me, I don't suggest staying here. This place is depressing. Bodies everywhere."

Some of the soldiers began looking at each other with quizzical glances. None of them seemed ready to abandon Tyzmon. "Something has brought me to this valley, my hexed staff shows me visions only of a demon who wishes to be called *Truth* he speaks of a man named *Ralph the Unlucky*, and another man who looks like me." Tyzmon paused, took a breath, looked at the various faces gathered around him. "Please do not stand in that posture: I am not your leader, I am a fellow traveler." They still didn't move. "Has any of you heard the name 'Ralph' or seen another who resembles me, perhaps younger?" Nothing.

Tyzmon sighed. "Fine, I'll hope my answers are within this valley. Tell me if any of you needs anything. I certainly have time."

"The men need water and we haven't eaten since half a day before the hail of stones and fire that wiped out the army." It was a new voice, from the second group.

"OK. I'll wait here, there is a small stream in that direction," he gestured, "...and certainly some of you have hunting skills? ...or can recognize edible plants, fruits, roots, something?" Most of the soldiers started gathering into a stream themselves and began walking in the direction indicated. When there were five, even they turned and followed the

caravan of thirsty soldiers. After a minute, before these motley men were out of view, Tyzmon, possibly lonely, followed as well.

When he rejoined them, some of the men were making camp at a clearing near a bend in the stream, others were collecting wood, all seemed busy. A large tree had fallen long ago and two or three soldiers were using it in various ways, Tyzmon sat on the ground with his back to it. He appeared to be sleeping. The soldiers continued their work.

When Tyzmon opened his eyes, it was early evening. There were trays and silverware, clinking of dishes, the soldiers appeared to be beginning a meal. Within reach, Tyzmon found a tray with dishes, food and water. He smiled, "thank you," he said, looking at the nearby soldiers, and lifted the tray onto his lap. Tyz carefully pushed any meat off his plate and onto the tray and allowed it to fall to the ground. He ate – *or pretended to eat* – what was left and drank the water.

Some of the soldiers had begun chatting amongst themselves and Tyzmon, for his part, seemed content to sit in silence. He didn't remember the last time he was in this valley or any of the times before that, either, for that matter; but he had a certain sense of doom. Something happened here. Something happened *to him* here. He tried to concentrate. He couldn't concentrate.

One of the soldiers approached him and took his tray, refilled his water. They nodded to each other. A few minutes later the man returned with some berries, "best we can do, for dessert, if you want," Tyzmon imagined the words rolling out of his mouth. He accepted the berries, tried to smile, nodded instead. The soldier sat near him. "Leaving soon?"

"Am I?" Tyzmon realized he didn't have a plan. But he was anxious about sitting still in the twilight, something, some thought or memory was

coming through. "Dragons!" He barked. Then, more calm, "there were dragons."

"Yes. Large dragons. I never believed in dragons. I guess I didn't believe in giants, either. Helvede, no reason *to* believe. There weren't dragons; there weren't giants. There weren't orcs or fairies, or flying horses or unicorns or any of that."

"Have you seen any orcs or fairies, flying horses or unicorns?"

"Orcs. I mean. Maybe orcs; I don't know, man. But before coming into this valley, there was no reason to believe in dragons, giants or anything of the kind. Dragons shouldn't be able to fly, they're too big." The soldier may have been something else, besides a soldier.

"You've seen dragons?" Tyzmon, himself, wasn't sure it was a question.

"Yes, I saw the dragons. They followed behind the giants. I was lucky, I wasn't immediately killed by falling rocks, but I did see the dragons. I remember. I remember seeing dragons and that's all I remember. I remember the thunder as the rocks fell, the crashing noise, the rumble as the giants marched, or danced, or ran, whatever you want to call that ... that movement, across the plains, coming down out of the hills in the south." The soldier stopped abruptly, ate a berry, continued: "Something wrong with this valley."

"I'm afraid if you leave here, you'll find *something's wrong with this planet*; I've been on the other side of these mountains, those large monsters you are calling giants and their smaller cousins, I think people call them 'orcs' have taken up residence there as well." He paused, chewed a berry, "...sorry ... for the bad news."

The soldier watched Tyzmon for a moment, ate his last few berries, said, "shall we make camp, or ... ?"

"I think we should move. For some reason I do not feel safe sitting still in the evening. I'm looking for ..." – *He couldn't remember, felt nausea, swallowed, head spinning ...* – "I'm looking for my friend and my brother." Saying it out loud solidified the thought and the memory pounced upon him like a cougar and he wept. In his mind, he saw Icon crushed beneath the boulder, he saw himself running, grasping Radulf and taking cover in the trees. He felt a wind-storm, felt himself lifted, wettened, warm, soft, then the burning of acid ...

He jumped up suddenly—no longer sick to his stomach—full of resolve. He screamed:

"I was eaten by a dragon!"

Tyzmon motioned the men closest and instructed them to find the others and if they were going with him, he was heading out soon. "This damned place. It's just not safe."

I think I'm looking for a campfire, Tyzmon may have thought he was speaking. "About a third the length from south to north of this valley, and about in the middle, East to west, there may be the remains of a camp, charred remains of a fire, possibly there is a boulder there. If I'm lucky, we'll find the bones of my brother there." He stopped talking, thought a moment, regained his train of thought, "we should also be looking for a soldier named, I think, Ralph; he has light brown, almost yellow eyes, a scar on his neck, no, no scar, anyway, his name is Ralph..."

To: Colonel Warren

Apparently, scouts had been deployed into the valley, up and down the stream on both sides, even up into the foothills. These scouts began returning to the ad hoc camp site as Tyzmon and the nearby soldiers were collecting themselves, their comrades at a river-stone-covered,

slight bend in the stream.

There was distant chatter as the scouts' news became known. One of the soldiers approached Tyz:

"Scouts have returned. There are others. Hundreds of them—not survivors—soldiers, like us. Your ... eh? ... people." He seemed to stumble over the last part. Tyzmon said nothing. "They're coming. They'll be here soon. ... to join you, to join us."

How long have I been wandering? Tyzmon looked at the soldier who became confused and began to fidget, Tyz realized he hadn't spoken aloud. "How many? Hundreds?"

"Several companies of men, whole platoons, entire squadrons. There are several brigades, at least a division." The soldier was suddenly animated with his excitement, a smile on his face, "How long have you been here, walking among us, taking us down from the shelves, mending our boxes, unspooling us ... !?" He leaned in and grabbed Tyzmon with both arms, holding him, hugging him, lifting him off his feet.

These additional men were joining Tyzmon's original troop as the excitement overwhelmed the soldier in a burst of physical man-handling. It was like a small city had joined a large house party.

Tyzmon, reluctant to disengage himself from the obvious appreciation of a fellow being, still felt uneasy about being stationary. He considered the advantages and disadvantages which were now making uncomfortable clumps in his mind:

Safety in numbers, versus a huge group being a larger target, drawing much more attention. Anyway, it was out of his hands, he'd apparently been reviving soldiers for days, weeks, even.

Had he been looking for Ralph, for his brother all this time? And why couldn't he remember? Is the memory problem chronic or acquired ... or, now acquired, something permanent?

He was dislodged from these and similar trains of thought by an obviously high-ranking officer addressing him:

"You, sir!"

"Aye, Tyzmon, my name. What is your name?"

"Warren, but call me Colonel. It has come to my attention that I am the highest ranking officer in this ... this *Army of the Undead* ... of yours (?)"
– *To Tyzmon, this sounded like a question.* – "These men are my responsibility, but, as I've been informed, we have no protocol for ... for returning to military service after death. The men seem to nominate you their leader." The colonel paused as though unsure of something, then, "I offer my services as liaison, if you wish it, Sir."

"Whatever you like, Warren." Tyzmon didn't have any agenda with the men and was, in point of fact, weary of traveling in such a large group. "Look, man, I'm just looking for my brother, and perhaps for another soldier named Ralph, at least I think his name is Ralph. This man is taller than me and quite young, I think he looks not a day over 17. He even still has the youth in his eyes." Tyzmon stopped, the colonel was waiting patiently, he seemed glued to Tyzmon's every word, "look," continued Tyz, "I do not believe it is safe to stay in one place and I am not exactly sure where to look, just vaguely ... in the middle of this valley."

The colonel straightened up, apparently interpreting something Tyzmon had said as an order. "As you wish Sir, right away."

Tyzmon resisted the urge to salute the officer. "Warren, I think we also

have to find out where these creatures have come from, I don't know about you, but these *orcs*, *dragons* and *giant orcs* are not creatures from the Earth as I picture it in my mind.” He decided to restate an earlier request, “if we could find an orc's body, or possibly even the corpse of a giant, I think we could ...” He gestured, he thought, feebly.

“I understand, Sir. We can interrogate a prisoner. Certainly there are enough of us now that we can handle *one* giant. Perhaps we can hope to find one who died of natural causes or accident...” His voice grew thoughtful.

Tyzmon gave a questioning look, “accident, Warren?”

“Certainly we were too busy screaming and running to attack them ourselves.” The colonel actually winked at Tyzmon. Both men laughed and suddenly the tension that Tyz hadn't realized was there was released and laughter filled the air as this contagious emotion overtook the most swarthy, serious soldiers and had already been picking at the less stalwart ones. “I'll personally see to it that you have a prisoner ... or at least a body ... to interrogate.”

With that, Colonel Warren saluted Tyzmon, turned on a heel and disappeared into the group of men.

In under 10 minutes, two men separated from the crowd and joined Tyzmon. They were both captains, they requested orders. Tyzmon discussed the advantages and disadvantages of staying put, moving, where to move, fatigue ... logistics, basically. At the end of this brief discussion, it was agreed to move to higher ground, search parties deployed at regular intervals, continued aggressive scouting into the valley and over the mountains. A patrol of a dozen men would accompany Tyzmon into the heart of the valley to find his people and to revive any more soldiers as they encountered them. *As well, another*

implication, any further bodies found would be brought to Tyzmon for "examination".

The entire corps was already moving into a position skirting the mountains before this conversation was at a close and Tyzmon found himself in a cluster of men all moving solemnly, though steadily, up the side of the nearest range.

Tre: The Dragonfeather

Most of the night was spent in maneuvers and the soldiers, of course, were very efficient. Tyzmon concluded that they died en masse as a result of ... well...

Who expects giants and dragons?

He'd apparently been assigned his 'patrol' already: a dozen hearty souls who—it seemed—couldn't decide if he was fragile, priceless cargo or their supreme commander. The thirteen of them and an advance-guard of another hundred soldiers hurried along the mountainside and, before the night itself was very old, made a kind of temporary camp where a couple of them slept and the rest busied themselves doing soldiery things.

Tyzmon may have slept, but he did not feel ill or, for that matter, even tired.

Tyzmon replayed many of the days events in his mind. He'd apparently been walking for days and days, weeks? Months? ...And reviving soldiers as he found them; hundreds and hundreds of soldiers. He scarcely stepped over a body he didn't stop and revive, or so it would seem. The soldiers were all very loyal to him but still to their chain of command, perhaps also his doing: by not challenging the hierarchy, he enforced the hierarchy. Were there more, were there soldiers stumbling around even

now who haven't joined these ranks ... Colonel Warren and one of Tyz's own captains had reassured him that they'd scour the valley looking for their revived comrades, and for the unrevived ones, too, or at least that's how they made it sound.

Then he started thinking about the scraps of memory, the ... the soldier, the trees, the fire, the boulder smashing him, himself, his brother; the mad dash for the trees—for the foothills. And finally, he remembered that he'd just told the soldier, apparently his friend, that there was nothing to worry about...

"Don't worry, man."

... these words, his words, echoed in his mind. But then, the memory ends and presumably that's when the dragon struck, vague feelings of a vortex of air and being lifted into it, sucked and massaged with a warm, milky substance which he knew in his heart was some kind of caustic dragon saliva.

Tyzmon couldn't remember what happened, if he actively removed himself from the dragon's gut or if he were ... if he were ...

Tyzmon shook his head and made a disgusted sound in his throat. It was around this time that he realized that his boots weren't fitting correctly, or anyway, the left one felt tighter than the right one. He rubbed his shins, felt the sleek, shiny scaly material from which his boots were made. He pulled his left foot out of his boot and immediately felt much better so he did the same with his right foot.

Something slipped past his forearm as he was removing the second boot and he picked it up from the ground. Whatever it was, it was hard and sharp and shaped something like a dagger; it was about the size of his hand from wrist to fingertips.

He couldn't see it, but imagined it looked something like this—



It was light and sharp and didn't bend when he pressed against it. It also did not smell pleasant. Tyzmon whistled quietly and a soldier came to his side.

"Please wash this and bring me someone who knows something about blades." *My brother knows about blades.* The thought occurred unbeckoned and he immediately said it aloud, "My brother knows about blades." But the soldier was already turning away, apparently didn't hear him and disappeared into the darkness, Tyzmon listened to his footfalls in the night.

Tyzmon stretched his legs, straightened his feet, curled his toes. He did this again and again with both feet, both legs. He was sore, but it was receding. He began stretching the rest of his body, his hands and wrists, arms; then turning at the waist and stretching his abdomen upward. Then his shoulders, pushing them back, relaxing.

Leaning upon the staff, he was able to stretch and balance and flex ... He was nodding his head, turning it, stretching his neck when he heard someone clear their throat behind him.

Tyzmon turned, suddenly embarrassed, barefoot in the grass.

"Your bladesmith and metallurgist, sir, Professor Mørkeblå; and your ..."
He paused, "your blade, sir." The soldier from before handed Tyzmon the object and the other, slightly taller man, bowed, saluted in a kind of double-gesture. The soldier's footfalls could be heard in the darkness as he disappeared about his duties.

"You are not an enlisted man, Professor?"

"I had been, but I was retained as a consultant by the Brigade of Five Stars before a training mission into this valley. I don't think anyone expected giants or dragons, Sir."

Tyzmon let this new information simmer in his mind, "I'll call you *Mark*."

"As you wish, Sir, but my first name is Sasha..." *An awkward pause as Tyzmon thought about "five stars" and "consultants" and "training missions".*

Tyzmon broke the silence, "As you wish, I shall call you Sasha. ... About this object, this blade, have you ever seen anything like it before?"

"I do not believe that is a blade at all, it appears to be a scale from an animal, sir." The professor shifted his balance, leaned forward, took the object and held it where it was caught in the reflected light of the Moon. "The green and the pattern make me think of a lizard. But the size and the strength," he took it in both hands and appeared to be attempting to twist it or fold it, "make me think it can be one thing and one thing only."

Tyzmon saw where the man was going, "You think it comes off a dragon, professor?" The other man was silent, possibly nodding thoughtfully in the darkness, then Tyzmon continued, "I took it out of my boot; I don't

know how it got there.”

Professor Mørkeblå handed the thing back to Tyzmon, “This is a scale, Sir, I believe it is a dragon scale. If it's like the kind of scales you'd find on fish, I'd say it came from the side or dorsal section; however, I've never been close to a dragon before. Until this 'exercise' I don't think anyone believed they existed.”

Tyzmon and the weapon expert took turns examining the dragon scale, handing it back and forth, holding it up to the Moon, rubbing the convex side, rubbing the concave side, &c. Finally, Tyzmon asked, “do you think you can make it into a kind of knife?”

“Of course, Sir, right away, Sir,” and he took the dragon scale and disappeared into the darkness.

Tyzmon sat down in a tuft of grass with a thump. He was suddenly tired. He reached for his boots, shook them upside-down over the ground and put them down. He lay back, thinking of sleep ... and then it was morning.

Tyzmon opened his eyes with a start; he'd been dreaming. He was inside a tight sack, there was no air, he couldn't move his arms, there was a putrid odor and a hot gel was burning against his exposed skin. ... He could smell roses and oranges. ...

The first thing he saw were his boots, almost touching his face, he turned, sat up and began putting them on. There was a pocket on the inside of the left boot, but the edge of the seam on the back was tore. “Gotta get that fixed,” he said quietly, as if to the boot itself.

As he put on his second boot, he noticed a tray on a small folding table, there was whole fruit, some peas and something that resembled a pancake, though thinner.

He decided to eat this time, as an experiment.

He pulled the short table over and began munching on the breakfast that had been left for him. The crepes were still quite warm and he enjoyed the aromas and the flavors. "I should eat more often."

"Pardon me, sir?" It was another man, he wasn't dressed as the other soldiers were dressed, he carried a kind of knife with a long handle.

Tyzmon finally recognized his blade-expert from the night before, "Sasha, good morning!"

"And to you, Sir. Here is your weapon." Sasha handed the knife to him by turning the blade in his hand and presenting the handle, a gesture he'd obviously performed several times.

"I had been enjoying my food, Professor, when you arrived, I was complimenting the food itself, I'm afraid I may not be used to the company of others." Tyzmon appeared to have no idea he was rambling.

"Of course, Sir, as you like," Sasha waited as Tyzmon examined the weapon. "It meets your needs, your approval, Sir?"

"Of course, of course. I'm not sure I expected it so soon."

Sasha bowed his head as if in apology, then leaned to sit down with Tyzmon, "you see, sir," he sat, "most of us can't sleep since, you know, the giants and the dragons and their ugly little friends. So it kept me busy."

"Happy to help?" Tyzmon laughed.

Sasha laughed, "Thank you, Sir. I needed that, Sir." Sasha laughed a little more, an embarrassed giggle.

"Can you please stop calling me 'Sir', it sounds so formal and I'm not in

your army, so I hold no rank at all." Tyzmon's attempts at breaking the tension had ended with his laughter.

"I think we'll call you whatever you tell us to call you, Sir." Sasha mirrored Tyzmon's smile, they both laughed.

"No one has told me what my first name is, but I have been called *Tyzmon* by those who've known me since I was a small boy."

"Tyzmon, Sir? Yes, quite correct, you look like a Tyzmon." They laughed again.

Tyzmon, still laughing, and examining the knife, said, "come back at noon I'll have a present for you, a thank you for this," he held up the knife like a nod of the head.

"Oh, I forgot," Sasha pulled a folded velvet sheath from under his tunic, behind his belt. "This is the type of holster a knife of that style requires." He said it so matter-of-fact, Tyzmon didn't know if he meant because it was protocol or some kind of compliment to the knife itself. He took the sheath, turned it in his hand, inserted the blade of the knife, removed it, turned the knife and inserted it again.

"Yes," Sasha was saying, "the dragon scale is bowed slightly, and there doesn't seem to be anything we can do about that. It resists bending, and my assistant almost ruined a grinding wheel on –" *Tyzmon cut him off.*

"You attempted to sharpen it?!"

"Well, Mors did, yes. He didn't ask, it's a perfectly normal thing for him to do. But anyway, Sir, not a scratch."

"I wasn't; I didn't say that because I was worried, I said it because last

night you made it seem like ..." Tyzmon didn't finish the thought.

"Well, now we know for sure, don't we?" He paused, then, "Mors knows best, better than the two of us anyway, he sliced his hand right and deep, that guy. Bandaged and being looked after by a lady nurse in the infirmary." He nodded vaguely toward the back of the camp. "They were asking about you, in fact, Tyzmon."

"The hospital people?" Tyzmon was surprised. "Why?"

"Well," the man was suddenly uncomfortable, then that giggle again, he spread his hands, "you see, Sir, there is a pile of bodies and ..."

"Oh, right. Of course." Tyzmon suddenly remembered agreeing to ... eh ... help ... with the bodies. "Well, I'd better go do that then, huh?"

"I'll go with you, Sir, I have to check on Mors anyway." The two men stood up, Tyzmon with more help from his staff than either man seemed to expect. "You alright, Sir?"

"I'm upright, so it's fine now, I suppose. Getting old, ain't it?" They both laughed. They walked away together, Tyzmon caressing the knife in its sheath.

While they walked, Tyzmon inquired about boot repair and a few other random things. He'd been meaning to ask about their conversation from the night before, *the brigade of the five stars*, this valley, the training mission, all of it, any of it, whatever he could get. He felt thirsty for information.

After they had departed, one of the nearby soldiers gathered up the tray, dishes and folded up the small table, leaning it against a tree. Then he, too, disappeared among the soldiers in the camp.

Fire: The infirmary

A massive, enclosed and camouflaged tent had actually been erected and within it was the infirmary. But mostly it was an empty room. Tyzmon found himself wondering where these dead soldiers got their gear.

"When I found you, probably you had little more than the clothes on your back," began Tyzmon. "Where do the trays, tables, tents, dishes ... all this ..." He gestured, "where does all this stuff come from?" He arced his hands, making a sweeping gesture involving both arms.

Sasha seemed surprised, "Sir? This is really the same equipment we had when we started the training mission, killing and crushing the men and their bodies didn't cause the gear to disintegrate." He seemed embarrassed, "begging your pardon, Sir."

"Oh," Tyzmon shook his head, "no, my mistake. You understand; at best I saw individuals, dead men, dead people, some crushed beneath large stones ..." He let it go.

There were three others in the mostly empty tent with Tyzmon and Sasha. They were in shadows along a wall of the infirmary. Sasha decided to make introductions, "Mors, sitting up, I see." He turned to a woman, "Uta, this is our ... our *revivalist* (?) ... Tyzmon; Tyzmon, Uta."

"Uta Emmet," she said, taking Tyzmon's outstretched hand into her own, bowing and then kneeling onto one knee, kissing the back of his hand softly, "it is the greatest pleasure."

Tyzmon flinched slightly, as though he'd taken a static shock. He recovered quickly, "I hadn't noticed any females ..." Or ... maybe he didn't recover quickly.

One knee still on the ground, Uta said, "there aren't hella ladies join the

marines, Sir.” Thoughtful a moment:

“Min livmoder bliver frastødt af mænds krige.”

Smiling, she stood, continued, “I only know one other woman down here, she works in *Supplies and IT.*” Tyzmon was staring at her and she took this as wanting to hear more. “Her name is Liza,” she turned to Sasha, “you can escort him?”

Tyzmon finally recovered. “Oh. I’m ... sorry, terribly sorry, no, I ...” He stopped talking, collected himself, “I will meet your friend if you decide to introduce us or if I need supplies or IT.” He looked at the man he hadn’t yet met, “your name, Sir?”

“I’m Bob.”

“Just Bob, Sir?”

Sasha and Uta looked at each other, Mors and *Bob* were looking at Tyzmon as though he were going to explode. Sasha said, “Doctor Robert Paul Mann,” he gestured, “I’d like you to meet Tyzmon, he ... um ... brought us all ... erm ... down.”

The situation was awkward. Tyzmon suddenly realized it too and began to laugh (worked the last time). “Don’t worry, I don’t want anything from you! Let’s see what I can do here,” he took Mors’s hand which was bandaged so much it looked like he was holding a cannonball.

Tyzmon squeezed the man’s wrist and turned his own other hand to touch the bandages with his Tyzlane Staff which hummed. The runes there flashed a brilliant jade and then everything was silent. Tyzmon and Mors began the unwrapping. Tyzmon let Mors finish when it was clear that little more than his hand was still wrapped.

Bob said, "Extraordinary." He was leaning in quite close. "Extraordinary," Bob said again.

Tyzmon laughed slightly then, deepening his voice, "I heard something about bodies?"

"Oh! Oh, yes." Uta and Bob said together, everyone went to the back of the tent. Uta leaned down and lifted the edge of the tent and they all went under, to the outside.

There was a pile of bodies behind the tent, and another man was standing there as well. He was not dressed as either a soldier or a medical practitioner. He appeared to be dressed head-to-toe in black and was wearing, as if this wasn't enough, a black canvas robe with a thick black canvas belt.

Uta seemed surprised, "Who are you!" More an accusation than a question. She turned to Bob and Mors, "Who is this man?!"

The man in black turned, slipped slightly, and took off up the hill. Tyzmon whistled, gestured.

Three men, then seven, then sixteen soldiers dashed up and after the robed man. Tyzmon turned to examine the bodies.

The sight was the gruesome mid-point between a kind of comic freeze-frame of a slumber party gone wild and a mass grave turned upside-down. Two of the bodies, however, were separated from the rest.

"These two," Tyzmon pointed, "who are they?"

Bob said, "One is a field marshal the other ..."

"The other is my father, Clarke, he is ... was a captain." Uta said.

"I'll revive them first. Uta, Bob, arrange to bring the bodies to me one by

one.” Tyzmon was already kneeling over the body of Uta's father. The man started breathing, began to sit up and Tyzmon pressed a hand to his chest, “relax a few minutes, I have work for you.” Tyz turned to the other body, the same thing again, “relax for a while, my good man.”

Uta was crying silent tears and a smile which threatened to tear through her cheeks was likely as not plastered on her face permanently. She squeaked a little with joy.

Tyzmon instructed the two previously dead men to aid Bob and Uta, then allowed himself to be led to the side by Sasha and Mors who had brought a stool for him to sit on. Tyzmon gave the Tyzlane staff to Mors to hold momentarily, “if I seem ill, hand this back to me.”

Uta and Bob and their two new recruits brought the first body. Tyzmon indicated they should leave the body and get another. He leaned down, balanced himself, elbows on knees, touched the soldier who began to draw breath. A few seconds later, the man sat up and Mors guided him away.

This happened another two dozen times after which the five of them, that is, the seven of them took a short break for lunch. The revived soldiers had been led away to a briefing room where they would be attended to and instructed. Mors and Sasha said they had to get back to the armory. Tyzmon nodded and said they could go after lunch, not that he would have stopped them anyway.

Tyzmon ate what was given to him, meat and all. The seven of them talked about little things, the clear sky, the pleasant weather, the men and their morale; and then lunch was over and it was time to get back to work. The two weapons specialists waved as they returned to their work.

Fifty bodies, there had been fifty bodies and they had already revived 27.

In a very short amount of time the last body was also revived and Tyzmon stood up, feeling happy, absorbing happiness from his seven, that is, *five now, coworkers*.

Fem: The foreign assassin

Uta took the stool, lifted the edge of the tent's canvas and put the stool under and inside the tent. Tyzmon was about to say he needed a break, really he just wanted to sit and be proud of himself; sit, take in the air, watch the birds and smile the smile of a beatific angel.

He didn't get a chance to say anything, there was some noise up the hill and his companions rushed in that direction, the man in black was being ... brought back, half led, half dragged, mostly, carried.

The accompanying soldiers, now including Uta, Mors, Sasha, Bob, and the first two soldiers Tyzmon had revived today, brought their prisoner to Tyzmon who didn't think this was unusual at all.

"Now who the fuck are you?" Tyzmon attempted to project an air of authority and anger but felt neither. In his mind, he was an actor on a stage doing an impression of Uta earlier, before the man ran away.

"Ihr werdet hier nicht lebend rauskommen!" The prisoner spat.

"OK, good start; good start," said Tyzmon. "What are you doing here?"

"Ich werde Dir nicht antworten."

"Isn't that interesting?" Tyzmon turned to the nearest soldier, "isn't that interesting?" The other man nodded for want of a correct response.

"Why did you run?"

"Ihr werdet alle hier sterben," the prisoner hissed.

"I won't." Tyzmon laughed. The other soldiers laughed after a beat.

"But I think I can just beat the crap out of you a bit ..."

"Ich bin niemand. Lasst mich gehen!"

"Don't release him." Tyzmon looked at the men who were holding the black-clad man, they all nodded. "Bind his wrists, separate his hands, tie his ankles together." They nodded assent. "You aren't going to like this, my friend, you aren't going to like this one bit."

"Ihr alle werdet hier sterben."

"You said that before," offered Tyzmon.

"Lass mich frei!" Said the prisoner. "Lasst mich frei!"

"Make sure those bindings are good and tight, will you?" He was addressing Bob who began pulling and poking at the knots, the doctor nodded.

"I suggest you answer my questions, I honestly do not know if I'm a compassionate man." Tyzmon said as though offering candy to a child.

"Du wirst von mir keine Antwort bekommen."

Tyzmon lifted the Tyzlane staff above the prisoner's head. "I suggest you tell me your name," he said.

"Ich bin unbedeutend. Lass mich frei!"

Tyzmon relaxed his grip on the staff which shifted against his fingers, making an echoing smack against the prisoner's head.

"Ihr werdet hier nicht lebend rauskommen." The prisoner said, a touch softer than before.

Tyzmon smiled a somewhat malevolent smile, the smile of a bright child

with an idea for how to get revenge on a small animal. "What is your name?" He said it with dramatic pauses between the words.

"Ich werde Dir nicht antworten." He said this, but sharply inhaled at the end, as though expecting a splash of cold water.

"Why are you here?" As he asked the question, Tyzmon slowly handed his staff to Uta who was beginning to think perhaps she didn't want to see any more. But at the same time, what would Tyzmon do, what *could* he do?

"Lasst mich frei!"

"I wonder if I *can* release you," said Tyzmon as he rose to his feet—*he'd been squatting slightly*. Tyzmon took the remaining half-step toward the man and punched suddenly out at him, into his chest. There was a loud pop and a tearing then gurgling noise. Blood flew everywhere. The prisoner jerked against his arms, the bindings, he would surely have fallen, if the soldiers were not holding him up.

Tyzmon brought his hand back and in it was the prisoner's heart, Tyz squeezed it and crushed it in his hand. Tyzmon dropped what remained of the man's heart. The prisoner's eyes were open wide, blood everywhere, blood coming out of his chest, his mouth, his nose, he made shallow breaths and gurgling noises.

Tyzmon placed the middle finger of his left hand on the man's head and the wound closed, the man took a sudden gasp of air.

"Ich schulde Dir keine Antwort." He seemed stronger than ever. Tyzmon did not seem surprised, but Uta almost fainted, probably not the only one. By this time, more soldiers had gathered around.

Tyzmon gave the Dragonfeather to Bob and told him to remove the man's

feet and hands and to bring them inside the tent. He went around the tent and inside where he sat on the floor. But then he had second thoughts, stood up and yelled as he exited the tent, "No, Bob, no!"

Bob wasn't even sure he could do as instructed, so being told not to was a relief. "Thank you, Sir," said Bob, the green-bladed knife almost falling out of his hand back into Tyzmon's.

"You know what, bring me a large mixing bowl, you can get me one of those, right?" Bob, horror-struck, nodded, went pale, ran away but felt like he was swimming against a current.

Tyzmon returned his attention to the prisoner. "I suppose I haven't quite decided how evil I am. But I am sure it is unwise to force others to commit my atrocities for me." In three sudden movements, Tyzmon took up his staff, swung it and swung it again, battering the prisoner's head twice. "So there's this rumor that you're not talking."

"Ihr werdet hier nicht lebend rauskommen."

Tyzmon was not impressed. "Do you want to know what I'm going to do with the mixing bowl?"

The prisoner remained silent.

"You want to guess?" Tyzmon was holding the Dragonfeather, changed position, put the blade into his mouth, held it with his teeth, long handle awkwardly tilting, bobbing.

The prisoner was silent, trying to turn away. Tyzmon smiled around the knife-blade, reached out and struck the prisoner like a child, "he doesn't want to talk."

Some of the soldiers were mumbling, possibly agreeing, possibly trying to decide when to stop Tyzmon; but then, he'd already killed the man, and

he'd revived all of them. Who were they to contradict him on issues of morality?

Tyzmon repeated, "he doesn't want to talk." He reached behind the man, pulled his head back by his hair and, using his other hand, took The Dragonfeather from his mouth and quickly, smoothly, removed the man's tongue, then his ears, then his lips.

There was blood everywhere, again. The prisoner was choking, his own blood spitting and splashing from his mouth.

"You know I can do this ..." he shrugged, "all day ... don't you?" The prisoner stared straight ahead, wide-eyed. Bob finally returned from the mess hall with a large metal bowl. Tyzmon placed body parts into the bowl, including the crushed heart from the ground. "See, if I touch him, he'll be back to normal, better than when you found him." Tyzmon paused dramatically, "you noticed that, did you not?"

It was true. The prisoner, when he first arrived, before Tyzmon killed him by ripping out his heart and crushing it and throwing it on the ground, was a man who had begun to gray. Now he was a younger man, maybe in his twenties.

The prisoner was moaning and spitting blood. Tyzmon, in another quick motion, almost faster than could be seen, punched him in the mouth with his staff, the man began spitting out and choking on his own teeth.

"Well, now it'd be pretty hard for you to talk anyway, I suppose. I wonder," began Tyzmon, "if you'll talk later." While he was speaking, he was holding the bowl in the corner of one arm while kneading the contents with his other hand, his staff held between arm and abdomen.

"Take him to the infirmary, keep him alive as best you can." He was giving these orders to one of the soldiers who had originally brought the

prisoner. "If he's hungry, feed him this." Tyzmon handed the soldier the bowl.

The soldier swooned, caught himself, dropped the bowl and, after taking three quick steps away from the others, began to vomit against a hedge.

Tyzmon turned to the prisoner. "You aren't looking so good." The other man's eyes opened wide as Tyzmon turned completely to him. Tyzmon reached out a hand, touched the man softly and, again, the prisoner's wounds healed. The sick soldier returned, wiping his mouth. One of the other soldiers led him away from Tyzmon, they watched from a distance of a few meters with another small group.

"I really don't have time for this shit," Tyzmon complained. "Are you going to talk, or am I going to have to do something I've never done before?"

"Ich bin niemand." The prisoner was gasping. "Ich bin unbedeutend! Lass mich frei!"

Tyzmon was at a loss. He was pretty sure if this had happened to him, *he* would have talked. Some people are very loyal, he decided. "Loyal to what, to whom?" Tyzmon said this, raising his voice to a shout. "We can't release him." Tyzmon was thinking out loud. "We can't keep torturing him, but we can't have him here, either."

Tyzmon turned to the soldiers who had chased the man in black up the hill, "did he have anything with him?"

"We took these away from him, Sir." It was something long, covered in black and shadows, some kind of folded and crushed velvet. Tyzmon took what was offered.

He unwrapped a long dark-blue or purple bladed weapon and a much

smaller silvery-steel knife. The first was the dark red of an Autumn leaf, the blade as long as Tyzmon's forearm, longer perhaps. The other was a small knife, a trace of dry blood on the edge. Tyzmon lifted the smaller knife and a memory stuttered, blinked in his mind, but like a small fish it was gone and then he wasn't even sure he saw anything at all, then even the memory of the spark was gone.

Tyzmon started to place the small knife into his boot, next to The Dragonfeather. Something hooked his mind, tugged gently, he rotated his wrist at the last moment, threw the smaller knife. One of the bystanders caught it. "Find out what that stuff is (?)" *A request or a question, I'm certain.*

The other weapon was far more interesting. Tyz lifted it from the satinesque nest—the underside of the crushed velvet wrapping—turned it in his hand, switched hands and threw the thing into the air, catching it as it spun and threw off dazzling sunlight with his other hand.

I'm pretty good at this. He continued throwing the short-sword into the air and ... and ... and well, dancing.

"I wonder if I can break this weapon," Tyzmon said to the prisoner.

"Ihr werdet hier nicht lebend rauskommen."

"Oh, I don't think so." Tyzmon really didn't want to damage the weapon, he placed the tip on the ground, lifted a booted foot and was about to stomp down on the blade when ...

"What do you want!" It was the prisoner, he was screaming.

"Seriously?" Laughed Tyzmon. "Fucking seriously?" Tyzmon put the

weapon back into the satin, folded the crushed velvet over it and asked the soldiers to put it with his things, literally, "put this with my things." — A soldier took it away, but Tyzmon had no *things*—he was carrying or wearing everything anyone knew he owned.

"I beat you, I kill you." He looked into the man's eyes. "I revive you. Unimpressed, you say nothing, remain willful, you threaten ..." He shook his head, "I mutilate you, cut off your ears, cut out your tongue, threaten to feed you your own body parts, but still *ikke noget*. And then, when I threaten this object *then* you're talking?" Tyzmon really was surprised. *Talk or the knife will be destroyed.*"

"Ich bin unbedeutend. Lass mich frei."

Tyzmon took a breath, sighed. "Tell me we aren't playing this game again." Tyzmon leaned over, bent at the waist and knee, almost in half. He was picking something up from the ground. Then he did it again. Tyzmon opened his hand, four teeth appeared. "Can you make a necklace from this?" He was addressing a soldier who nodded. Tyzmon turned his hand, the soldier reached out, took the teeth, dashed away.

Tyzmon watched the prisoner. He motioned the soldiers to relax, the prisoner was standing on his own feet, briefly, then he wobbled and soldiers helped him sit. Tyzmon sat.

Tyzmon stared at the man before him, tilted his head up slightly, "I'm told the thirst is pretty bad sometimes."

Seks: Good news climbs out of the valley

Tyzmon was getting comfortable, thinking he'd just wait the man out when there was commotion down the hill. The noises originated near where the hillside sloped less steeply becoming the valley floor. The guarding soldiers helped him up and resumed the watch on their prisoner.

Tyzmon, starting down—toward the disruption—was called back, distracted by the guards. “What should we do with him?” The guard indicated with his chin. Tyzmon was thinking they had found his brother, *I don't care, kill him, bury him.* “Sir?” The guard said.

Tyzmon, impatient, said, "Dig a hole, put him in it."

Tyzmon almost tripped over his foot turning back as he continued down the hill where a cadre of soldiers was anxiously discussing something with other soldiers. These had been a kind of guard for the camp. Tyzmon waded among them until he was recognized and they moved into a semi-circle.

Two of the soldiers coming up from the valley stepped forward. One nodded to the other who said, “we think we've found your brother. We have found a severely scorched boulder and some clothing near what may have been, long ago, a camp site, smaller stones in a circle where someone had built a large fire ...”

Tyzmon smiled, “take me there.”

His original guard, the two captains plus ten more men were joining the group. In moments this group of two-dozen men was heading down the slope and into the valley. While they walked at a somewhat rushed pace, it could still be thought of as gentle and Tyzmon leaned to one side, addressing one of his captains, “have you got the long dagger?”

“The prisoner's purple-bladed knife-thing? Yeah, it's —” he took his pack off and pulled the wrapped bundle from it, “— here.” The captain handed the bundle to Tyzmon who, removed the blade and returned the wrapping.

“Did anyone see any kind of ... I don't know ... holster or sling, for this

thing?" — *The captain shrugged, shook his head, said nothing further.* — Tyzmon was gingerly touching the flat sides and the sharp edges of the surreal blade, "what makes it this strange color, this webbed pattern," he asked.

"We haven't investigated, Sir; we were guarding you and returned to the armory for the weapon when you began your descent of the hill."

"Why?"

"I'm not entirely sure, Sir. I'm afraid, it just seemed like it's what you'd want us to do. It was on my orders, and, as you see, I had the weapon on my person." — *He seemed unsure if he'd done the wrong thing.*

"Well, if you want to carry it," Tyzmon handed the strange weapon back to the captain who re-wrapped it and placed it back into his pack.

It took the rest of the day and most of the evening to get to the location described at the foot of the hills by the soldiers' camp. No one seemed fatigued and perhaps they all had their reasons for this. Tyzmon's mind wandered to his dragon encounter, "by the way ... have you seen another soldier in this valley, someone named, I think, Ralph?"

"No, no Sir, and we've been looking." — *It was Tyzmon's other captain who was speaking.* — "It is a very strange name, Sir. None of us carries that name or anything similar. I'm sorry, Sir."

"Is it really?" It occurred to Tyzmon that he had no idea what was and what wasn't a common or uncommon name. "Perhaps I'm wrong about the man's name. And the other question, no one can answer it, I presume?"

"I'm sorry, Sir, before you revived us the other day, no one remembers you, no one recognized you from ... from before." — *This was the first*

captain again.

Possibly many months had passed after all...

Chapter V: Reunion

"Have your men surround this area," Tyzmon spoke in the direction of both captains, "also, have two or three of the strongest aid me here." – *He was pushing the boulder but may as well have been a squirrel.* – Four men came forward, the rest disappeared into the dark, along with their captains.

"Help me, I don't want to revive him with this stone on his body like this." As Tyzmon said it, he noticed the scorch marks on the stone had a kind of shimmer where he had touched them. Something tingled in his fingers, through his body.

"Wait!" His exclamation came as the men were arranging rough poles and sticks to make levers to help move the large stone. Everyone stopped moving. "Step back ... something else is going on here." Tyzmon's eyes followed the twinkling dust and suddenly he felt his breath knocked out of him and he fell, heavily, to the ground. Two of the soldiers shifted as if to come to his side, but he waved his arms from where he sat, "no, don't move!" He croaked, still winded.

And then it happened, the shimmering, the twinkling and shining dust began to take the shape of a man. He looked like a pencil drawing at first, a man with his arms up as if to protect his face which displayed a look of horror such that, with surprise, Tyzmon realized he'd never seen before. Not even earlier when he removed the heart from a living man in front of a dozen witnesses.

The man slumped and fell to the ground next to Tyzmon, he wasn't moving, but he was a complete body – even some of his clothing was intact. Tyzmon thought aloud, "maybe time is moving around him

differently, maybe I'm not reviving them at all." The body was dead, but it was real and it appeared whole.

Tyzmon, still on the ground, rolled toward the body. He got up on his hands and knees, leaned over the unmoving body; he suddenly recognized Radulf. "This man is Ralph!" He bellowed happily, "this man is Ralph!" And with a surprising force of will, Tyzmon, smiling and laughing was holding the body. He was a small child clutching a favorite toy in the night, and tears made streaks upon his cheeks. Suddenly, Radulf began to breathe and he opened his eyes. Tyzmon untangled himself, taking the other man's hand in his own, helping him to his feet.

"Ralph? What the hell happened here?"

The previously dead man was still breathing but did not speak. Tyzmon gestured to his small group of soldiers. The others had returned and were shining their hand lights on the scene, into Tyzmon's face, into Ralph's face. Ralph put up a hand to guard his eyes from the glare and resembled his spectral self, minus the look of horror. He stumbled a little, Tyzmon gave him the staff to lean on.

Tyzmon motioned the guards back to guard-duty and went to help the soldiers move the boulder off what was left of his brother's corpse. Ralph stood up, looked at his body, touched his own chest, took a deep breath. He gave the Tyzlane Staff back to Tyzmon. Apparently sure that he was whole, Radulf also helped move the boulder.

The rock was just too large. One of the captains returned from the darkness. He had a shovel out. He tossed it to one of his men who seemed to immediately know what to do. He began digging a hole next to the boulder, a kind of slope. Soon after, they were all pushing the boulder. Some of the guards had ignored orders and joined them. Using

sticks as levers and the brute force of so many men, the boulder shifted and immediately rolled about a third of a meter, then it was in the slope that had been dug and slid off Icon's body completely.

Tyzmon motioned for everyone to stand back and Radulf was already moving away. Tyzmon lifted the Tyzlane staff over his head and the noise of thunder shook the valley floor even before the earthquakes started. This time it did not rain, but lightning struck Tyzmon and the ground near Tyzmon and the bones and stones that had been a fire ring oh so long ago.

Tyzmon lowered the staff, knelt at his brother's side, lifted an eyelid with a thumb and then lifted the other one. Tyzmon resisted the urge to blow air over his brother's body. Icon's eyelids fluttered like butterfly wings in a breeze, he took a deep breath. Icon batted Tyzmon's hands away from his face, smiled broadly and embraced his brother.

One of Tyzmon's captains brought over a bundle, "they told me you may need clothes," he said, handing the bundle to Icon. Everyone laughed.

Them.

Chapter VI: A Loss In the Night

En: Colonel and Lieutenant

This is where the story kind of splits in two directions...

At this time, Colonel Warren and his squad of 3 dozen elite soldiers were making the slow crawl out of the valley to the north. The terrain was mountains and more mountains. Kanin Scott Lutèce, Warren's lieutenant carefully navigated the rough ground.

Kanin, wearing camouflage jacket and leggings over his lieutenant's red undershirt, exposed at cuffs and neck, approached the colonel. "The scouts have been instructed, Sir; the other group reports seeing a settlement to the north-east." He paused, then, "there have been no reports of giants or anything, really."

"Elskede Tyzmon was quite clear, *the monsters went north.*" He emphasized the last as if to say that Tyzmon made it so by speaking it.

"Yes, Sir, I know this Sir, of course, however, not a whiff, not a boot mark, nothing."

"Just make sure the camps are well camouflaged and as close to the sides of cliffs as possible. We can't take any chances. In the morning, we'll send two groups to investigate that settlement. Unless we find another source of water, we must continue following this stream." There really wasn't enough light to see by and the mountainous landscape made the night itself close in like a claustrophobic horror. "You're dismissed for tonight, get some rest, if we don't find a trace by noon tomorrow, we'll head north-west toward the other water."

Lt. Lutèce, crouching a bit, made his way back to his own open-air tent. The night was warm, balmy. Removing and rolling up his jacket, Kanin laid on his cot, put his hands behind his head, watched the twinkling of stars and other things up in the sky and drifted off.

I hope he had good dreams.

To: The rooster crows

The next morning, Colonel Warren was not woken by his lieutenant as would have been expected, but instead by a female from the Brigade of Five Stars, Gisela Gnaver, Kanin's deputy. She gave him the bad news:

"No, Sir, it's not that he's missing, he is dead, vaporized or something."

"What do you mean by 'vaporized'? If he's vaporized, how do you know Scott's dead?" Using the man's middle name was a sign of familiarity, but as he was missing, a kind of formality, a sign of respect.

"Sir, Scott's body, his clothes, everything ... is there, but it's disintegrated. Had he been an ice cube, he'd be water vapor now. It's really a terrible mess, I have a small crew cleaning as we speak."

"What the helvede happened? Was the camp infiltrated?" The colonel was at risk of losing his shit.

"Well, that's the good news, actually. Jensen says we can track the perpetrator. And more bad news, he says it's not human; the killer doesn't appear to be human."

"What is it if it isn't human?" The colonel was getting dressed as they spoke, she reached to help adjust his collar.

"Come with me, Jens is conducting a survey of the area. His team was

finished with the L.T.'s remains. They were using infrared when I came to wake you. That technology won't continue to be useful as the Sun rises." Deputy Gnaver turned and began walking the same harsh ground Lt. Lutèce did late last night.

Jensen did not look up from his work even though he heard Gisela and the colonel arriving. He was collecting what he hoped was a DNA sample. In his mind's eye, he saw one of the creatures they'd all been calling orcs and it was just conceivable that these creatures wore nothing on their feet. He swiped the half-dozen samples against the collector-matrix strapped to his wrist. The machine vibrated slightly between samples, made a low-volume ping a moment after the last sample. "If this is DNA, it is definitely not human." He was talking to deputy Gnaver but knew Colonel Warren could also hear.

Colonel Warren spoke. "Gisela was telling me five minutes ago that we already knew the attacker wasn't human (?)" – *This was either an accusation or a question.*

"Oh, of course, Sir." Jens stood up, "the energy signature was completely wrong, and the heat given off by the invader was substantial. Unless he was hit by lightning or some kind of self-propelled bomb ..." He stopped, briefly, as though searching for words, "Unless he was attacked by someone very quick and running an extreme fever, Lt. Lutèce was not killed by a human being." He stopped, looked at his wrist, continued, "Anyway, we would recognize the ... um ... effects of a human weapon."

The machine attached to his wrist made a louder tick then several chirps in succession. "It's bio-matter, that's for sure. But this is not human tissue."

"OK." Colonel Warren was addressing no one in particular, then, to Miss Gnaver, "get everybody, we're going to track this creature." She saluted

and was gone in an instant. To Jensen, “any indication of how fast it was moving, anything about its locomotion at all?”

“Well, Sir, it can't be moving very fast, and ...” He was indicating another soldier, another member of his team, “Oz brought forward the idea that the creature is *alone*, Sir.”

The man was pressing buttons on a machine as big as his own head, the machine had protruding handles. He was called Oz, but his name is Omar Zabaneh. Oz was dressed as a tech and talked like a tech and may as well have defined the term. He began to speak:

“I'm not sure why it went by these other men, these tents, including yours, Sir,” chin up to the colonel, “and mine, Sir. But there just wasn't enough matter...” – *The machine apparently distracted him.* – “...it looks like our friend came in, turned toward the L.T.'s bunk, stopped for a few minutes and ...” Omar swallowed, his words came out almost as a squeak, “...and then he did something, I think he fired an energy weapon.”

“That is confirmed from this end, Sir.” Jens was addressing the colonel, but turned to acknowledge Omar, “although, from the pattern of the...” – *he took a breath* – “...debris, Sir, if the lieutenant had been a water balloon, I would tell you someone suddenly popped it with a needle...(?)” – *He seemed unsure, but no one else there could possibly contradict him.*

Tre: The chase

While the colonel pondered these statements, deputy Gnaver returned with one of the scouting parties. The colonel turned and left the forensics team to their work. “We have to be fast. Even if it doesn't move very fast, it has a head start on us by a few hours.” The team leader started shouting orders and handing out small yellow devices that could be strapped to the upper arm. Everyone got two. They also had

smaller yellow devices already strapped to their ankles. The soldiers thus attired stood in a line and one by one were inspected by the leader who waved a thin brown plate in front of them, leaning low and, it appeared, exposing their feet as well.

The colonel addressed the search-team's leader, "stay with me Jeffers, when you've completed programming those scanners; we'll take up the rear."

These machines could be programmed to indicate north, or any direction, they could be set to indicate an energy signature or a substance in the air, they were now being primed to detect the creature that exploded Kanin like a child's assault weapon. Reset to default, these machines indicate north. The wearer is alerted by stimulation of skin in the appropriate direction. If you are walking north, it feels like something warm is rubbing where-ever the device is attached. If you are walking south, it also feels that way, but on the other side of your arm or ankle.

Almost immediately the search party broke in half and Colonel Warren and Jeffers also split up; fortunately, the group Jeffers followed made a tear-drop-shaped arc and returned to where they started. The machines were apparently trying to make them take another lap but they just followed after Colonel Warren. The colonel fell back and re-joined Jeffers.

"I know, and yes, it happens all the time," Jeffers answered an unasked question.

The group of soldiers followed the mountains, more or less, to the east. Jeffers and Colonel Warren discussed logistics and called back to last-night's camp to relay information, give orders. They were delaying, if not canceling, the trip down the mountains to the village; they needed as much information as they could get on these mountains.

"Jeffers," Colonel Warren said, "how close are we to the edge of the inclusion zone?"

"It's a little difficult to tell from the inside, Sir. But we're in the Archangel Mountains, so we can't be too far." Jeffers thought a moment, "less than two hundred clicks, certainly."

"But it could be two kilometers?"

"I suppose, Sir." Jeffers pondered, "do you think those creatures are outside the valley?"

"After deputy Gnaver gave me the bad news, I called back to Mountain Base One." He paused for no apparent reason.

"Yes, Sir?" Queried Jeffers.

"They are thinking that the creatures have been outside the valley. Now, as far as I know, none of the men vores elskede far hjerte revived has left the valley, so perhaps Tyzmon himself has seen these creatures outside the valley before we ... met him." Colonel Warren shrugged, "I suppose we'll find out. Where could they have gone anyway?"

"If they continued north and left the zone, there is a lot of mostly open ground, some settlements and larger villages ..." He let the words hang.

"I'm not sure, Sir. Everything I can think of is bad: They're camped, here in the Archangels, where we'll surprise them and they'll kill us; they continued north, out of the zone and are now destroying the coast on their way north, or anywhere, really; they turned east and we're following one but will find them all and they'll kill us; we're following a lone or lost orc, and this is the best-case-scenario, and he'll kill a few of us with his *needle gun* before we can take him down, if we can take him down."

Colonel Warren turned to Jeffers and they both slowed significantly, "but

we'd detect them."

"Sir? What, Sir?" Jeffers was confused.

"Mr. Jeffers, we have all this equipment, we're following one creature and his weapon. Certainly if and when he re-joins his group, his people, eh—" *He was cut off by Jeffers's sudden enthusiasm.*

"Right, Sir, right you are. I'm sorry, I'm jumpy and a little paranoid. Yes, it's not like we have any worries of being lead into a trap or anything." Jeffers took this exchange as a cue and fished a dark-yellow box from one of his pockets. He handed it to the colonel. Warren put it into a pocket on his thigh. "Obviously, if it vibrates where you can feel it, hide." Jeffers suddenly had another horrible thought and embarrassment didn't stop him from blurting, "although ..."

"Yes, man, spit it out?"

"It isn't like every machine ever invented has always been fool-proof. What if they have a way to mask their energy and heat signatures?" Jeffers immediately wished he hadn't said anything.

Colonel Warren laughed. He laughed and punched Jeffers jovially on the arm. "Lighten up, man!" He was still laughing, "you're already dead. You really need to develop a sense of humor about life."

"Colonel?" Jeffers stammered a little, "you're telling me to lighten up?"

"I'm not saying we should shout and announce ourselves, but try not to be so fatalistic." Then, changing tone, "don't give yourself a heart attack, now."

And then Mr. Jeffers did laugh, but not especially loudly. And anyway, they were catching up with the group which seemed to have stopped and were spreading out. "What is going on here?" He said.

One of the men stepped over, "we're gaining on him, Sir. He's ... quite ... close." The soldier moved away and back toward the others. They were making a somewhat crooked line perpendicular to the path toward ... whatever it is. Here, the mountain grass is above knee-height and quite dry. Wild fires must be frequent.

The group were aiming their own weapons, weapons that resembled their flashlights, just smaller. With the non-weapon hand, they were brushing the dry grass with long, narrow, telescoping batons. A game fowl suddenly fluttered and took to the air. Had it not been for years of training, that creature would not have survived the day.

The search-team suddenly stopped, all of them. It was as though someone had shouted stop. Two of the men were pointing and making gestures.

"I think we've found him," said Jeffers.

Colonel Warren gestured to him. Jeffers re-joined his team. There was a black, shiny lump on the ground. It wasn't a natural object. Jeffers squatted, grabbed a hand-full of the dry grass, pulling with it dry earth in a clump from the ground. He motioned his team to back off. He threw the grass and clump under-hand and hit the lump straight on. It didn't move.

"Hello!" He yelled. *Nothing*. Jeffers put out a hand and the man next to him offered his baton, Jeffers took it. He lifted up his hand and made a gesture, circling with his finger. The men made a circle around the thing. "Please identify yourself," Jeffers said as he took several steps forward.

Suddenly, it moved, there was a screeching noise, it stood up and was apparently in the middle of pointing at Jeffers with both arms together but his men shot the thing and it fell down. Then it turned and rapidly

moved in the grass. The party followed, the man in the lead firing at the thing as he ran. "Sir!" He was saying, "I don't think our weapons are having an effect."

Jeffers offered, "you knocked it down, didn't you?"

"Or it ducked into the grass, with respect, Sir. It shouldn't be moving, is all, Sir."

Jeffers remembered something the colonel had said, "hey, it's not like you've never died before!" Then he yelled, "just grab it, don't worry," ... and they did. The party sped up their running, surrounded the creature, disarmed it, and by the time the colonel appeared, Jeffers was already tying it up.

The creature was screaming and hissing and screeching and spitting. Its body spasming, then going limp – *as if that trick would ever even fool a child* – and then starting again. The eyes wide, its freakish mouth with the four terrible teeth on the outside, pointing in the wrong directions, looked like it would try to bite.

Some of the coverings, clothing or armor, had been removed, there were onyx and hematite-colored gloves, helmet, shoulder pads, a thick belt of large, metallic, thin, and dark green scales. All of the creatures artifacts were marked or engraved with squiggling lines and strange symbols.

Members of the search-team even managed to confiscate a thing, possibly the weapon that killed Kanin, and it really did look like something that would be called a needle gun. It was a silver-colored, metal (?) handle with two prongs coming up and curving toward each other, and then down, perpendicular to the handle, but not touching. There did not seem to be a trigger. They were being quite careful with it.

This is either a terrible weapon or a soldering tool.

Two soldiers built an ad hoc stretcher and they attached the creature to it.

"I don't like this, I think we should kill it." Someone said. "We don't know enough about it, and we were sent to get it, not kill it." Someone else said. Colonel Warren overheard similar things as the group began carrying—well dragging—the plank they'd attached their captive to.

He decided to answer as authoritatively as possible, "we were sent to retrieve a giant, certainly we can handle one of their pets. If we kill it, we won't be able to question it, may not be able to question it anyway." He realized there may be a counter-argument and added, "none of us knows how we were revived, some of us don't even know for sure that we were revived. We don't know, as well, if Tyzmon can continue reviving people, and that hardly indicates he can revive other creatures. And even assuming he can, we certainly don't know if he can revive *these things*." He said the last two words with as much disgust as he could manage. Finally, he said, "may not even want to."

The march back to where the group had set up camp the night before took longer than the hunt, but was still over quickly. All the scouting groups had been recalled, 3 soldiers were dispatched to fetch water, fish, &c. It was just a few minutes after noon, the Sun at its apex, normally the guard would change and the morning group would become a scout troop—except that was no longer necessary.

The few soldier-scientists conducting the forensic investigation earlier had apparently finished; Gisela, the deputy, signaled to the colonel as he approached camp. Under her uniform coverall, the stark red of lieutenant's rank was just visible at Gisela's collar: A sad reminder that

he'd lost a friend.

Warren checked his shares and, as indicated, the report had been uploaded. He decided to integrate the report later if he could get some good strong coffee. He signaled back and then gestured again and she got to work giving orders and taking down the camp.

They ate in shifts after the water-fetching group returned. Then the entire team was re-assigned to color-coded sub-groups for the hike back to base camp on the other side of these mountains.

Fire: The trap

The group closest to “the creature”, those carrying it, and the ones assigned as security detail, were the black group. The forward group was the white group, these were the ones farthest from their captive.

One white-group soldier took a misstep and fell on some brush. His two team-members came to his side to help him up and all three suddenly vanished in a shimmer accompanied by a short, high-pitched zip.

No one else saw any of this.

From the rear, Mr. Jeffers, the colonel and the deputy were suddenly stung from behind with what was later described as “a thousand needles”. Two members of the *robin's egg* group saw them fall and moved closer to give aid but their bodies were nowhere to be seen.

Suddenly there was a lot of noise and confusion and a loud explosion to the north, down the mountain from their location, toward other, taller mountains. Then—another explosion—closer, and the entire unit took cover.

Men were marching from lower on this mountain, pointing large weapons

at the hillside and discharging bolts of bright cobalt which caused the noise upon impact – *but didn't seem to kick up any dust*. There was a call among these newcomers. All at once, they raised their weapons and turned to continue up the mountain.

One of the scouts risked whispering into the comm, she said, “they're human, Sir.” And the comm went dead.

Jensen fingered a button on his earpiece, made the connection, “stay down,” he breathed. Then he stood up and walked back down, toward the strange army below. When they didn't fire on him, he raised both hands above his head and shouted: “we are not your enemies, we mean you no harm! This is a training mission.” Mostly the truth.

Someone in the group below bellowed something but no one understood what was said. Jensen said, “what? I don't understand.” And one of the soldiers below broke out of formation, lowered his rifle and fired a cobalt bolt which struck Jens in the abdomen, he fell backward, clutching at his belly, screaming.

There was an almost soft brushing noise as he fell.

The comm crackled, there was a moment of electric, electronic confusion of clicks and bleeps and then a whisper, “stay down.” The comm was silent for a half minute then, “do not move.”

The armed newcomers were immediately upon them and around and within the group. With somewhat threatening gestures and grunts, they made Colonel Warren's team stand, then congregate in a circle. They had been made to drop their weapons (and their flashlights).

This large strike-force from lower on the mountain was easily large enough to be called an army. They were dressed, head to toe, in black

with an apparently close-fitting shiny and organic material. Many were wearing hoods made, it appeared, of black wool, some had on sleek helmets with a dark, smokey, glossy and translucent face-shield. It was one of these men who leaned over Jensen's body and touched it briefly with a gloved hand.

Jens recovered instantaneously with an audible inhale of breath.

"What the helvede is going on here?!" He was a little upset.

The black-clad, gloved man straightened up and turned to the, now seated, soldiers of Colonel Warren's elite group. He began speaking, but no one understood anything. He had some kind of diamond-shaped insignia on his left shoulder, there was alien writing and a thick, black, jagged line: *mountains*.

Jensen stood, turned to face his cohorts, brushed his body and his legs of dirt from his fall. He seemed to be fine.

Three of the take-over force marched past the seated men. They stood before the orc, still bound to a board. One of them took something from a pocket on her chest, held it between herself and the orc and moved her thumb. The orc made a loud guttural noise which ceased suddenly. She then turned and raised an arm. She gave an exaggerated nod, turned and she and the others returned to their larger, collected force.

The man who revived Jensen handed him a cantaloup-sized black-metallic ball. The black-clad men and women began, slowly at first, turning and marching north, down the mountain. From the back of their train, two or three were still facing up, walking backwards, watching the assembled soldiers. But then, after two or three minutes, they were gone. A

memory and a dead orc.

A scout whispered into the comm: "they're from the village." After some hesitation, the group dispersed to retrieve their weapons and, presumably, resume their journey.

Jensen examined the orb. There *was* a seam, or anyway, a line around the sphere, a darker material, almost as though someone had drawn a circumference with a thin pen. "Can anyone tell me what this is?" His comm chirped and his own voice echoed back at him, the voice actuation kicking in. Someone took the ball out of his hands. His eyes were closed and he felt himself fall, strike the ground. A moment later, though, he sat up. His eyes were closed tight.

The orb buzzed. A feedback noise filled the comm. Then all communications equipment went dead. Everyone heard a slight whistling sound. A moment later, they were surrounded by a shimmering, static—a kind of white-noise dome. The six people who had earlier vanished reappeared and screamed, but stopped abruptly. They all appeared unharmed.

Jensen opened his eyes, took a breath, and, with help, stood up. "What is going on here?" And then the feedback and his own voice again. He touched a hidden button on his ear-piece. "They just wanted to kill the thing, the orc?"

Suddenly Colonel Warren was on the comm, "is anyone harmed?"

"Just you, Sir."

No one knows who said that, but the tension was lifted temporarily. They still had the dome. And they'd lost their captive. *But at least they didn't take the body.*

From down the mountain, a fresh group, dressed in animal skins and rags was coming up and toward them, it was markedly less sophisticated than the—what to call it?—strike force that preceded them. In another 10 minutes they were all assembled just outside the dome. One of them walked to it ... and then through it.

There was a sudden buzz on the comm as soldiers whispered to each other and then all was quiet again.

The person who had walked into the domed area put her palms forward, she made odd, deep, rapid guttural noises. Then she was silent, then she made odd, deep, slower guttural noises. She made a big show of removing a side-arm and placing it on the ground.

Jensen stepped forward, into the comm, he said, "I'll take care of this." To which no one said anything, not even Colonel Warren. Jens took another step toward the woman, then two more steps. He also made gestures with palms down, then forward, then up, he also made a slow-motion show of removing his weapon, placing it on the ground. He took another step toward her.

The mountain woman pointed up, past Jens in the direction of the orc's body. She made an audible sigh, gestured and pantomimed and clutched her abdomen.

Jens nodded. Into the comm, he said what everyone was thinking, "the orc killed someone." He spread his arms, shrugged his shoulders, whispered, "I don't know what it is," he gestured, pantomimed, whispered, "we were sent to find one."

She seemed to understand, started shaking her head, gesturing and even speaking, if that's what that was, her guttural language. She leaned down, pantomimed picking up a child, held invisible child in her arms and

a tear streamed down her cheek. A child was murdered. They all knew it.

Jensen spread his hands again, *I don't know what we can do*. He put his arms out, pantomimed taking a child and the woman began vigorously nodding her head, she turned to the her people outside the dome gesturing for them to come forward.

She looked past Jensen into the crowd of soldiers, looking at them, scanning the group. Her party came into the dome. She suddenly saw the metallic orb, raised an arm and pointed at it.

Having nothing to lose, the soldier brought her the ball.

When she touched it, the dome dissipated.

Two males carrying a large, apparently dense silver sack approached Jensen who cast a glance to Colonel Warren who was watching as though a child at a dramatic performance. They took their load to the colonel. Another pair of men with a similar burden were behind them and two women with another bag, though smaller and white, followed, almost meekly, behind them.

Fem: A return to the valley

The men and women placed these sacks, pretty obviously bodies, in a tidy line in front of the colonel who still seemed one point six million kilometers away.

They turned and started back down the mountain without a look back. The ambassadress, the original woman who had entered the dome turned back to Jensen. After a moment of hesitation, she put out her right hand. Jensen didn't resist the urge, took her hand and shook it. She bowed, turned away, face flushed, filled with wet eyes and tears,

dripping from her chin, walked, more slowly than the others, she did look back, but just once.

The orc, its body in two pieces, was wrapped in polymer wrap as carefully as possible in case—well, in case.

With almost no discussion, the three bodies were incorporated into the gear and the squad resumed their hike back to the valley *army of the dead* headquarters.

There's an ancient path up through the mountains, heading south, back into the lower basin that is the valley and the large city beyond. The path is rather narrow, obviously a hiking path. They had no more trouble navigating it now than they did navigating it the first time.

About an hour after dusk, the soldiers stopped for dinner, making camp for the night on a broad, flat area at the summit of the lower of two neighboring peaks. Colonel Warren, his deputy and Jensen conducted a briefing meeting. But they had been hiking together, so the meeting was really just an extension of the conversation and an excuse to eat together. They discussed Scott. Laughing at memories the way people everywhere always do.

The next morning, the camp was abuzz before the Sun's first peek over the eastern cliffs and peaks of the Archangel Mountains. And after an attenuated, excited breakfast, they began the almost six hour hike back down to the main encampment.

The relics.

Chapter VII: Reunions

En: Humans and Humans

After an impromptu—and early—lunch with the squad upon re-entering the main camp, Colonel Warren, his deputy and Jeffers were directed to Tyzmon, behind the infirmary. Along with those two bags containing what was left of the orc, the still-wrapped bodies of the three villagers were to be brought to the infirmary proper.

Tyzmon was reviving more found bodies, all soldiers—so far, and there seemed to be an efficient process where a body, carried by two soldiers was laid at his feet, reanimated and lead away by two other soldiers. Eventually, Tyzmon stood from the small stool he'd been squatting on, dramatically stretched and turned toward the infirmary tent. He was met by two men who accompanied him around the corner and inside.

One of these was a man who resembled Tyzmon to an extraordinary degree. He was obviously much younger and dressed in the matte-black of special ops. The other was dressed in a kind of shiny purple robes, he walked with an air of complete freedom—almost humor—evident even from a distance.

When Deputy Gisela Gnaver, Jeffers and the colonel arrived at the front of the large infirmary tent, their cadre of half a dozen soldiers bringing the bodies were already there. The villagers, two adults and a child had been unwrapped, the *creature* was still in translucent polymer wrapping. These dozen plus one bodies then entered the tent a half minute after Tyzmon and his entourage.

“Colonel!” Tyzmon turned, addressing the group, but addressing the colonel, “you’ve brought so many friends back with you today.” He

seemed happy.

"We needed help with these bodies, Sir." The colonel said gravely, indicating the villagers and the bags containing the creature. "Three of these are humans from a village in the mountains..." He stopped awkwardly, but then powered on, "we couldn't communicate well with the villagers, but these may be more victims." Finally, "the other," he pointed, "is one of the creatures they call an orc".

"I've revived so many people today. Let me see this creature." Tyzmon's eyes didn't leave the colonel's, but he did gesture in the right direction. Uta, Clarke (her father) and Bob directed the colonel and Tyzmon to a waist-high shiny metal table. There were instruments on carts all around it. Two soldiers followed behind, each carried a dense, apparently liquid-filled polymer bag which they deposited on the table and immediately exited the tent. Warren turned and gestured and the rest of the cadre followed them out.

Uta and Bob were putting on tight rubber gloves and face and head coverings, and goggles. Uta took a short, sharp blade to one of the bags and cut it open, Bob did the same with the other bag. A kind of congealed goop spilled out of the bags. Everyone immediately reacted to the stench, even Tyzmon.

Tyzmon stepped away from the table and caught Colonel Warren's arm, "you haven't met my brother and that man," he indicated the purple-robed figure, "is Radulf." The colonel nodded, his face was turning pale and he was about to be sick, he retched. Tyzmon rapidly brushed the back of his hand against Warren's cheek. It felt a little like a slap that missed, but the colonel immediately felt better.

They returned their attention to the table. It appeared to be covered with blue and green paint mixed with a dark blue, almost black ink. "You

found it like this?" Tyzmon was looking at each of the people around the table, locking eyes, then moving to the next.

"No, no, this was a creature the size of a short man." Jeffers was saying, "we had it alive, it was taped to a board. But unfortunately, see, we were met by mercenaries or some kind of village guard with bizarre weapons and they bisected it, they shot it into two pieces."

Colonel Warren cut in, "they weren't foul goop when they were put into the bags." He was almost afraid to ask, "can we question it, Sir?"

Tyzmon took this as a joke, he laughed, Radulf laughed, no one else laughed. "I do not think it can answer any questions. Have you tried questioning it, Colonel?" He may have meant before it was killed.

The colonel suddenly felt like a cadet, "well, it was dead and ..."

"Relax, man." Tyzmon seemed very relaxed himself, "I meant before it was—ruined." He meant before it was killed.

Jeffers said, "it was worse than the mountain people, Sir, none of the translation algorithms could make any sense out of it, it was hissing, no complex patterns were detected."

"Can we take this," Tyz indicated the orc-puddle, "outside?"

"Sir?" This from Uta.

"I'm not sure what I can do, but the tent could catch fire, or am I guessing wrong?" Tyzmon said this, clenching and releasing his jaw, "also the smell will kill us all."

Clarke turned and opened a cabinet against the canvas wall of the tent behind him. When he turned back, Clarke was holding four bright orange discs. He handed two to his daughter and one to Bob. Uta then turned

and handed an orange disc to Gisela. She pointed at the floor by the table. One at a time, the legs of the table were lifted so orange discs could be placed between them and the ground. Clarke pressed something quite small in his hand and the table lifted a few centimeters off the ground. He and his daughter then pushed it toward the door. Everyone else followed and they all left the infirmary.

Tyzmon indicated a flat expanse that was presumably a safe distance from the tents. "Couldn't bring me a live one," he mumbled under his breath as he walked behind the rest of the group.

At the indicated location, Clarke deactivated the discs. Uta noticed that the table had dripped goo and there was a trail leading almost all the way back to the infirmary opening. She and her father exchanged a look: *oops*.

Tyzmon motioned everyone back, and away. Bob flicked on a flashlight, pointed it at the table. Icon started juggling fire which distracted Radulf who smiled like a happy fox, or any fox.

Sighing as if about to do something unpleasant, Tyzmon placed both hands down into the liquid, palms directly onto the table.

Nothing happened. Nothing happened at all.

Tyzmon opened his eyes, spat, "I got this crap on my hands for nothing?" But as he was saying *nothing*, the table shifted suddenly, one of the legs buckled and the whole thing tilted. Tyzmon was pushed by a force no one could see, but managed to keep his hands on the table and not fall down. "Colonel?!" Tyzmon, suddenly breathless, a hoarse whisper, "we may have a problem if this works!"

Warren suddenly reached up to his ear-piece, relaying orders. While

Tyzmon was wrestling with a table and an invisible foe, soldiers were arriving from all directions.

But other than destroy the metal table and assemble a battalion of security personnel, nothing seemed to be happening. Tyzmon was trying to speak, managed to croak out, "you guys should probably back off." His nose was bleeding, his body was trembling, vibrating, every muscle tensed. Suddenly the day, previously a cloudless, Sunny day, was dark, overcast, the clouds were boiling over each other; there was loud thunder. Then nothing and the clouds dissipated.

And Tyzmon was wrestling a small man, a creature with an awkward stance and a grotesque face. It was hissing and growling and repeatedly biting Tyz's forearm. Tyzmon had an unusual expression, of tense amusement, as though laughing at a joke that should offend. Tyzmon's blood was spraying everywhere.

Soldiers swarmed and extracted Tyzmon and orc back to two separate entities. Tyz was carried, bleeding and exhausted, back to the infirmary. There, Uta began wrapping his arm against his loud vocal groans and rather blatantly offensive protestations. When she finished he took the blood-soaked bandages off and he was, of course, uninjured.

"That hurt. The little bastard really didn't want to be here." Tyzmon, in spite of being in good shape, bodily, was still talking like he was winded. "Okay, let me see these mountain people."

Uta seemed surprised, "Are you sure, don't you want to relax, take a nap? I don't know, have a cookie?"

It seemed like he was about to answer but then he smiled, interpreting this as a joke and making a kind of fake laugh expression but no sounds. He turned toward the bodies the soldiers had brought back, two adult

males and a young female child. Colonel Warren cast a glance at a nearby guard, the two of them lifted the child's body and brought it over to Tyzmon.

"Why do they look so different?" Tyzmon was talking about the skin, for one thing, on one of the males and the child, it was pale, pink, almost white; the other male's skin was a kind of shiny brown. These people also had thin lips, body hair—even the female child had a light wisp and almost invisible layer of hair. Their feet were such an odd shape, rounded on top, short stubby toes, like flesh logs.

The more one thought about it, the more otherworldly they seemed, the more superficial the similarities!

Everyone was quiet, possibly making the above list in their own minds. Or they just didn't know who should be the one to answer him. The others were casting each other glances, Tyzmon started doing it too.

Finally, Uta said, "We aren't exactly sure. There are several lines of inquiry on the subject. First of all, there is something wrong with this valley, none of our communication equipment can penetrate it or, from the inside, escape. People, families, go into it and disappear, never to be heard from again. There are all kinds of stories, theories: but the people here seem to be archaic humans."

Colonel Warren's eyes were suddenly open wide, "you mean you've never seen one of them before?"

But Tyzmon was getting confused and his head was spinning, he was suddenly remembering his aunt and his uncle, the old magician, Macmillan, whom Icon said was their father, the other children, everyone was so pale, so pink, with the hair. *Except* Macmillan, the old magician,

was shiny and gray like Tyzmon or Radulf or Icon or Warren, and he had no body hair, just eyebrows and side-burns. He had the same longer forearms and shins, the flattened feet, small, pointy ears, and the large, deep, dark eyes. But how could he be both? And come to think of it, did he even have the hair in front of his ears?

"Icon ..." Tyzmon reached out a hand and his head spun and he felt nausea and everything was spinning and he felt himself fall. Other arms steadied him, straightening him out, placed something soft beneath his head.

"I told him to rest." Uta said with a satisfied smile.

In his head, Tyzmon's own voice was a bleating sheep: "the soldiers look like you, the humans are small and pink. *The soldiers look like you, the humans are small and pink.* The humans have colorful, small eyes, rounded ears, pink or brown skin, they have soft hair on their bodies. You aren't human, you aren't human. *They'll kill you if they catch you. They'll dissect you. **They'll dissect you.***" His body shook and he passed out.

He dreamed of sultry pink women with only two breasts who were oddly ashamed of their body hair.

...And Tyzmon dreamed of metallic gray women with no body hair at all and the correct number of breasts.

Just before he was aware of a soft light filtered pinkly through his eyelids, he dreamed of a large wolf attacking, lunging, jaws clamped onto his recently injured forearm, it wouldn't let go. In the dream he was yelling, screaming...

To: Last of the lizardmen

Tyzmon woke and stood up. Radulf and Icon were with him in an artificially lit room. He realized it was simply a tent, but it wasn't the pine-needle drab of the soldiers' tents, it was a silken white tent. No, it wasn't white, there was glare on his eyes, sticky eyelids. He blinked it away. "Where?"

"Tyzmon," Radulf said, addressing Icon.

Icon turned to face Tyzmon. "We'll have to rejoin the others momentarily."

"What happened?" Tyzmon placed his palm on his face, pressing fingertips into his forehead.

"Look, Tyzmon, we have to talk. You forget things, important things, and then someone has to tell you or you get to learn the ..." he paused " ... difficult way."

"There was a small creature, it bit my arm and I ..." Tyzmon was shaking his head, squinting and pressing his face, his head.

Icon sighed. "Look, we should get back to our guests. I haven't seen this many people in thousands of years. You seem to forget the vastness of the timescales in question. Tyzmon: you and I, we're not human. We never were."

Radulf didn't seem surprised, this was clearly not news to him. Tyzmon said, "you knew?"

"After you saw the fuzzy people, the female child, you seemed ill and sat on the floor, Icon, Uta and I tried to make you comfortable. Icon and I brought you to this tent shortly thereafter and he told me." Ralph may as well have been reciting a recipe for soup.

Icon continued, "our parents are not human. Look, Tyzmon, this is going to be a lot for you to digest, but our parents come from another galaxy. The people of this planet called that galaxy Andromeda, I have no idea what it's called now."

"But we look like them, we look like Uta and the colonel and them, those soldiers, we look like Ralph here ..." Tyzmon's speech was rapid and confused, almost a child's whine.

"Try not to get worked up, Tyz. We only look like them because of several adaptations our ancestors enjoyed and passed on to us. For one, in close proximity, we release hormones that have neurological effects on nearby creatures, especially intelligent creatures. There is something else going on, as well. The light around our bodies is bent, so even if non-organic images are captured, we appear to be what we seem, namely, people. I'm not even sure I can explain everything to you. Suffice it to say, there are chemical and physical properties of our bodies that fool most creatures and equipment."

"But ..." Tyzmon had no real protest. He was raising his arms, but let them drop.

"It would be incredibly difficult to show you what we look like outside the influence of these chemical and physical camouflages." Icon's tone was somewhere between an instructing parent and an academic lecturer. "My own theory is that we'd appear as dark green lizard people." He was quiet while he watched his brother's face, then continued, "our father once told me that our ancestors could become invisible. The truth is, there is no reason we cannot become invisible still. We seem to have lost only the behavior, not the ability."

Radulf said, "The thing is, I and the other soldiers will continue to see you as modern people; but if you revive those ..." he paused, looking for

a word, "... those relics, they'll probably see you like one of them as well." He gestured with both hands, waving, alternating. He shrugged, looked back at Icon.

"I've warned you in the past to avoid situations that could cause people to see the truth. I'm not entirely sure a situation like that could exist, but ..." he looked at Radulf, "... I'm not exactly sure that even these people would be happy to know that we're here." He stopped, he appeared thoughtful. "You've mentioned before that you thought we look alike?" Possibly a rhetorical question.

"There's a family resemblance," stated Radulf.

Icon snorted, "forgive me if I don't take your opinion of the matter seriously." This made Radulf laugh.

"Shouldn't the chemical cancel out, though?" It was Tyzmon, thinking things through.

"To tell the truth, I don't know. I don't know why, in a room where it is just the two of us, or just one of us with a mirror, why we don't see our 'real' bodies." Icon stopped, thought, then said, "all I know is the illusion is almost complete, almost perfect."

Tre: Of pirates and werewolves

Radulf addressed Icon, "can you also revive the dead?"

Icon gave Radulf a serious look, "I can do many things, but that is not one of them." He took a breath. "Our father told me stories of fighting pirates between the stars, between galaxies. I'd like to think he was very good at it. He told me as well that there were a series of malfunctions and possibly a saboteur aboard and he and his crew were marooned in space. Their communication equipment was completely gone, as in

ejected from the ship. And they had machines that could collect energy and matter from space itself. And other technology that could convert that energy into propulsion and ... and tools and nutrients." He paused, visualizing Macmillan, the old magician regaling him with tales of adventures beyond the stars. A single tear slipped down his cheek.

Shaken but undeterred, Icon said, "The mole, the spy, the saboteur, if he was one, was a shape-shifting creature, if he was one." Icon paused, tilted his head and eyes down, trying to remember, "on the planet where we came from, other creatures have the ability to disguise their bodies. We have intelligent dogs that can appear to be men." He blinked, still thinking, he scratched his chin. "I think ... I think, there may be other creatures that sometimes appear to be men. But our father seemed mainly concerned with the dogs."

A full minute passed, Radulf looked back and forth between the two brothers. Icon was trying to remember a story told to him maybe half a billion years ago. Tyzmon was absorbing, as if for the first time, that he was the child of a spacefaring race of supermen.

Finally, Tyzmon said, "I think I understand, perhaps we should discuss this later. They're waiting for us, I presume?"

Radulf nodded. Icon led them out of the tent and across a flat expanse and back into the main camp and to the infirmary.

Fire: It's a frog, it's a butterfly, it's a cat, it's a ghost

The interior of the infirmary was unchanged from earlier when Tyzmon collapsed, save for the use of artificial lighting which appeared to emanate from the fabric walls of the tent itself.

Besides the dead *archaic humans*, only the three *medicinsk personale* remained, Uta, her father, Clarke and Bob. Uta turned and, giving Icon a

glance, examined Tyz briefly, "are you OK?"

"I'd like you to take a blood sample from me, Radulf and my brother here," said Tyzmon. Icon stopped walking in surprise, his eyes momentarily widened. Radulf, ever the amused one, put out an arm and began pushing up the sleeve of his robe.

Uta was reluctant, wondering what was discussed in private amongst these three. "I'm sorry, Tyzmon? Is something wrong?"

"I have reasons to believe I'm not human. I want to see if we can verify this information."

Tyzmon's habit of getting right to the sucking wound in the heart of the matter was unanticipated by Icon, he looked between Tyzmon and Uta, then, after the initial horror wore off, he too began exposing his arm. "Let's do it. I'm a little curious myself." Icon had only slightly more to lose than Tyzmon. May as well play along.

"If you're not human, what are you?" Uta was rearranging and examining various instruments on the carts around one of the shiny metal tables.

"Icon and I were born on Earth, but our parents were possibly several centuries old when they arrived here from," he suddenly turned to face Icon, "from where now, droomeedah?"

Icon hesitated, "a long long time ago, people who resemble these bodies called it Andromeda; it's a whole other galaxy. I'm not sure your people have a word for it, in many ways you're advanced from the people we knew but in many ways you aren't."

Uta was still facing away, picking up small metal objects seemingly at random. "Do I want to know?" Her voice was strained.

Tyzmon said, "it won't change how I treat any of you. Our father and his friends warned us in various ways to avoid just such a test and other things. They feared these 'archaic humans' would imprison us and dissect us. Perhaps they would have; but I do not believe you, Uta, or your people would do such things." Tyzmon took a breath, swallowed, "anyway, if I sense the least hostility from your people, I can create a distraction and escape."

Icon said, "Uta, just take the blood, I'm not sure why he's doing this. I've already briefed Radulf here. We wanted to prepare my brother," he glanced at Tyzmon, dipped his chin, continued, "in case reviving these corpses set up a situation where our camouflage was voided." It looked like Uta was going to say something, Clarke too, but they were both silent. Icon said, "where we come from, there is a whole evolutionary line where species have several overlapping forms of camouflage. Many animals do it better, but as on Earth in prehistoric times, and now, there rose to prominence a self-aware, intelligent group of creatures which," he took a breath. "Which, when they were finished fighting and interbreeding, quickly overran the planet and spread out to the stars." *Where they continued fighting and interbreeding...*

Uta, apparently coming to a conclusion, turned around, two syringes in one hand and another in the other. "Dad, Bob," she handed each a syringe, "let's move this along."

Uta's syringe punctured Tyzmon's forearm easily, she drew off a cubic centimeter of blood. There wasn't anything unusual about it. So far, so good. Clarke had already finished drawing Ralph's blood and he turned toward a large machine whose purpose only medical people could understand, or so it seemed. He pushed a couple buttons, there was a loud click and the device began to hum. He opened a hatch which came forward and exposed a bright white flat and fibrous shelf with

depressions in several rows.

Clarke squirted the contents of his syringe into an indented pocket, typed in "1", took Uta's syringe, emptied it into the next pocket, "2", finally sample "3" was from Icon via Bob. He closed the door, and pushed a large rectangular button that was flashing green.

A screen flashed to life, then two more buttons started flashing. Clarke pushed both simultaneously. There was a slight purring noise and a couple blips, the kind of thing I assume medical analysis machines are expected to do. Finally, it was quiet and there were three ovals displayed. One appeared to be a moving picture in color, the other two were still and gray.

"I don't believe it!" he breathed. "Uta, it says they're ... they're amphibians," a beat, "no, no they're insects," another moment, "no, that's not right. Wait..." He tapped a few keys then he tapped more and then began rapidly tapping. Finally, "the machine can't tell me what these cells are." Another puzzled pause, then, "or if they're even cells." He turned away from the machine.

Icon said, "it's part of the camouflage." He sighed, suddenly resigned to the inevitable, "check the refractive index: melt the fluid and send light through. Or run a standard spectral analysis, but you'll need to dry them for that. Do you need another sample?" He started to offer his arm again. Taking the cue, Radulf and Tyzmon did the same.

Clarke, dubious, shook his head and returned his attention to the device. This procedure was apparently very simple, because he pressed only one button.

Suddenly the machine seemed alive, all manner of buttons started lighting up all up and around the device, the screen went blank then

flared to life again. "This is incredible." Clarke was looking at what I would call a sine wave, "Radulf is human. But you two," he turned to them momentarily, then back to the machine. "You two are *plant matter* ... ?"

Icon shrugged, "I wish I could tell you. The camouflage is rather complete. I mean to say, I don't know what we look like either."

Clarke was looking at the wave on the screen, reading the chemical markers for the varying wavelengths of light, "if it makes you feel better, you're carbon-based."

"What else would we be?" (This was Icon)

"I don't know, what do you have on andy-rom-ed-eh?"

"In," Tyzmon said, "it's a galaxy, a spiral cluster of stars ..."

"What if you were cut open, would your organs be in the expected places?" Clarke seemed genuinely interested, Tyzmon took in a sudden breath and seemed unsteady on his feet. *Was this how it would begin? Would they take him and dissect him?*

Icon said, "when the soldiers helped Tyzmon retrieve my body from under a boulder, they were unsurprised by what they found, if that helps."

"This is incredible." Clarke lifted an unused syringe from a table adjacent to his machine, "do you mind?" He was addressing Icon who was already holding his wrist up. Icon nodded sagely. Clarke withdrew a syringe-full of 'blood' from Icon.

"Don't be alarmed Uta," Clarke said, then, addressing Tyzmon, "if anything happens, you can revive me again?"

"I can tell you I'll try. Why, what the fuck are you going to do?" But he

already knew.

Clarke deliberately injected himself with the fluid he removed from Icon.

...But nothing happened.

"What were you expecting?" This from Radulf, this too: "Why the helvede would you do that?!"

"Certainly I wasn't expecting nothing." He waited momentarily, then said, "Why? Sometimes the most convenient subject is yourself; sometimes the best chance is immediately." He took a breath, opened his mouth to speak again, closed it. Clarke's breathing was suddenly shallow. He collapsed.

Uta fell to his side, "Father!" But then she calmed down. Uta looked up at Icon then turned her head to look at Tyzmon who slowly lifted an arm, pointed past her. Radulf whistled.

Clarke had vanished.

Radulf suddenly said, "I did *not* expect *that*."

Icon stepped over to where Uta was kneeling, "is he still there?" Icon leaned over, almost touching Uta's forehead with his shoulder.

"Yes, he's here, we just can't see him." She leaned over, turned her head, "he seems to be breathing and I can hear his heart."

Icon turned to Tyzmon, "this is new."

Something flashed horrifyingly through Tyzmon's mind, he wanted to dismiss it, but he couldn't, finally, he said, "I was eaten by a dragon." Then, clearing his throat, he said, "is there an invisible dragon out there

somewhere?"

Icon and Radulf, as though cued simultaneously, laughed. Icon said, "depends. How did you get out?" They both laughed again. Ralph pointed and continued laughing.

Tyzmon blinked several times as if blinking would show annoyance. Then, walking to Uta's other side, he leaned down and touched the body and nothing that was there. "Do you think we can wake him up? How long has it been?" Tyzmon and Icon arranged themselves and lifted Clarke onto one of the metal tables. Tyzmon directly touched Clarke's cheeks with his hands.

Nothing happened. Then, from the table, there was a quiet noise like someone talking.

It was Clarke, but the disorienting and spooky feeling of a voice from nowhere was lost on no one in the infirmary. Clarke said, "did I die? ... How long? Did you have to revive me again?"

Tyzmon shivered, he said, "No, you fell or something, how do you feel?"

"A little dizzy, it's hard for me to," he sighed heavily, "catch my breath."

Icon said to the empty table, "put up a hand, hold up two fingers and then count them, tell me what you see."

Clarke sighed as though annoyed at being treated like a child. He said, "obviously, I see my hand and two fingers, why did you ask?"

Radulf this time: "None of us can see you, Captain."

Uta said, "Dad, I give your kidneys about an hour to filter Icon's blood, and we have no idea if there are other side-effects." She was about to say something but Radulf cut her off—

"Clarke, we can't see your clothes either."

Clarke said, "I'm going to get off this table, if you're quite finished with me."

Uta said, "be careful, we can't see you at all. If you weren't talking we wouldn't even know you were here."

No one saw Clarke nod his head, he turned, rolled slightly, swung a leg off the table and landed on the floor.

"Nice experiment, Dad, now what are you going to do?"

"I suppose I'll wait for it to wear off. I—"

Tyzmon cut him off, "You're assuming Icon's blood isn't toxic or that there isn't some other side-effect that'll wreak havoc on your system?"

Clarke said nothing and no one knew where he was.

Tyzmon said, "Clarke, I suggest you stand by Icon, pull his arm if anything goes wrong. I should revive these ... people."

He touched the little girl, she started choking, *that was new*, then opened her eyes, stopped choking and jumped back, almost falling off the table.

Tyzmon said to her, "are you there?"

Uta touched something behind her own ear, "Colonel, you should come back here, bring Jensen."

Icon and Uta struggled but managed to bring one of the other bodies over. Placed him upon a metal table. Tyzmon touched him on the forehead and he opened his eyes. He reached up and took Tyzmon's wrist. He made odd noises and no one knew what was going on with him. The little girl shrieked, jumped from her table and climbed up and onto the table containing the first male.

Radulf said, "her father?"

Various people shrugged their shoulders or nodded, depending on their level of idealism. No one could see where Clarke fell on that matter.

Tyzmon took his arm away from the male. He walked back to the last body, touched the cheekbone with his palm, and used his other hand to take the man's far hand which suddenly stiffened and clenched back. The archaic human smiled broadly. Tyzmon cast a glance at Uta, then Icon, finally addressing Radulf, "this is what he meant, I suppose." Meaning Icon.

From empty air, Clarke said, "how do we communicate with them?"

Tyzmon said to Uta, "didn't you just call Colonel Warren?"

"Ja."

"Ask him to bring a map of this valley."

Rise of the Lizardmen.

Chapter VIII: Technological Marvels

En: Secrets from the past

The second man turned to Tyzmon and began "speaking" in the guttural gibberish, he started gesturing slightly, first with one hand, then both, then, speaking rapidly, he gestured rapidly with hands, arms, entire torso, even moving his legs.

Tyzmon's earlier look of far-off bewilderment was wiped from his face as though it were dirt beneath the auspices of a dutiful mother. He nodded to the gesticulating male. The other male, lifting the female child, turned, swinging his feet over the side of the table, he began speaking guttural gibberish, too.

And then Tyzmon turned to the male with the child and *also started speaking in the guttural, archaic language*. He gestured to the child who smiled happily. Then the three of them were speaking rapidly and looking at Icon.

Tyzmon, whose shoulders had straightened while he was speaking to these fossils, lowered his shoulders and said to Icon, "can you understand? They recognize you."

Icon's eyes were wide but the surprise drained from his face. "It has been a *very* long time, Brother." Then, after a few moments of silence, "I think I can make out some of the verb forms." Icon shrugged.

The archaic humans and Tyzmon exchanged a few grunts and hand waves. Tyzmon put up a hand in the forever and universal gesture for silence. "They think you are a god. They think this is heaven. The soldiers look like gods to them. Just similar enough. I've told them we

are in an army tent hospital. I've explained that we are, in fact, on Earth." He turned back to the archaic human he revived last.

The three began grunting and gesturing again. Then Tyzmon hissed like a snake and everyone was quiet. "They are describing giants and large winged-lizards..."

The child began grunting rapidly, gesturing, her fingers reaching up, her arm slipping past her other hand.

"She says the group arrived from a *hole in the sky*. She says they went south, over these mountains here, were gone for a long time and returned. She says the sky opened like a—" He paused, thinking of a word, "—a zipper." He paused again, then, satisfied with the word 'zipper', continued. "Some of the creatures, she is saying, went into the *hole in the sky*. Wait." He gestured at the male beside the child, then grunted harshly. "The *orcs* have weapons that liquify flesh, explode it in a ball of blood." He shivered visibly. He grunted at the child. She grunted back, no gestures. "They don't know." He grunted at the first male, then rapidly at the second. "None of them knows what happened. They were running, their friends were being killed, hot, boiling blood splashed everywhere. Nothing." He paused. "Then here." He shrugged, "their 'heaven'."

Tyzmon turned to Icon, said something softly into his ear. Icon clutched at the air beside him and he and Tyz left the infirmary. Tyzmon hissed at the archaic humans on his way out.

Outside, Tyzmon and Icon encountered Warren, "Colonel, I'm going to escort these *people* back to their village. I'm going to request that Clarke, Uta and my security team accompany me." Warren nodded. "I'll need a device. Do you have anything that can be used to track an animal?"

Warren scratched his chin, "in the valley, sure, but if it leaves the valley ... unless we also leave the valley, we'd lose the signal. Why?"

"I'll tell you later, if it comes up. Bring me two. For now, these are my wishes." Tyzmon was getting rather brazen, wouldn't you say?

"Jeffers," Warren had tilted his head, speaking to his comm, "meet me in infirmary." Warren nodded to Tyzmon, touched his own ear, said, "OK."

Tyzmon gestured for Warren to lead them into the tent. After Warren was inside, Tyzmon whispered to Icon, "I wonder if Clarke will volunteer for a mission." He smiled deviously. Tyzmon resisted the urge to rub his hands together menacingly. "We have some business here first, though."

Clarke said something but it was ghastly, the disembodied voice, so he had to repeat himself, "sure, I'll do it."

Tyzmon said, "try to stay quiet. It's a *secret* mission."

The three were about to turn and re-enter the infirmary tent when Jeffers and Oz rushed past them. Tyzmon shrugged, followed.

The archaic humans ran to Icon's side when they saw him, gesturing but otherwise silent. Tyzmon grunted softly, gesturing, palms down.

Omar was speaking to Warren. Uta was speaking to Bob and Clarke (by way of Radulf).

Tyzmon cleared his throat. "Radulf, Icon and I are going to take *Erick*, *Dave* and *Courtney*," he indicated the short, pink and brown, archaic humans, "to see if we can get *something* out of the orc. Colonel?" Warren straightened. Tyzmon continued, "take us to the prisoner?"

Colonel Warren turned to leave, interpreting the instruction as you or I would, *immediately*. And perhaps Tyzmon meant that, but Icon made a

three-finger gesture, then a fist and rotated his hand, thrusting it eastward. Warren did not see this, Tyzmon, however, did. He said, "in the morning, Sir."

The colonel stopped walking, half turned, looked at Tyzmon, nodded, saluted and exited the infirmary. The other non-medical people followed quietly. Invisible Clarke, his daughter, Uta and Bob, along with the archaic humans and Tyzmon, his brother, Icon and Radulf remained.

Tyzmon said to Uta, "we'll take care of your father, make sure these people," indicating the *relics* with his chin, "don't escape, they're not prisoners, but don't let them leave, I can count on you?" Uta nodded, squinted her eyes, was about to say something back but Tyzmon said, "of course you can count on me." *I think.* Pretty sure. *Hopefully.* As the four of them were leaving, Tyzmon said to Uta, "we're the only ones who know about Clarke's condition, as a medical practitioner, isn't his privacy a concern?" She smiled, nodded, *I understand.*

Uta whistled a moment after they'd left the infirmary. Radulf poked his head back in. "Give this to him." It was a cookie.

The next morning, after breakfast in their weird white-but-not-white tent, Tyzmon, Icon, Radulf and a difficult to account for Clarke returned to the infirmary where they found Colonel Warren waiting for them. Uta was apparently finishing up a physical examination of the taller, darker archaic human.

Colonel Warren led the way out of the infirmary with Radulf and Tyzmon close at his heels. The smaller, more muscular humans stayed close to Icon. As they marched behind Warren, Jeffers passed going the opposite way, he disappeared into the infirmary.

To: That special bond between a man and his assassin Warren led the way to an enormous pit dug into the ground on a flat shelf almost at the spine of a mountain. The walk took about forty minutes. There were several soldiers posted along the route and a large number more posted around the hole in the ground.

Tyzmon looked over the edge. Radulf did as well and whistled. Icon stepped up to the edge, but the archaic humans refused, shaking their heads, putting out their hands, palms out, forward, *I don't want to.*

Tyzmon addressed Warren, "we have to make it talk. Don't you guys have translators, or machines for this purpose? Didn't you say something about this?"

Warren cleared his throat, "most of the people of Earth speak the Earth language. There are a few outposts, Luddites, rebels, what-have-you, who speak various other languages, dream of some kind of anarchy, or something, or maybe it's just a fun weekend hobby." He paused, apparently making a decision, or lost for words, finally, Warren sighed. "We do have machines that can learn and we've adapted a few of them for this *training mission.*"

"You expected to need devices of this kind, then, Colonel?"

Tyzmon's accusatory tone immediately disarmed Warren who said, "we are gathering as much information as we can about *the inclusion zone.* From the outside it simply doesn't exist." He paused, thoughtfully, continued, "I mean to say, it's there, but somehow you forget about it. The army has known about it for a long time." Suddenly, as though going for broke, Warren shrugged, said, "we are the forty-second such mission." He looked down, took a breath, said, "most of them came back out with little more information than they had when they went in. Before us, none were lost." The colonel reached up to touch his ear, said, "bring the

translation devices, please.”

In a minute, a woman dressed in white with colorful stripes across her left shoulder arrived with a large box. Warren said, “Thank you General Crosse.” He took the box from her. She snapped her heels, saluted and walked away. Addressing no one, he said, “they do things differently in the air force.” He put the box on the ground at Tyzmon's feet, straightened up. Turning his palms up, he shrugged, “they're active.”

“No matter what happens,” Tyz sighed, “don't kill the thing.” He took two of the machines from the box and, without another word, jumped into the hole, sliding awkwardly against the dirt wall and falling like a rag doll. At the bottom, the blackened monstrosity immediately attacked him.

Omar “Oz” Zabaneh, the tech, arrived in the wake of Tyzmon's apparent suicide mission into the pit. He handed the colonel a square yellow machine with an elastic strap.

The colonel shrugged, handed the machine to Icon, turned back to Omar, made a gesture, *two*. Dismissed, Oz touched his own ear and quickly retraced his steps while speaking rapidly into the comm.

The colonel turned back to the pit, resting his hands together behind his back. Everyone watched from the edge of the pit as the orc ripped into Tyzmon. Some of the machines in the box began chirping. Pretty soon they were all making various pings, pangs and clicks.

Tyzmon, covered in his own blood and little else, as his clothes had been ripped from his body and were strewn around the floor of the pit, said not a word, didn't even defend himself. He felt his left arm get dislocated which probably hurt. The colonel touched his ear and mumbled something about clothing. Tyzmon continued letting the little creature punch, claw, kick and chew on his body.

Suddenly, though, he grabbed the creature around the neck, looked up and said, "did it work?" The colonel, apparently speechless, nodded, gestured with a raised arm.

Tyzmon punched the orc in the face four or five times, he bellowed, screeched, screamed. He punched it again. He pushed it and kicked at it, then pushed it and it fell onto its back.

The orc hissed. A moment. A tin echo: "What the fuck do you want, Andromedan!"

It did work.

"You know of us then?" Tyzmon tried not to sound surprised. One of the yellow machines began hissing.

"Of course we know of you!" The orc hissed, the machines clicked. "You are from the little cloud. Your people are the dry piss residue of the universe. Where-ever there is a urinal cake one of your people is there trying to sell it to some naïve child in a neighboring galaxy."

Tyzmon was unperturbed: "My brother tells me it has been a long time, a very long time, since we've arrived here." Machines hissing.

"You! Are filth, you're slime. You and your people are the ejaculate of prepubescent halflings squirted onto the foul excrement of slime beasts. You should kill me here, now. My people will smell your filth on the air around my body. Beasts from methane swamps won't even consume my remains." The orc hissed. The machines made clicking noises.

"So, I take it you don't like us." Tyzmon smiled malevolently.

"Fuck yourself Andromedan. Fuck yourself with a pitchfork." More hissing. More clicking.

"Answer me or I'll lick you!" Tyzmon said, smiling menacingly. Machines whistled and hissed.

"You wouldn't!" Hissing and clicking, *et cetera*.

Tyzmon looked down at his torn and bloodied body, "maybe I'll fuck you." The two machines hissed.

The orc, still on his back, began to push away.

Blood and sweat dripped from Tyzmon, he stepped again toward the orc.

"What answers do you want, Shadow?" The machines were speaking, the orc was hissing.

"Where are you from?" Tyzmon said it slowly, took another step, coming close to the orc's foot. The orc pulled it away, crawled on heels, wrists and elbows, scooting backwards, a bug on its back, keeping Tyzmon near its feet.

"We are from this galaxy. We use the Cihocki-Inversion to travel between locations, and between worlds." Orc hissing, growling; machines chirping, speaking, clicking. "One of our subways malfunctioned and linked here by mistake."

Tyzmon blinked several times absorbing the information. When it was clear that neither orc nor machine was going to speak again, "What is your name?"

"Ephen of Morford," the orc hissed, the machines clicked.

Tyzmon wiped some sweat and blood off his chin, reached his bloody hand out, the orc attempted to back off but the steep wall of the pit prevented this. It screamed. The machines said, "Nooooooooo!"

Tyzmon reached down and grabbed the orc's ankle with his bloody,

sweaty hand, lifting his leg up.

"No, you mustn't!" Hissing, clicking ... &c.

Tyzmon pursed his lips, making a noise in his throat.

"Don't rape me, you beast! Release me at once!" The orc was hissing and screeching, the machines were speaking melodically.

"I can have you cleansed." Tyzmon teased, the machines hissed.

"Release me! Foul beast! Rapist! Monster!" Hissing, clicking, musical speech, as before.

"...or I can impregnate you with my scion." Tyzmon turned, reaching for the orc's face, the orc failed to move away, he couldn't push through the wall of the pit. Tyzmon grabbed one of the creature's external teeth.

"Nooo!" If the machines were super accurate, it would have come out muffled. The sky darkened.

Tyzmon leaned forward, bent his elbow, pulled back, releasing the orc's ankle. There was a pop. Green ooze squirted up from where a tooth was removed. The creature fell and lay still; green fluid dripped from its mouth. The sky cleared almost instantaneously.

"I know you're conscious you slimy bastard." The machines hissed.

"Release me." The orc hissed, the machines clicked and sang. There was suddenly a terrible odor. The orc opened its eyes, turned, evening up its body along the pit wall. It attempted to move away along the wall and was leaving a dark yellow, foul smelling trail.

"You fight like a child." Tyzmon said, wrinkling his nose. "Yesterday you were a disgusting plasma delivered in two separate bags with an odor that made strong men wish for a quick death. Today you are on your

back like a cheap prostitute sullyng herself before the first paying customer.”

“Please. Please, I beg you. Please.” Soft hissing from the orc, clicking, musical speech from the machines.

“I'll keep your fang.” Tyzmon said, closing his hand. He scratched his chin, “can we put you back on your subway?”

The orc's hissing came out of the machines as a soft sobbing. It seemed to be praying or apologizing to its mother, which is about the same thing, I suppose.

“I'll have them send water, Ephem. If you want to be returned, we can send you back.” The machines were clicking, whistling and, finally, hissing.

The orc lay in its own excrement, dark green blood dripping onto its naked onyx chest.

Tyzmon decided to try one more time, “where did the others go, why were you left behind.” No one had briefed Tyzmon, this was a guess.

“I wasn't left behind, I volunteered.” He hissed, the machines translated, the process was, by now, almost real-time.

“You volunteered?” Tyzmon took a step away from the orc.

“I was,” it stopped abruptly. Tyzmon leaned forward, almost forgetting about trying to make the creature comfortable. He straightened up, took another small step back. Orc: “I was asked to close the door on this side.” This last completed the process and the machines almost matched the creature, it appeared to be mouthing the wrong words to its own speech. The machines also inverted the waveform and nearly canceled out the creature's hissing.

"If you close the door on this side, the subway can't stop here?" Tyzmon had no idea what he was talking about, to be true, but this seemed the right thing to ask.

"We already know this is a false stop. We, long-ago, put this region off-limits. This was a game preserve for a very long time." The orc hesitated, then said, "Now it is a protected park." Silence filled the pit. The orc, seeing that Tyzmon wasn't going to speak, continued, "we don't want the fauna from here messing with Cihocki technology, we can't have them creating inversions and appearing on planets all over the Milky Way." It stopped speaking.

"You don't welcome your galactic brethren?" Tyzmon wondered if he was calling the orc a racist.

"They are little more than animals. Our du'hamour are smarter than they are." It hissed and the machines chirped, but did not translate, or perhaps hissing was the translation.

"Du'hamour?"

"Our large dragons."

Tyzmon looked around the floor of the pit, located torn pieces of one of his boots, walked to it, kicked the debris aside, looked around. He saw his other boot, walked to the far side of the pit, pushed the torn pieces of shiny scaled boot aside and lifted The Dragonfeather by the handle. He returned to where he had been standing, near the orc's feet.

Tyzmon held up his slightly curved bladed weapon with the long, almost spear-like handle.

"You've killed one!?" The machines made it sound more like surprise than an accusation.

"I'm unsure what happened. It may have tried to eat me." Tyzmon threw The Dragonfeather up in the direction of Icon, almost thirteen meters up, at the rim of the pit. Icon leaned and caught the weapon expertly. Tyzmon walked along the wall of the pit, found and reclaimed the Tyzlane Staff. He walked back over to the orc.

Tyzmon took a step toward it, then placed his foot between the orc's knees, there was more terrible odor, more congealed fluid, orange this time. Leaning down, Tyzmon touched the orc, there was a distant flash and a noise like thunder. The orc's wounds were healed, its tooth replaced.

"What sorcery is this, Andromedan?!" It was amazing, it was like the translation machines didn't even exist.

"I am come as time," said Tyzmon mysteriously. He turned, leaned forward, touching his knuckles on the pit floor as he bent at the knees and waist, his spine curving. He straightened suddenly, hopped as a flea, and exited the pit in a single motion.

Icon inhaled suddenly, clearly caught by surprise.

Tyzmon turned to the nearest soldier, "don't let it touch you, but send down buckets of distilled, filtered water. Avoid contaminants, use polymer or stone containers, no metal." Tyzmon paused, then thought again, "don't let it touch you," he repeated. Tyz turned and walked around the pit to where his group waited. Icon handed over The Dragonfeather without protest.

Tyzmon shouted down into the pit, "you can't close the door on this side, little creature, there *is no door on this side.*" To Colonel Warren, almost a whisper, he said, "I think we can send him back."

The colonel, less impressed than Icon with Tyzmon's grasshopper-like

jump, addressed him as though nothing had changed, "as long as we're up here," he said, "what did you want us to do with the *other prisoner*?"

Tyzmon turned suddenly back to face Warren, "what other prisoner?"

Tre: The mummy

Around the rim of the pit, here was a path made of flat-sided, smooth river stones which appeared ornamental. Colonel Warren led the way along this path which joined another and veered away from the deep chasm which was the sad domain of Ephren the *orc*. The colonel spoke to nobody in particular and was too quiet to be understood, so apparently was using his comm *or going insane*.

As the first pit became a memory behind them, they started to see a second pit up ahead. Warren touched his ear and spoke up, "you told them to put him in a hole, Tyzmon." He pointed.

In the pit, much smaller than the cavern the orc enjoyed, and only a few meters deep, was the man who'd earlier been dressed all in black. Now he was dressed in dingy white wrappings of a dozen centimeters wide. Tyzmon thought of funeral dressings for members of a civilization that was already long-dead when he was a child. He then began to wonder if even his brother knew how long ago *that* was...

There were guards everywhere. They stood with their small flashlight-style weapons, sticks with thin knives attached and other things and weapons that Tyzmon couldn't describe later. "Guards." Tyzmon said.

"Yes," said Colonel Warren.

"So many." Icon said.

"Ja." Radulf said, "if he can get out, why not dig a deeper hole?"

The colonel turned to Radulf, "that's not what we're worried about. Anyway, these are volunteers."

The small group was now standing on the edge of a decidedly shallower pit containing a seated man wrapped from neck to toe in what could have been a single length of dingy white cloth. "Why is he dressed like that?" It was Icon talking.

They were interrupted by Deputy Gnavor and two other females who wore the shiny organic uniforms of stark white apparently favored by the air force. They were each carrying a box. Warren said, "speaking of dressings." He lifted the box from Gisela's arms, handing it to Tyzmon. He did the same with the next box. The last box he lifted from the air marshal and opened himself, draping leggings over his arm. Tyzmon had placed one of the boxes on the ground as he opened the other.

He took the leggings from the colonel and opened the remaining box. He proceeded to dress himself dutifully. "I lost some nice boots in that ordeal," he said. He stood, in fact, barefoot in shiny new clothes. Addressing Gisela, "what animal had to die for this?"

Apparently immune to Tyzmon's humor and eyes darting to Icon, she replied, "we were warned not to use animal pelt for your armor, Sir."

Tyzmon laughed. Radulf laughed. Icon laughed. Gisela looked at Warren and even *he laughed*. "I don't understand the humor, Sirs," a mild complaint from the deputy. She waited a moment and said, "in any event, there is a rumor that you are returning the villagers, I'd like to volunteer to accompany you. To make this request is why I volunteered to present you with your new suit." She was addressing Tyzmon but Warren gestured locking both his hands together.

"If it isn't too much trouble," he looked at Tyzmon, then back at his

deputy, "she should accompany you. Be careful, Sweetheart." The colonel's voice broke a little when he said this.

Deputy Gnavor stepped into a kiss with the colonel, wrapping her arms over his shoulders, around his neck. "Don't worry, my love."

The archaic humans made a kind of mute giggling noise, especially the female child. Radulf looked between this public affection and Icon who tilted his chin and smiled slightly. Tyzmon, apparently oblivious to the non-verbal gossip surrounding him said, "I'll bring her back to you, don't worry." He turned to his brother, "Icon, can you *shoot* fire?"

Icon smiled and then exposed his teeth making the smile into the words, "yes, of course." Tyzmon pointed away from the slope of the mountains, kind of a *show me* gesture. Icon leaned down, placing his right knee on the ground, left foot planted ahead. He rotated at the waist, lifting his left arm, palm down, fingers closed. As he looked up his arm, over his knuckles, a sizzling noise and a whoosh, a fireball exploded from his fist, flared into the valley and out of sight. He stayed down on one knee, arm up.

"Is it a trick of light, or is it real fire?"

Tyzmon's words didn't have the tone of an honest question, but Icon answered anyway, "either one or both, Tyz. You know this already. I am a fireman, you know what that means."

"It is perfect." He slapped Icon on the shoulder, "protect the colonel's mate." He turned to Warren, "she's in good hands." Then, after a moment that he used to help his brother to his feet, "you were about to explain our mummy friend down there." He nodded at the man in the small pit.

Colonel Warren was at a loss for a moment, then Tyzmon said, "why is he

dressed like that?"

Warren quickly lifted his hand to his ear and two guards turned from the edge of the hole and approached. After saluting, the colonel said, "why is the prisoner dressed like that?"

The two soldiers cast a quick glance at each other and finally the one to Warren's left spoke, "he requested it, Sir."

Warren almost literally dropped his jaw. He took a moment to recover. He said, "did he ask for a rifle, too? I heard him asking for his freedom earlier, why is he still here?" Sarcasm splashed on the ground.

"It wasn't an unreasonable request, Sir." The guard said.

"He's a prisoner, any request is unreasonable."

This hilarious exchange was interrupted by the prisoner apparently recognizing Radulf. "What the Hölle?" He said, and, "what sorcery is this?"

Tyzmon moved to see past the two guards, he looked at the prisoner. The prisoner was staring at Radulf. Tyzmon looked at Radulf. Radulf was shaking his head, "I have never seen him before in my life, I swear it." He shrugged and laughed. He said, "I think you have me confused wit—"
" but he was cut off.

"Radulf of Sommarsward. *Radulf, born in the Hamlet of Helgen Ynez.* Ralph of the long blade. Ralph the Vengeful. Radulf the Wicked." The prisoner spoke these phrases in quick succession, and the last with a distinct sneer. Radulf's eyes widened imperceptibly. He looked at Tyzmon, then at Colonel Warren.

Ralph said, "he knows me." He stared at the prisoner, "but I do not know him."

Tyzmon, puzzle pieces dropping into place, suddenly shoved Radulf out of his way, the prisoner saw him again for the first time. "What the fu—"

"You are the one," said Tyzmon. "You are the one who murdered Ralph." Tyzmon threw the Tyzlane Staff at the prisoner who dodged to the side, the staff landed and rolled at his feet. Tyzmon hopped into the hole with the man and punched him in the throat, then snatched up his staff and climbed out of the hole. The prisoner was clutching his neck and gasping for air.

Radulf, thunderstruck, looked back and forth between them. "No, I was killed by boulders or ..." He shook his head, he really didn't remember.

Tyzmon said to him, "Ralph, for fuck's sake, man – when I found you, you had a knife wound on your neck!" He lifted his left hand, snapped his fingers twice and one of his captains came running from some hidden spot higher on the mountain.

"What did they tell you about that small dagger?" Tyzmon addressed his captain.

"Yes, it was confirmed this very morning, Sir. Ralph's blood, collected last night, is the same blood as was found dried on the small knife found on this man here."

"And you didn't wake me up to tell me this?!" He was apparently furious.

"I'm immensely sorry, Sir. We didn't know what it meant. We didn't know ..." he paused, then continued, "we didn't know anything. Callam thought you already knew."

"Who the helvede is Callam?!" Tyzmon spit when he spoke.

"Callam is your bodyguard, Tyzmon." – *This was Colonel Warren speaking.*

"Callam is the *other captain* besides me," said the captain, apparently too scared to be offended or annoyed that he was being blamed for something he couldn't have foreseen.

Colonel Warren interjected, "And this man's name is Ivan."

"Yes, Sir, yes, my name is Ivan." He stopped talking, looking back and forth between Tyzmon and the colonel, he appeared to be scared for his life.

"Do you have the small dagger now, where is that knife now?" Tyzmon was losing it. The prisoner was recovering, Tyz noticed, threw the stick again and returned to the hole where he punched the man in the abdomen and then, when he doubled over, slammed both fists together into the man's back. The prisoner's knees bent and he collapsed onto the ground. Tyzmon grabbed his staff, climbed, with help from a guard, out of the hole.

Captain Callam was walking down the hill toward them. The archaic humans were looking at Tyzmon with an odd mixture of fascination and wonder and, naturally, horror.

When Tyzmon was standing above the hole again, Captain Ivan said, "Callam has the weapon, he's," he indicated with his chin, "coming now."

Tyzmon walked to intercept his other captain. "Give it to me." Callam obliged. He followed Tyzmon back to the group at the rim of the small hole. Tyzmon handed the dagger to Radulf, gentlemanly, holding the tip of the blade so his friend could take it up by the handle.

"What are you waiting for," Tyz said to Ralph, "kill the bastard."

Radulf laughed, looked at Warren who didn't move, didn't change expression. The colonel looked back at Tyzmon who actually may

explode.

Even Icon wasn't reacting, and he probably really could explode, I mean, if he wanted to, being a Fireman and all that.

Tyzmon could remember Ralph's story, the entire episode before Icon's bonfire flashed through his head and he quoted, "*We decided the best course of action would be revenge, aye, this is not the first time I've been thought dead and become free as a consequence.*"

And with that, Radulf went to the edge of the hole, turned, jumped down, turned to face his assassin who was actually recovering again, standing. The prisoner choked, put a hand up, "Please. It was a job. Please don't kill me."

Ever since being revived after his encounter with a dragon, Radulf's sense of humor became more and more entwined with his sense of self, his sense of reality itself. "It's like you were delivered to me," he said, smiling as though a child given a puppy.

The other man took a step back, "No, please. How will you live with yourself?"

Icon snorted, he laughed. Tyzmon allowed himself to be distracted by the sound but then returned his attention to his friend in the hole.

Ralph said, "if what you say is true, we're the same, except that I didn't kill you." With his free hand, he pinned the mummy-wrapped-assassin against the stone side of the hole. He pressed the edge of his forearm against the man's throat. "Oh, and you didn't even have the courage to face me. *I face you now.*" He drove the dagger underhand into the prisoner's chest, beneath the sternum. Almost immediately, the prisoner was dead and Radulf himself was holding the man up. He released his grip first on the handle of the small knife, then shifted his elbow and the

mummy fell unceremoniously, to his knees, to the ground.

Radulf leaned over, recovered the small knife from the man's body and climbed, but was half-lifted by Callam and Ivan out of the hole.

Tyzmon said, "although..." Everyone looked at him. "Nothing, nothing. Ignore me."

~~ INTERMISSION ~~

Go do something else. Then come back.

2ND HALF: THE INCLUSION ZONE

Among peaks and passes...

Chapter IX: The Large Ones Redux

En: Mountaintops and memories

Three dozen people made camp on the broad, flat expanse that was the smaller of two adjacent mountains. Four days had passed since the events at the pits. Tyzmon was still getting used to his new uniform which included an ear piece for the comm. He considered it a nice part of the costume. Comm codes and hardware had also been loaned to Radulf and Icon.

The uniform did not include boots. He missed his boots. Tyzmon, like all who've lost good footwear, remained a barefoot martyr to fine boots lost from the beginning of time, throughout the expanse of known space.

There had been a big meeting. Colonel Warren referred to it as a debriefing. Plans were discussed: the future. Had there been more food in pastel colors, it would have been a party, I'm sure of it.

At the debriefing with Colonel Warren, the afternoon of that day which felt so long ago, Deputy Gnavor made her plans clear: She intended to find and revive Scott. Her plans included taking Tyzmon to the loci where they lost the lieutenant. Tyzmon, as usual, didn't require any convincing.

The colonel marked the appropriate mission maps, and the overlay with the Archangel Mountains north of the valley. The bottom map was the mission where they had retrieved the orc, the mission made urgent and tragic by the loss of the lieutenant. Locations had been clearly marked:

Loci main camp; loci temp camp a; loci temp camp b—Scott's remains; loci mountain village; loci orc found; loci orc caught; loci

trapped/ambushed by archaic 'strike-force'—acquisition of 3 archaic human bodies; loci evening camp on mountain top.

This is where they were now, in fact.

Deputy Gnaver had heard the stories, seen the short videos from the witnesses' shares; the present and future of gossip is dripping with technological credibility. She knew, for example, that Ralph had come out of nowhere: He wasn't there, not a whiff, then he was an image, then he was a body on the ground, then he could walk and help move a boulder...

Tyzmon couldn't help. He had no idea where Radulf had come from.

Gisela would not be deterred:

Holding out hope—even if your lineage or anatomy is different—seems to be one of several critical factors that make us human.

Gisela's plans would change almost nothing about the forthcoming mission, the group would likely camp near the point in question anyway, except that she would be brought along and was point on "operation retrieval".

A little irony? Finding Lieutenant Lutèce, alive, would bring her a kind of demotion.

Besides eating food and discussing the dead, other things were covered during the *debriefing*:

Tyzmon instructed the colonel to work out an exit plan, to continue scouring the valley for remaining bodies, remaining soldiers, *try to get everyone out*. He'd be back within a week and do whatever was necessary.

Before the meeting ended, Icon had said something about the mountains being near the *opening of the time envelope* and this sparked a rapid

conversation about the nature of the valley itself:

The modern people, that is, this group of soldiers – *including Radulf* – referred to it as *the inclusion zone*.

Icon explained that his and Tyzmon's father, Macmillan referred to the entire valley under various and sometimes mysterious expressions, among them –

- the crash site
- the debris field
- hopper's exhaust
- but most commonly, *the time envelope*

What started as a kind of humorous conversation became a somewhat serious discussion and with Tyzmon as translator, Erick – "*Courtney's father*" – reported that his people, the proto-humans called it a variety of names on a certain theme: rift, orée and edge.

Clarke and Uta, who hadn't attended the meeting were formally assigned to the mission. Icon, giving Bob an inscrutable look, refused to give details, but did say they were fully aware of what they had to do. Colonel Warren looked to Tyzmon who nodded slightly with a quick glance at his brother.

In the few minutes after Radulf emerged from the pit containing the body of his assassin, Callam presented him the purple short sword. Tyzmon said, "it matches your outfit." But when Radulf almost refused the gift, Tyz explained, "it was on him when he infiltrated the camp, I don't think it's a weapon at all, it looks fragile and ornamental."

Ralph didn't get the implication at all and took the weapon happily.

Sometime after, but before the debriefing, he'd acquired a scabbard of bronze and lizard hide—possibly from Captain Ivan.

As willing and helpful as ever, in spite of Tyzmon's friendly insult, Radulf took responsibility for the orc. Ephien had been bolted to the top of a metal medical table. With the legs removed and a kind of sled attached, Ralph needed only to give it a slight tug to drag it up into the mountains, going down the other side wouldn't be any different. The creature refused to eat, assuming it needed to eat, so at meal times, Tyzmon would come and touch the creature's skin, *just in case*.

Not known for his empathy, and not exactly willing to discuss the matter, no one, perhaps not even Tyzmon, himself, knew what to make of his *send it back* plan.

Three dozen people made camp on the broad, flat expanse that was the smaller of two adjacent mountains. Four days had passed since the events at the pits. Tyzmon was still getting used to his new uniform which included a shoulder patch indicating his department and rank: Resurrection services and volunteer.

The camp itself was much less formal than the elite forces camp under Colonel Warren, for one thing, the hierarchy was in shambles, where Tyzmon went, people became, at best, helpful volunteers. I don't mean to say that they treated him vastly differently, although, if I die and you bring me back, I'll likely treat you vastly differently. The impression you'd get was that he was a trusted uncle or possibly, a brother, older; perhaps heroic.

Much less formal, but for the most part the people involved are soldiers, they kept protocol. *They just smiled more.*

Which is interesting, as Warren was constantly instructing people to

To: An effing battle

With the Sun, breakfast and a breaking of camp. The hike down the back of the two lower peaks wasn't treacherous, but it would take awhile. The soldiers took a good pace—but it was an easy pace—in apparent consideration of their shorter-limbed proto-human guests.

It had been six hours. Every hour and ten minutes they had been taking five minute breaks. In another ten minutes they'd have another break; but this one, a lunch break, would last forty minutes or more. There was some noise down the mountain.

Gisela remembered the strangely dressed people who had trapped Colonel Warren's team on the prior mission. She started thinking about how they were disabled rapidly and the orc had apparently been the target. She was thinking through the encounter, straightening up a little in anticipation when there was suddenly a loud bang and a whoosh immediately to her side.

She was sprayed with small rocks and dust. A boulder had hit the ground beside her, kicking up debris and was now rolling down the hill. Deputy Gnaver spit dirt and dust, wiped her face with her forearm and turned to look. Behind the hiking soldiers, proto-humans, Tyzmon and his people, the orc on its sled, *two enormous orcs*.

"Giants!" Someone yelled. And everything was pandemonium. There was screaming. People were being smashed beneath huge chunks of mountain. The largest rocks anyone could ever imagine were flying through the air, landing in a cloud of dust, a spray of dirt and sand.

But there was a third figure as well. It was as tall, possibly taller, than the giants.

It was Radulf and he had a sword.

Before she lost consciousness, Gisela saw a titanic version of Ralph behead one of the giants, then she died beneath a boulder that rolled downhill, smeared with her blood.

In battle. Tyzmon flea jumps onto the side of a giant, stabbing at it with The Dragonfeather, climbing, stabbing again. The effect was less than when Tyzmon attempted to move the boulder from his brother's corpse last week. He saw the other giant fall. Another, a third giant, a huge shiny purple-clad Radulf, took a large version of the purple knife to its neck. The giant orc fell in two pieces.

Icon was on his knees, on the ground, fire spat from both his fists. He brought his hands together, fire came from them like a urine stream. The remaining giant ignored it; it was on fire, flames licked Tyzmon's feet, but the monster scarcely seemed to notice.

From down the hill, the strike-force, their bizarre weapons, some kind of rifles. Three shots, one or more shooters, and the giant fell, pinning Tyzmon beneath its body before it disintegrated in a kind of metallic cloud of dust.

Immediately, there were two more giants, they were coming down from the peak of the mountain, Tyzmon had a moment to notice this before the enlarged Radulf, taking two immense steps up the mountain, sliced one in half, but then, suddenly, Titan-Ralph and the remaining giant were gone.

And there was a dome over the entire area, the surviving soldiers were slowly getting back to their feet. The proto-humans, not casualties this time, were helping wounded soldiers in the silent and universal way of nurses on battlefields since the beginning of time.

The comm was down, of course. The static, white noise, the whistling, but this time it was different. Or perhaps it was mostly the same, except for the dead. There weren't giants before, that was true. And Gisela had been there, then, too, of course, the only one who died that time was the orc.

Members of the strike force were surrounding the dome and, apparently seeing the orc, walked into the dome. One of them removed something from a pouch on her chest, held it to the orc's body, moved her thumb and without a sound this time, the orc's body relaxed. She reached down, retrieving an orb from the ground, the dome dissipated.

Tyzmon was standing over one of the soldiers' bodies. He appeared to be swearing but no one heard anything. He leaned down, then moved to the next body he could see.

The *archaic humans*, Dave, Courtney and Erick were talking, rapidly, to a small group of these newcomers. From their gestures, they were explaining the events of the past few days.

The proto-humans brought a heavily armed female wearing a helmet to Tyzmon, still reviving the giants' surprise victims. Tyzmon's face was awash in tears. He said something about arrogance, shook his head, returned to reviving soldiers.

The village and the museum

Chapter X: Mark V Humanity

En: The TITANIC demonstration

There was no dissuading Tyzmon from his task of reviving his expedition teammates. Sometimes he didn't know where to look and could be gently guided. Since she had been in good spirits and was a kind of de facto leader, Gisela was up ahead of the the main group when the giants appeared. This simple fact made her the last soldier to be revived on the back of Low Mountain.

But that was twenty hours ago, yesterday, in fact. And from Tyzmon's perspective, considering his madness the day before and remembering that he doesn't need sleep, it probably seemed longer. But then again, at that point, he had been alive an immense number of years. So perhaps it was a flicker of a candle, a blink of an eye.

He sat in a cot in a small cabin. Artifacts from his past were everywhere around him. The cot itself was supposedly a bed he, himself had slept on. He was alone. Well, as alone as a man with a demon can be. He sat. He thought. He dreamed.

A brief knock at the door and it opened and Icon entered. "Wow." Then silence. Icon went to a long table against one wall and started picking up items, turning them in his hands, setting them down and moving on to the next.

Tyzmon's eyes opened with a snap, he said, "they tell me the orc controlled those monsters." Icon knew this, the woman who led the strike force told them both as she led them down the hill to this village. The hike took most of the afternoon and dipped into the evening.

Of course, Tyzmon had to translate most of the conversation, which means he, almost certainly, knew— Icon said, “they were projections. I’m not sure how much these people know, but that is not Andromedan technology, not an ability our people have.” He scratched his chin, moved on to the next object on the long table, a large hourglass made of blue crystal with clear, salt-like, sand.

“What about your fire, I felt the flames lick my feet, consume them. When they destroyed the monster, they were sore, they were burned. I was pinned beneath it.”

“And you didn't panic. Which is good.” Icon turned so he could see his brother, set down a cube with many various colored squares all over it, some kind of puzzle. “They seem familiar with us, but they don't seem to know your full powers. They probably didn't know mine before I freaked out. I wish I had known that fire wouldn't work on that thing.”

“Do you think they'll try to ...” Tyzmon's voice lowered, “to dissect us?”

Icon laughed. “They aren't going to do anything to us. I worry more about our soldier friends. Apparently they aren't supposed to be here.”

Tyzmon, ignored his brother's reassurances, continued on, “what do you think they'd find if they dissected us ...?”

So Icon ignored him and continued, “I think we need to convince the docents that they're harmless or trustworthy or something.” He thought aloud, “certainly they won't commit mass murder.”

Tyz abandoned his earlier train of thought and joined Icon at this station, “these people are the first humans, the proto-humans. I do not think they'd consider it moral or justifiable to kill any of the extant people of this planet. Besides, discovering this ... this *museum* isn't a crime.”

Tyzmon suddenly remembered something, took a breath to speak but his

brother was already talking.

"I suppose the worst that could happen is that the *current intelligent bipedal Earthlings* would learn some of their planet's history. I don't see how that could hurt anyone." Icon stopped, "you were about to say something?"

"No, I ..." But Tyzmon couldn't remember and was frustrated for a moment. Icon handed him his staff. "Thank you. I was going to say, I think, what happened to Ralph?"

"Do you mean, where did they take him, or do you mean, when he became the giant hunter?" Icon was smiling and he chuckled.

"I'm just a little confused. Those giants came from nowhere and almost took us out in less than a minute. And then ... and then there were two more." Tyzmon was shaking his head.

Icon stopped laughing. "Tyz? We just went over this. The orc created them. They are a function of orckind. The security forces for this museum assumed the giants were projected by some kind of foreign technology." Icon took the one step between himself and his brother, he spoke quietly, "you proved this wasn't technological in nature when *you revived the orc-puddle*." He put his hand up in front of his brother's face and snapped his fingers, twice. "You need to snap out of it already." Icon's eyes searched those of his brother.

Tyzmon sighed and pushed his brother's hand aside. He turned, hopped off the cot. He was about to say something but didn't. He started pushing a small toy along a narrow empty section of the table – *a wheeled vehicle, it was dense, possibly made of metal and painted red, there was a telescoping white polymer ladder on top*. Then he said, "where did they get this stuff?"

"The past, I guess ..." Icon heard a noise on the other side of the door and stepping past his brother, he opened it. It was Radulf.

"You guys should come with me, OK?" And he turned and started walking along the side of the cabin, after the surprise wore off, Icon and Tyzmon came after him.

Tyzmon caught up with Ralph, walked beside him and Icon followed a pace behind.

Radulf turned after a couple hundred steps, took the purple weapon from its scabbard and handed it to Icon.

"What do you see?"

Icon shrugged, took the weapon, held it in one hand, held it in two. He handed it to Tyzmon, said, "other than being purple and not having a guard," he waved a hand, "it has a soft grip ...?"

Tyzmon turned the blade over in his hands, "I still think it's ornamental, I still don't think one should be using this as a weapon." He swung it, a motion you'd expect, if he were a child.

Radulf put out his hand and Tyzmon handed it back to him. Ralph faced the brothers, put a hand up, palm out, started taking steps backwards, looking down, and behind. At about 6 paces, he held the knife, grip up, blade down.

A low pitch, high volume boom and they could see another Radulf and he was a magnificent titan. The normal Radulf just stood there, his face blank, the Titan Radulf was walking toward them with his monstrous blade and making earthquake footfalls. ...And then it was gone and the small Radulf put the knife away, rejoined the others.

"So you control it?" Icon said.

"There is a trigger, a switch, on the grip, well, under the grip, I guess it's on the tang." Radulf was talking really fast. It was new.

Tyzmon suddenly spoke up, "How the helvede did you know to do it, to push the ... the thing on the thing?"

"I didn't. And at the time, I thought that whatever triggered the giants triggered me as well. But what actually happened was those ancient people appeared down the hill, and the giants appeared at the peaks. I saw the boulders falling, saw the giants. I had taken the sword out and was getting ready to ..." He stopped, considered, continued, "... to die beneath a boulder, I suppose. But I thought I could fight, so I held this weapon, I must have held it pretty tight and ..."

"And you hit the switch by accident?" Icon's voice betrayed a certain comic wonder. He turned to Tyzmon, "do you think the assassin knew?"

Tyzmon said nothing. He suddenly remembered why they perhaps dispatched the murderer a bit too hastily. "I think I have to revive that røvhul."

Ralph and Icon turned and spoke in unison, "What?!"

"We don't know, for one thing, who hired him; Ralph, you're still in danger. We don't know, as you've discovered, if he knew about this weapon, but I didn't know about this weapon and the more important thing: How did he survive the two waves of orc and dragon attacks?"

Ralph thought for a moment, "Maybe he came after ...?"

Tyzmon said, "you saw the giants, you told us. You didn't even realize you'd been murdered." He let that sink in, then said, "you joined the expedition into the valley. You were killed in the valley. You saw the orcs

and their dragons and their whatever – the giants.”

Icon cut in, “I remember, yes, you saw giants, and probably the dragons, but may not have lived to see the orcs, which means you were killed coincident with those things. The assassin was in the valley at the same time as you and orcs and all that.”

Radulf said, “if you revive him, do you think he'll answer your questions?”

Icon and Tyzmon looked at each other and they both said, “yes.” Tyzmon was nodding his head, and he said, “if not us, you.” He paused, thoughtful, said, “who else have you told?”

Ralph shook his head. *No one.*

And turning to give Tyz a significant look, Icon said, “they may already know, but it shouldn't hurt to keep this between us for now.”

To: The burns

The three men, super heroes, all, mysteries, all, returned to Tyzmon's little cottage. “I mean it, Tyz, can you please not tell anyone? Even if they seem to know, please?” Icon was saying, but he knew it didn't matter. Tyzmon was going to do and say what Tyzmon *would* do and say.

Tyzmon said to Icon, “Andromedans can throw fire?” His face had a mischievous expression.

“What?” Icon said, but Ralph also turned. “What?” Icon said again.

“It's just, the fire seems to be the same effect, *thing* as the giant orcs. Giant Ralph, projected orc giants: you said are domestic, Milky Way galaxy, abilities. The way I see it, there are things we can do that they can't, or don't, and there are things we can all do and there are things they can do and we can't. Unless I don't know about my giant-

projecting, matter-out-of-nothing skills. *It's possible*—I guess.”

Icon sighed. *He'd told Tyz this story before.* Ralph didn't know, so there's that. He looked at his hands, at his wrists. “Philip was a man who wore all green, and he was veiled, so I'm not even sure it was always the same man. He spoke rarely or not at all, instead giving me tomes to read and using mere gestures in my presence...” Icon was momentarily silent, then continued. “He taught me. We always met in a certain field, starting about the time I was seven. Until I was about eleven, I guess. But at first, there were rings, bracelets; he gave me bracelets.”

Icon paused, rubbing one wrist thoughtfully then starting on the other. “For awhile, the power was that of the bracelets. And little by little I absorbed it. Or I learned it. I still don't know. He tricked me once, this little man, the green-wearing teacher guy, and gave me rings that were supposed to be more powerful bracelets. With them, my powers increased three-fold.” He said nothing, rubbing his wrists, *that was the last meeting ...*

Radulf and Tyzmon were watching Icon expectantly but Icon seemed to be far far away. Finally, Radulf cleared his throat, “your powers increased, and ...?”

Icon shook his head, blinked as though waking up, coughed into his hand, continued talking. “Well, they weren't more powerful bracelets, they were just copper rings.”

Tyzmon looked at his brother's wrists, “some trick.”

The three of them continued talking about these and other powers, powerful things, but were soon interrupted by a group of three archaic humans who'd apparently come to get Tyzmon.

"Your team." One of them was talking and only Tyzmon could understand, but these proto-humans were very fond of hand and body gestures, facial expressions, so it was almost as though they didn't need speech – kind of convenient, actually. "Your people," the short fur-ball was saying, "they have all developed a kind of rash, the leader is stoney. Is comatose."

Tyzmon, vibrating with energy, started back in the direction this collection of nurses (?) came from, but stopped, turned back: "where?" His voice carried the urgency of a scared child.

The man who had spoken grabbed his elbow. He turned, began running, everyone followed.

In his head, Tyzmon had already worked something out that would be told to him when he reached a new kind of infirmary, a large brick building, a proper hospital: Ralph was not afflicted, so it wasn't the whole group.

It didn't, in fact, take much conversation before Tyzmon – *and now Icon, starting to understand more and more of this odd ancient language* – knew who the sick were, in particular.

The people he had revived on Low Mountain. *But not even all of them.*

Gisela had it the worst, as the man had suggested by Tyzmon's door. Tyzmon asked Ralph and Icon to find people he had revived after the most recent giant attack who were not afflicted. This was not a problem and half a dozen soldiers accompanied Radulf and Icon when they returned.

Why? How?

Twenty soldiers were lost on Low Mountain. Six are fine. Gisela is alive

but not moving. The other dozen plus one soldiers had a kind of rash on their faces, necks and some, their chests. Gisela, comatose, also had the rash, in her case, it was especially bad on her lips and chin.

These unlucky thirteen – *and Gisela* – were isolated in a brightly lit room near the main doors of the hospital.

A somewhat troubling thing: *Tyzmon's touch had no effect.*

While Tyzmon, Icon and Radulf were puzzling over Tyzmon's inability to fix these soldiers, the archaic humans, a couple doctors and other staff members, were conducting experiments, also trying to diagnose and/or treat them.

"Wait," Tyzmon said when a technician wearing what appeared to be a space-suit and bio-filtering face-shield came to Gisela's bedside to take a sample from her reddened lips. "Just wait." The medical isolation suit – *or golem or whatever it was* – was a spooky piece of equipment, because it was this large, shiny white machine with a person inside, but it made absolutely no sounds. Even the footfalls were muffled or canceled.

Tyzmon was trying to remember. This was his life. Something happened and he struggled to remember. Or something almost happened and he was pulled aside and made to remember. He blinked his eyes, shook his head. *Remember!*

"Icon," he said. "What was different, did you see anything different when these people were revived?"

"You were quite emotional, we couldn't talk to you. We could guide you to the next body, but anything else met a kind of blank stare."

Were they revived too hastily? Tyzmon's thoughts were racing. *That can't be it, they'd be dead, not burned.* "Burned." Tyzmon said it aloud,

I know, there were witnesses.

"Tyz?" Icon looked between Gisela and Tyzmon.

Tyzmon turned to the giant statue to medical technology, "are they burned?"

"We don't know, Tyzmon. I guess it could be. I thought it was a rash, but I suppose it could be a burn. Do you have an idea what may have caused it?"

Tyzmon pinched Gisela's lips, breaking the dark, almost pink, gray and damaged skin. He took a thin stick from the mechanical-looking doctor, rubbed it into and through the wound he made. "Can you test for foreign matter?"

"You were crying." Radulf said plainly.

"What?" Icon turned to Radulf; Tyzmon also turned.

"You were freaking out. You said you were an arrogant fool, that you'd caused all this pain and suffering, that you had almost killed everyone. You were crying." Radulf gestured, wiggling fingers and drawing his hand down from eyes to cheek, he was getting the hang of this gesture-based communication.

Tyzmon remembered from before, the time at the pits. "It's true, I had intended for these people to kill the orc. After Colonel Warren and Gisela made it plain what had happened, I decided to bring him back here, expecting them to isolate and murder him again."

"But why?" This was Icon speaking.

"Why? I don't like the guy."

Ralph spoke up, "so why didn't you just kill him?"

"Oh, I hoped he'd cooperate. I didn't know he'd make giants to chase us down the mountain." Tyzmon was thinking. The room was ghastly silent. No one moved, except the large medical statue guy, analyzing Gisela's tissue. But that thing never made noise; it made it worse.

Radulf and Icon looked back and forth between each other and Tyzmon, finally, Icon said, "what did you hope he'd cooperate doing?"

"Cooperate, Icon?" Tyzmon's mind was spinning.

"You said, *you hoped he'd cooperate*, what were you going to do?" Icon's words came slowly and even at a lower volume.

"Oh, I know he's not the only orc left on Earth, in the *Inclusion Zone*. I thought we could use him to help us find the others." Tyzmon exhaled. He placed his hands on Gisela's face. Nothing, like before.

"What?!" It was Ralph, he shouted, the word seemed to echo, but it didn't. It was just that the memory of a shouted word in a dead-quiet room was a kind of an echo in the minds of the people there.

Icon changed the position of his feet, facing Tyzmon squarely, he was gesturing like a proto-human, saying, "you *knew* he wasn't the only one, so he's not the only one?" Icon dramatically put his hands on the sides of his head with a kind of double slap, "I tell you not to say anything and you practically tell as soon as there are people *to tell*, but then you keep a secret like this?"

"Well, I mean, certainly I didn't have any proof, I just think he's a liar. I lie all the time. Or, anyway, I did, before I met you," he was talking to Icon, "I suppose I have no reason to lie now and am probably out of practice. But it doesn't mean I can't recognize when someone is telling me what they think I want to hear." Tyzmon huffed, like a cough but just air, "can we concentrate. Please. On this problem. I'll tell you

everything you want to know another time, whatever is wrong with our friends ..." he stopped.

The room got spooky quiet again.

"OK, I couldn't kill the giant; Icon, your fire didn't appear to hurt the giant." Tyzmon's eyes weren't focused on anyone or anything, he was thinking out loud. "The only things that could hurt the giants were these peoples' – " he gestured, apparently including the whole village, or at least the hospital building itself, " – rifles, that dome-thing and Ralph's giant – thing."

Tyzmon scratched his nose, lowered his hood and put a hand on the back of his neck. "Wait, you said I was crying?" He had turned and was addressing Radulf.

Radulf nodded, but Tyzmon grabbed his arm. Tyz pressed a finger against his own eye, then pressed it into Ralph's forearm. "What the ..."
But Radulf didn't finish the thought.

Nothing happened. Nothing happened at all.

It may take several hours, he thought. "It may take several hours."

Radulf looked at his forearm. An orange flashing light and a kind of bird-like call came from the machine the statue medical man was using. The alarm was shut off, the space-suited, quiet statue turned around and lifted both hands, pointed at Tyzmon, swung an arm. *Come here.*

Why do medical personnel like such large empty rooms, thought Tyzmon, thinking of the soldiers' infirmary tent. He, followed closely by Ralph and Icon, walked the three dozen paces to the machine, to the quiet statue.

"She seems to be contaminated with bio-matter extracted from an orc."

Tyzmon noticed a speaker on the side of the statue's head, turned and saw another speaker on the other side. The suit made the wearer speak in stereo. Tyzmon suddenly wanted to speak in stereo.

"Can you test the others?" This was Icon, since Tyzmon seemed to be far away, staring at the medical-space-suit-robot-statue.

"I can and it is done." This may have been the first positive communication between Icon and one of the archaic humans in hundreds of millions of years. "They all have it, the same oxidized—by our standards—carbon bio-matter. She has it the worst and it appears to have entered her mouth." Unable to gesture effectively inside the suit, with Tyzmon daydreaming of being a large robot, no one understood these words. Icon and Radulf did understand that the test was run and they were all positive for orc *stuff*.

Icon shook Tyzmon gently, then not so gently. "Tyzmon!"

"Yes, orc matter contaminating the people I've revived." *I think I know how, but I don't understand why.* To the space-suit, "can we have it removed?" *Can it be isolated, sucked out?* Tyzmon didn't know what he said and what he simply thought really loud. He wasn't gesturing, either, so that didn't help.

"Do you have test animals, here, in your facility?" Tyzmon's voice was airy, like a dream filtered through an exhaust fan.

"What?" The statue seemed surprised.

"I want to kill a test animal, do you have one?"

"That wouldn't be ethical, Tyzmon." The stereo-speaking robot sounded shocked, as much as a robot statue can ever sound shocked.

"Can you get out of that suit? I'm pretty sure you're safe." Tyzmon was

saying.

Icon shook his head, held up his hands, pulled Tyzmon away from the suited figure. He whispered into Tyzmon's ear, "I do not think you should kill this guy and revive him to make a point."

"Gal."

"What?"

"The medico in the suit is female."

"You would notice that," Icon spit the words, then said, "I think you're planning to murder the person in the suit, whatever their sex."

"I can revive her." Tyzmon's voice was small, almost a child.

"On the mountain, you were emotionally broken in half over the deaths of soldiers, you went from body to body reviving them. You were crying about the pain you had caused; your arrogance. And now you want to arrogantly cause more pain?"

"If she volunteers?"

"Tyzmon? Think of another way to do whatever it is that you are thinking of doing."

The space suit said something but only Tyzmon could understand, so he paid attention: "we can't remove the stuff, guys. We can filter it – " An awkward giant-mechanical-hands gesture for 'filter', " – but we can't ..." a moment's silence, "... remove it."

Tyzmon's look of shock wasn't even the most shocking thing, he literally turned white, even the clothes he was wearing, a bright white. Tyzmon dropped the Tyzlane Staff. He took a step back, then clutching his abdomen, heaved, turned and vomited onto the shiny hospital floor. He

fell to his knees, heaving, dripping, vomiting. He collapsed into the vomit and was still.

The statue touched a button on her face-shield. "Please bring Apollonia Laurentia to the hospital, we think it's safe for her to enter the biohazard room."

Custodian droids, small cantaloup-sized spheres, were congregating around the vomit puddle and Tyzmon's body. He still wasn't moving, but they busied themselves cleaning the floor. Tyzmon's body was lifted onto a gurney and wheeled over to lay next to Gisela. The metal balls were gone as suddenly as they'd appeared.

Tre: Blender

Icon and Radulf came to Tyzmon's bedside. The statue-suit opened in the back and a long-haired, dark-skinned proto-human extracted herself. She joined them; but not as silently as she would have in the suit.

"Icon," Tyzmon said, weakly, opening his eyes with a flutter, "bring me a bird." He reached to Radulf who took his arm and helped him up. Tyzmon shook his head, took a breath and jumped down from the gurney. Icon was already exiting the room.

"Tomika," the proto-human said to Tyzmon, putting out a hand. Tyzmon took her hand in his, "I didn't mean I was going to kill you. My brother thinks I'm a monster, even when I show that is not true. He is still jealous of me, but it makes him a better person." He smiled and Radulf blushed.

Radulf said, "Now I'm going to be sick."

Tyzmon and Tomika ignored him, dancing in each other's eyes.

Ralph exclaimed, "she's a fossil!" To which Tyzmon shot him a dirty look.

And I'm an alien, and you're a dead assassin. But no one could hear Tyzmon's thoughts. "She's not a fossil," Tyzmon did say. Then in the proto-language, "where are you from?"

"Not that far, Tau Ceti, there is a large, Goldilocks zone, planet there, with three satellites, two natural, one man-made, settled by *first travelers* almost a quarter of a billion years ago. The planet itself is too large for humans like us, *seconds and fourths* are more comfortable there, but none of the Earth's intelligent people stay for very long, the gravity alone ..." She suddenly stopped talking, Tyzmon was staring at her mouth. She blinked significantly, he took one of her hands.

Radulf's shock may take longer to wear off, he was still staring with a slightly less than literal dropped jaw. He couldn't understand what Tomika was saying, and in fact, didn't yet even know her name. He fidgeted.

Tyzmon noticed. "Ralph?" Then he misunderstood and said, "right, impolite of me, she's telling me about the humans. You belong, I think, to a kind of fifth wave of people on this planet. These people, he raised his chin in Tomika's direction, are the first, if I'm understanding correctly." His face turned, he spoke to her, then, once again addressing Radulf, "yes, there are five distinct groups. They're not the same species. They don't really have a lot in common. Intelligence and the two legs, bipedalism." *Come to think of it*, "you aren't a lot different – from my perspective."

Ralph's eyes narrowed, "how would you even know?" *He said it with a kind of challenging tone.*

But this awkward moment was interrupted when a group entered the

room followed by Icon, carrying something on his back. When Radulf turned back to the gurney, Tomika and Tyzmon were sitting on it in each other's arms looking into and touching each other's faces.

Icon saw this, shrugged, more in his mind than with his actual shoulders, walked to Radulf and handed him a net full of black rocks. Ralph was happy to interrupt the display on the gurney, he cleared his throat, and when that didn't work, he punched Tyzmon in the arm.

"Oh, my birds!" Tyzmon said, stroking Tomika high on the inside of her leg, she giggled. Ralph turned away, he was looking rather pale.

Tyzmon smiled, moving both his hands to her face, he circled her ears with his long fingers. From her perspective, of course, he was simply a tall handsome man. Tyzmon said, "what happened to the orc's body?"

One of the archaic humans stepped forward. She was wearing some kind of ornamental gown, a costume from half a billion years ago, apparently. No one here would remember and probably it wouldn't have been appropriate back then either. Or maybe it would.

"My name is Apollonia Laurentia, I lead the security staff here at the museum." She did not gesture, except for touching her chest with her closed hand when she said 'I'.

"We were led down the mountains into this sulcus, but I didn't see where the orc's body went." Tyzmon said it like he was reading it from a page to no one in particular. He had twisted his body and was facing Tomika. His hands were on her breasts, her face was glowing a kind of warm pink. She didn't stop smiling, pressing his hands, but not moving them. She leaned forward with a sigh, pushing Tyzmon's hands onto her shoulders. He returned to playing with her hair and ears.

Other proto-humans were reacting in a fashion similar to Ralph, blushing,

some turning away or giggling like children. Tyzmon hopped down from the gurney then helped Tomika down—an unnecessary, but gallant gesture. He stood behind her, pressing against her body. Over her ear, he said, “bring me the orc?” He said it as though he'd already said it and they didn't hear him or were confused about their instructions.

Apollonia pointed at one of her team who left the room. Then, deciding something, she said, “Tyzmon.” He looked at her, but held Tomika with one arm, pressing their bodies together, she made a slight moan.

Apollonia continued, “you may want to focus your efforts?” She exhaled, apparently uncomfortable, “you two –” she stopped, looked down and to the side, then continued, “you two can do what you need to do, but –”

Tomika turned suddenly to Tyzmon, took his other hand and led him to a small door beyond all the beds containing sick soldiers. They went inside.

Icon placed the net with the four black rocks the size of his fists onto the now empty gurney. He scratched his head, unsure how to communicate with the humans. He took a breath, tapped a metal edge with a thumbnail, it made a surprising noise and a spark. Everyone looked at him. *We need to put the orc stuff onto these birds. When Tyzmon comes back, he'll touch the birds. They'll recover. This bird,* he wasn't talking, just gesturing, *he'll revive then we'll splash the orc fluid onto it.* He looked at the faces of the people, even Radulf seemed baffled. *Didn't your people have translation fucking machines!* “I thought you guys had machines that translate?”

“I don't know where they are, we didn't bring them with us.” Ralph was shaking his head.

“It occurred to no one that we may need them?” Icon couldn't believe it. *Your people are going to die out.*

There was noise outside the main door to the room. Some loud proto-language and a grunt-like sound. Apollonia said, "let them pass." Icon and Radulf could only assume that's what she said.

Three males wearing some pretty impressive armor entered pushing a closed – *possibly metal* – box on a dolly with large wheels. They stood it up and without hesitation, ran back out of the room pushing aside and knocking down the person who had been sent to get them.

Icon separated his birds: *This one gets revived like normal. This one gets revived then dipped in orc grease. These two get dipped first, then revived and this one, gets dipped again after that.* Four birds, four experiments.

He gestured around the birds with his fingers and Apollonia seemed to understand, she said something unintelligible and the same soldier from earlier left the room again. The archaic humans were talking to each other in small groups; Icon and Radulf stood without anything to do. This could also have been a party, but there was no food, pastel or otherwise, in sight. An awkward party.

Twenty minutes later, the man came back carrying one of the orbs, it could have been one of the janitorial robots or one of those dome-trap-things. He placed the sphere on the gurney with Icon's birds. The proto-humans continued talking and Icon and Ralph continued to stand awkwardly.

Eventually, Tyzmon, naked, emerged from the small supply closet. Tomika, wearing slippers and nothing else, came behind him, her back straight, proud. Neither of them seemed aware they were naked in a room full of people. Icon gestured to his brother who looked down at his chest, turned, took Tomika's arm and pulled her back to the closet. The door closed and a minute later, it opened. They weren't wearing the

clothes they were wearing when they went in. They were wearing matching medical coveralls and smiles.

"OK, you've got the birds, you've got the orc?" Tyzmon announced, his bare feet slapping conspicuously against the shiny floor. "This may be a bit messy, I'm afraid."

Some of the proto-humans pushed the metal box over to the gurney, lowered the dolly backwards and opened the box. There was a large plastic bubble filled with liquid.

Tyzmon stepped back when Icon pointed. He put out his hand and Radulf instinctively handed him the small silver knife. Icon punched the knife into the orc-bag and the stench filled the room, a few of the less stoic proto-humans coughed or cleared their throats.

Tyzmon stood on the other side of the gurney, touched the *control* bird and when it was clear that the bird was alive, and as Tyzmon was moving back, one of the archaic humans touched the orb and a small dome covered the gurney and extended to the floor. Then he, himself, and Tyzmon were inside the dome along with Radulf and Icon.

Icon touched two dead birds with the knife which dripped orc ooze onto the gurney. He moved back. Tyzmon touched the forth bird and the two *contaminated* birds. As one of the contaminated birds started to move, Icon dripped more orc sludge onto it. He wiped the knife against some of the soft bedding on the gurney and handed it back to Radulf.

All four birds were very alive and animated, they squawked and hopped, there wasn't enough room for them to take flight, but they bumped against the dome and landed, hopping onto the floor. One of them immediately started acting strangely and stopped hopping and lay down, its noises ceased. Two other birds were also exhibiting symptoms but

they hadn't stopped moving. Except for one, they all appeared to have been shot out of the sky with a fireball. Singed feathers, burns to the flesh underneath, but they were alive.

Tyzmon said, "now it gets tricky." Tomika, apparently abandoning her slippers somewhere, perhaps barefoot solidarity, was pushing a machine on a metal table. The other proto-humans, the ones who recognized it sighed a kind of shocked noise that caught in the throats of those who heard it and they also choked up a little. Apollonia ordered them all out with a grunt and a gesture. Then it was four birds, Apollonia, Tomika, Icon and Radulf and Tyzmon in the room.

Apollonia said, "you have to liquify them?" The awe in her voice hit its peak with the middle syllable of 'liquify'. Her gestures made her meaning crystal clear. Tomika said nothing, Tyzmon said, "we can't extract the contaminants." He looked at Gisela's prone body, looked down, finally, "but we can filter it out."

Tomika made a clicking noise with her mouth. She pointed at a couple buttons and said something to Apollonia who said, "you're leaving?"

Tomika said, as much to Tyzmon as to Apollonia, "I can't be part of this, I understand what needs to be done, and why, and that we're doing it for the greater good, but killing animals and," she swept her arm to include the soldiers on the beds, "these people, I can't do it."

Had Icon understood her he would have said something sarcastic about Tyzmon not having these problems.

One of the birds was, apparently, fine. The non-moving bird on the floor was lifted by Icon who immediately cooked and killed it in his hand. He did the same with the less damaged other two birds. He caught and killed the control.

Apollonia walked into the dome and touched the sphere. Tomika was getting into her shiny white, metal statue-suit.

She had tears on her cheeks.

One by one, the birds were placed into the blender device, and a thick bird-goop was retrieved into a glass canister. The four canisters were taken to Tomika who put them into a slot in the wall where, after a moments buzzing and flickering of lights, they were removed, apparently unchanged.

Tyzmon took each of the canisters in turn and poured the contents with one hand onto the other and before it splashed onto the floor, it was a bird which landed on its feet and began hopping around.

Tomika was getting out of her medical-space-suit before the last bird was revived successfully. Icon was counting seconds, but it seemed pretty clear that the procedure had worked.

Neither Tomika nor Apollonia seemed the least surprised by Tyzmon's ability to revive these creatures... Apollonia had been on the mountain and had seen Tyzmon reviving soldiers; but not Tomika.

Tomika gathered the birds and kind of herded them toward the main door where she managed to get them outside. She turned, giving Tyzmon a significant look. She reached up for a jacket and putting an arm into a sleeve; she left the room.

Tyzmon said to Apollonia, "now these guys." He gestured and Icon began going bed to bed apparently burning major organs of the afflicted—and, *thankfully*, sedated—soldiers, ending again, with Gisela. A tear dripped from Tyzmon's chin onto one of his bare feet.

The procedure of filtering the humans' remains was more difficult than

what was done for the birds. For one thing, obviously, their bodies were much larger, and they didn't have Tomika's help this time. But eventually, they managed to liquify and filter all the bodies. And as soon as a cylinder the size of a small barrel was removed from the machine, Tyzmon reached over the edge and touched the surprisingly thin fluid inside. Gisela, again, was last.

Apollonia had helped Icon remove the clothing from the bodies after he killed them earlier and when they were revived, their clothes were handed over. They were adult-sized naked children glistening, shiny; covered in what could have been sweat.

Icon thought about when Tyzmon revived the orc-creature. They had to go outside, there was thunder, and wind.

***He'd have to remember to ask Tyzmon about this
sometime.***

Icon, trying the gestures again, and awkwardly, too, the proto-language, managed to convey to Apollonia that what they needed now was alcohol.

If hope for something better was a figurative metric common to humanity throughout the ages, alcohol production and consumption was a literal one.

Fire: Diaspora alpha

There was much talk among the now, apparently whole patients and non-affected soldiers. Tomika had returned, Tyzmon, Icon, Ralph and Apollonia Laurentia left the room in the capable hands of hospital staff and the epsilon soldiers, recently recovered and otherwise. They—these half-dozen-minus-one—walked across the grounds of the museum to a kind of bar where Dave was a kind of bartender.

Except that he constantly acted like he was already drunk, Tyzmon couldn't get drunk and Tomika only drank a kind of sweet bluish water. Apollonia drank a cedar-colored liquid that Icon strongly suspected was more flammable than he, himself, was. Tyz, Icon and Radulf had øl.

Tyzmon got to translate, and the conversation was a slightly more awkward version of the following:

"They're all OK then?" This from Apollonia.

Icon sipped his øl, "for now anyway, but, I think it worked." He lifted his glass, a kind of salute; he dipped his head in Tomika's direction and took a big drink.

Tomika giggled, Tyzmon was touching her under the table. She said, "what do you think is happening when they," – she gestured: *fingertips birds' wings* – "get restored?"

Apollonia started to say something but Tyzmon said, "I think time works differently around me. And, and Icon, too. I'm not sure why I can revive people or do other things I can do and, for example, Icon cannot. I only know that our father said or did something that separated us." He repeated for Ralph and Icon.

Icon remembered the comm device, said to Radulf, "do you think we can talk to Warren?"

Ralph said, "oh," he touched his earlobe, moving his finger around the side of his ear, folding over the pointy tip, touching the comm device attached there, "you really forget you're wearing them."

Tyzmon and the females were speaking the proto-language and Radulf instructed Icon to use the radio. "It's a little tricky, and it takes some getting used to, but ..."

Icon pushed a contact behind his ear.

He said, "Warren?"

"This is Colonel Warren, hello, Icon. How's the mission proceeding?"

"We've had a couple," he paused, thinking of the appropriate words, settled on one, "snags, but everyone seems fine. We're in the village. It's not a village. It's some kind of museum, gift shop. It's difficult to explain."

"I'm sure. Is there anything I can get for you?"

"Those translation machines," Icon made it sound as much like a question as possible.

"You need to talk to the orc?"

"I need to talk to these archaic humans." Icon's voice was matter-of-fact and he was about to say something sarcastic about how they should have come prepared but the colonel was talking.

"... you need to use Rosetta, um, *the zero protocol* ..." He stopped, then said, "is anyone else there, someone who can look at your ear?"

"Ralph is here." Icon nodded to Radulf who touched his ear.

"I'm here," Radulf said.

Colonel Warren told him what to do and signed off. Radulf adjusted Icon's comm and Icon adjusted Radulf's comm. Then they could understand the proto-humans. *Why the fuck didn't he tell us this stuff at the meeting!?*

Icon shook his head with frustration.

Apollonia was saying, "... those original people, the alpha group, the Earth people like Tomika, Dave," she turned to look at the bartender, "and *everyone* here," she was gesturing, "and myself, left the planet half a billion years ago, they—we expanded into the galaxy."

Apollonia continued, "it was empty, mostly, back then. Roughly a hundred million years later, a second wave of bipedal intelligent people left Earth and found their distant cousins and ancestors among the stars of the Milky Way." Apollonia swallowed some of her toxic beverage, then taking a breath, continued. "Between heavy gamma radiation from exploding stellar masses and the infrequent asteroid strikes, the Earth is mostly wiped out every hundred million years or so. Another hundred million years is long enough for an individual species to find domination of the planet by way of intelligence. In Earth's case—so far anyway—they've always been bipedal, land dwellers. The forth wave, *delta people*, hopped into galactic citizenship a hundred and thirty-five million years ago." She smiled, sipped her drink.

"Epsilon people," Apollonia turned to Ralph, sighed, "epsilon people don't seem interested in space at all, and, it's a shame, because they didn't have religion and superstition holding them back, they're just not interested." She seemed tired, sighed, "they are, though, overdue."

Tyzmon was nodding along and had apparently forgotten that he was supposed to be translating.

Ralph said, "Who or what is religion?"

Tyzmon laughed, Tomika shifted suddenly in her chair and Apollonia, looking as though she had received a shock, said, "*You speak Galaksia*

Normo?"

Icon cut in, "We talked to someone on the comm," he turned so she could see his ear-piece, "and the comm is now translating for us."

Tyzmon turned to his brother, his face said, *show me*. Icon leaned forward, touching the ear-piece gingerly, then he sat back, Tyzmon said, "I'll have more øl." *Wow*.

When it came, Tyzmon said, "you didn't say that the third wave left the planet or what-ever. Where are they, or did it skip a cycle?"

Tomika said, "oh, those guys. The Gammas." She stopped, seeming thoughtful. She put her hands palm-down on the table, fingers open, said, "no one knows what happened to them. They were blue-green in color, and had webbing. They were incredibly intelligent, more so than any of the other groups."

"No one knows what happened to them," she repeated after a thoughtful moment.

~

Later that evening, they discussed the location of the museum and the numbers of visitors. Apollonia and Tomika told them about how the atmosphere had changed and wasn't comfortable for alpha or even second-wave, *beta* humanity.

"But that doesn't even matter," sighed Tomika, "on account of the Sun." And she explained about how the Sun was getting bigger and the planet in general was too hot... "Only gamma, that is, third-wave, humans, and later can stand it now, and extant animals, of course. For the most part, that's why some animals only live in this area, these mountains and the valley below."

Apollonia was speaking almost before Tomika said 'below': "We have some ideas on how to fix it. That is, how to make it so we can live and tour Earth, the whole planet, again. But it would cause mass extinctions of the plants and animals here, this wave." She looked right at Radulf, "and your people, too, of course. So we stay in the valley and on the *Luna surfaco*."

Tyzmon thought about the Moon.

The Search For Scott

Chapter XI: Gisela's Mission

En: A big day

The biohazard ward had become a kind of barracks for Gisela's *retrieval team*, especially after their bizarre ordeal with *Orcsblood Syndrome*.

There were many more birds in this little crevasse, this *sulcus*, mini-valley, which, if it weren't for Gisela's impatience and military background, probably would have been a pleasant way for Tomika and Tyzmon to wake up.

Instead, there was a strong rapping at the door and, as his brother had done the day before, Gisela entered without a cue. "Big day, Tyz, big day."

He feigned sleepiness, "come back in six minutes."

Gisela had retrieved his uniform from the broom closet and threw his jacket at him. It hit his bare butt, where a sleeve made a kind of slap, which made Tomika giggle.

Tomika was already getting dressed and Tyzmon said, "fine, fine." He put an arm up, hand open and Gisela threw the remaining pieces of his outfit. Tomika slid past Gisela who noticed she had rips and bite marks in her clothes.

Gisela closed the door and leaned against it. Tyzmon stood up and put the rest of his clothes on. Gisela said, "we woke up and the lieutenant was gone, we had camped the night before, and actually had plans to investigate this *village* that day. I've requested your brother and a team from museum security to accompany us."

"We should bring Ralph, he's actually killed a giant." Tyzmon also thought

he was amusing.

Looking slightly down, she touched her ear, whispered something, said, "OK" then nodded at Tyzmon, "he'll be at the staging area." And seeing that he was ready, she grabbed his staff, opened the door and exited, Tyzmon followed.

The *staging area* was behind Tyzmon's little cottage. As they walked the several hundred meters where others were assembling, she said, "you live there?"

"I don't know, that's what they say. They say it's my room. I don't really remember it. I remember some of the items on the table, but maybe I don't. I'm a little confused about all this." Tyzmon's voice trailed off and she didn't even hear the last sentence. He took her elbow and they stopped, "my brother tells me I don't spend a lot of time here." Then he turned and they joined museum security.

Apollonia Laurentia clapped her hands together, "good morning!" She shook Tyzmon's hand, then turned to Gisela and looked up at her, "how are you feeling?" *If you looked closely, you would see that Apollonia was wearing one of the epsilon soldiers' ear piece comm units.*

Gisela, on her—what, now—third resurrection, said, "it's not like what you may think." She turned to Tyzmon, "whatever he's doing, you don't feel like you've been sick or out of action or whatever. It's like one moment then the next." She hesitated. "I know about the burns on my face, because I felt them, then it was like I was tired and then I was waking up in some kind of barrel, covered with water and having my clothes offered to me."

Apollonia said, "they added the water, or anyway, the machine did. That's what they told me."

Tyzmon gasped, "Oh! I did wonder about that, a little."

"Well, I've never met someone who's been blended and watered down and filtered before. Certainly a story most people can't tell their grandchildren." Apollonia put a hand up onto Gisela's shoulder, turned and joined her team. Over her shoulder, she said, "I've brought only the bare-bones team."

Radulf and Icon were coming up the hill with four soldiers. Gisela still had Tyzmon's staff and she handed it to him and walked down to meet the guys. "Do you really expect trouble?"

Icon said, "Even if we did, I'm not sure calling me would do any good. I don't know if you got to see it, but the giants were immune to my fire." They rejoined the group.

Apollonia was instructing her security team – *four people, all helmeted*. Gisela touched her ear, "can everyone hear me?" Apollonia turned and raised a hand, her subordinates also raised a hand. She muted the comm. To Ralph she said, "they're on loan." – *His brow was crinkled and he was pointing at his ear*. Tyzmon and Icon raised their hands and then Radulf, whose hand was up already, kind of waved, too.

Gisela and Apollonia looked at the maps—these were actual paper maps, because the archaic humans did not have access to the colonel's shares, drawings—"it's a two hour, two and a half hour hike, do you think?" Apollonia was saying to Gisela who nodded. "Let's go!" They said in unison.

Tyzmon, Ralph and Icon followed the four-member museum security team which, in turn, followed Apollonia and Gisela.

Checking that his comm was set to receive only, Tyzmon said to Radulf, "the giant orcs can lift and throw rocks, do you think it's the same?"

Radulf shrugged, "I hesitate to discuss it with these guys around us. I'd rather not be turned to goo."

Icon smiled and chuckled a little. "I don't think you're in any danger, Ralph."

The three of them talked like this for the journey. The security people were also talking amongst themselves. Gisela and Apollonia talked about the scenery, each other and Lieutenant Kanin Scott Lutèce. Gisela admitted that they still didn't know what had happened to him. Apollonia confirmed that the "orcs" did have some kind of disintegration weapon, but none of them had ever seen one. Gisela told her to ask Tyzmon if they wanted their people back, that he was "unlikely to say no."

And then things changed a little as they approached the location marked on the map.

To: Lieutenant Kanin Scott Lutèce

Gisela was disappointed that the map was wrong, but checked her share against her position and knew they were only a few hundred meters from their destination. She said, "some kind of transcription error, I guess; but it's up here." She started to recognize things almost immediately and was able to locate *the place* rather easily. "Here."

Tyzmon stepped forward and urged Gisela to back off. "When I found Ralph, I didn't know he was there." He took a careful step in the direction Gisela had indicated. "It seems like, I don't know, we can't be in the same place at the same time, so I get pushed aside. Sometimes shoved ..." He took another step.

Nothing happened. Nothing at all.

"Are you sure we're in the right place?" He asked, somewhat quietly. He

took another step, he should be standing over Kanin's body by now. He squatted, moved to touch the ground and was thrown backwards, flipped awkwardly and landed on his face on gravel, dry grass and stone. There was a thump as his staff fell. "Ow." He grunted. After a moment, he looked up.

A man lay peacefully where he was standing only moments before.

Tyzmon managed to squeak out, "is he still dead?"

Gisela stepped up to the body, squatted and placed her hand on his face.

"He's cold, he's not breathing."

Tyzmon took a deep breath, struggled a touch and then managed to stand up. His face was cut and bruised. He closed his eyes and shook his head. He stood next to Gisela and leaned over, taking Scott's head in his hands. Scott's eyes flickered, he took a breath, sighed. Tyzmon almost let go but wasn't sure the lieutenant was completely down from his shelf. "Kanin? Are you there? We're worried about you." Tyzmon was speaking in a kind of breathless whisper.

Kanin gasped, opened his eyes, focused on Gisela, said, "Deputy!?" Then he noticed that Tyzmon was holding his face, "*What the fuck happened!? I died. I died, didn't I?*" His mouth agape. Then, "answer me!" And, hastily, "don't lie to me."

Apollonia was standing at the lieutenant's feet, she tossed a small black pebble onto his chest. It was an ear piece, comm hardware. Tyzmon picked it up and placed it on Scott's ear.

Apollonia said, "What do you remember?"

"I spoke to Colonel Warren, where is he anyway?"

Lt. Kanin was alive.

Gisela immediately touched her ear, "Colonel? Yes. I'm happy to hear yours too. We got him. The L.T. is alive."

Radulf gestured at one of Apollonia's helmeted security people. The figure detached and handed him a bottle. Ralph leaned over, nudging Tyzmon with it. Tyzmon took the water and handed it to Scott, who said, "oh, thank you." He looked at Radulf, "thank you." Radulf nodded.

Gisela was still talking on the comm. She turned to look at Kanin as her hand went up and touched her ear, "The colonel wants to speak with you."

Tyzmon helped Kanin to his feet. He adjusted his comm, said, "Colonel?" A pause. "Yes. Thank you for sending her." A pause. "Oh." A pause. "*She* did." He looked at Gisela. "She did?" A pause. "OK, I'll let them know. Yes, you too, Colonel." He looked at Gisela, "Warren says we should head back?" *A question?*

Gisela touched her comm, "Retrieval team?" A pause. "Yes, meet us on the mountain, our loci is clearly marked. Bring the gear. We're going back."

It seemed a strange place for them to make camp, especially as it was still pretty early in the day. On one hand, it was the morbid loci where the lieutenant had died. On the other hand, it was a suitable location, considering it had been chosen before.

Apollonia shook Gisela's hand, turned to Kanin, "I wish you well." She turned and headed down toward the museum village; her team followed.

Tyzmon hastily slapped Scott on the back, "bring the colonel and another dozen people here in two days," only Kanin heard. Tyz turned to follow

the *strike force*. Ralph and Icon said their good byes as well, following Tyzmon down the hill.

Gisela and Kanin exchanged a glance. She shrugged, said, "he has a girlfriend."

Ninety minutes later, Tyzmon, Icon and Radulf returned to Tyzmon's cottage. Tyzmon went in while Icon and Ralph stayed outside talking in the Sun.

Tomika was laying on his cot nude, feigning sleep. Tyzmon turned, opened the door slightly, said "I'll meet you there," and closed it. Icon rolled his eyes, gestured. He and Radulf continued walking among the museum buildings. Passing the rest of Gisela's team, which was heading up, they stopped to wave.

Buttons and Buttoning

Chapter XII: Among the Alphas

En: Welcome to Tyzmon's

Tyzmon leaned his staff against the corner of the room closest to the door, adjacent to a long table containing numerous mysterious artifacts. These were facsimiles, duplicates of items he'd supposedly owned in his long long life. His cot, now occupied by the luscious Tomika, was hanging diagonally across the room. He hadn't noticed before, but there was a chest on the floor against the wall opposite the table. The wall across from the door contained two tall windows which were polarized and draped with curtains made from thick canvas.

He went to the chest and opened it. Tomika shifted in the cot, looking over the edge at him. In her eyes, *back to bed, Lover*. But he couldn't see her. Inside the chest was a gnarled branch with the same markings as his Tyzlane Staff, a jacket, loose-fitting pants, several belts, some thick cotton clothes—including underwear, at least a dozen balls of cotton which were socks in bundles and *boots*.

Tyzmon started to put the boots on. Tomika cleared her throat. Tyzmon abandoned that project and joined her on the cot.

~

Three hours later, there was a knock at the door and Icon entered. Tyzmon and Tomika were wrestling like puppies. Icon watched for a few minutes in amusement, fascination and, naturally, terror. He was surprised the cot didn't come loose from the ropes holding it to the ceiling. He cleared his throat. Tyzmon looked up, over Tomika's wet, sweaty body, shook his head, "I told you: I'll meet you *there*."

Icon went to the table and picked up the hourglass, pretended to study it, turned back to the cot, held it up, cleared his throat again when he realized they'd gone back to – whatever it was they were doing – when Tyzmon looked, Icon shook the hourglass, opened one eye wider, lowered his head.

Tyzmon said, “really?”

Icon said, “Tyzmon it's been hours, come on.”

Tyzmon looked at Tomika, sighed, looked back at his brother, turned toward the chest, “did you see my boots?” He returned his attention to Tomika who was cooing.

Icon crossed to the chest but the first thing he saw was the branch. *Tyzlane Staff*. He took it out of the chest, rubbed it with his hands. It wasn't a facsimile. It was *The Tyzlane Staff*. Icon turned back to the door where the other branch was leaning, *The Tyzlane Staff*. *What the helvede is going on here*, he leaned the *other* staff against the wall, bracing it against the chest so it wouldn't fall. “Yes, nice boots,” he said, even though he hadn't really seen them. He went to the door, took the Tyzlane Staff. He rubbed it.

It wasn't a facsimile.

Suddenly a few elements from the long long past fell into place. *No wonder. No wonder the staff managed to exist all this time*. He smiled inside as he decided to play a little game on his brother who was currently ignoring him anyway. “Tyzmon, now.” There were grunts from the cot. Icon placed the staff from the chest against the corner by the door and put the other one, the new one, onto the table, moving some items to make it look like it belonged there.

He turned back to the cot, knocked on the wall next to the door, "it's getting late. I don't think it'll take very long, and we should do this while it's still light." He heard a sigh from the cot and Tomika climbed to the floor, smiles and giggles. She had neatly folded her medical uniform on the floor between the two windows. She started getting dressed, but watched the cot as she did.

Icon said, "can you open the windows?"

She seemed startled that he was talking to her. "The curtains you mean?"

"Yes, I suppose, but can the windows be opened. You know, physically?"
In case you wonder, Icon no longer needed translation machines to talk to these humans, but he had the comm activated anyway, just in case.

"No, and it'd be kind of hard to break them. We take Tyzmon's security pretty seriously. Didn't they show you yours?" She raised an eyebrow.

Icon tried to make the same facial expression, but managed only to open one eye wider than the other, "mine?"

"Your house, your place." She was dressed now, she opened her arms as if to include the room around her. "Our instructions are to keep it up for you."

"How long have you been here?" Icon may have meant the whole museum.

"I've been here for two months, Earth time. There was an opening. I was finishing an Epsilon Anthropology degree, I don't have any family, I'm already a medical doctor, it sounded fun." Tomika shifted her hip, as if posing for something.

Icon scratched his head, "I mean, I meant, how long have *you all* been

here – this place, the museum, the hospital, all this,” he tried out his version of her all-inclusive gesture.

“Oh.” She seemed a little disappointed. “Thirty years, Earth time. Before there was nothing this elaborate. Only a sentry and an exposition team of scientists. They keep tabs on the gamma radiation, asteroids, distance the Moon ...” She stopped talking, looked at Icon with slightly squinted eyes, “you really look a lot like your brother. How much younger are you? Twenty years?”

Icon laughed, but to Tomika, it was a kind of squeaky white-noise, she did recognize it as a laugh. He said, simply, “he revived me.” She said nothing and her face didn't change, “I think, when a person or animal is revived, they go all the way back ...” He couldn't think of a word to convey his thoughts. He rubbed one wrist, then the other, “... for example, think of an animal. They're born, they get bigger and stronger. Then they start to get slower, older ...?” He said it uncertainly, but she nodded, so he continued. “What seems to happen, is that a person is revived back to before they start to get slower, maybe a half-dozen years.”

He had a sudden thought, “Tomika?”

She had gone back to watching Tyzmon who hadn't moved from the cot. She shook her head and looked at Icon, “Mm?”

“How old are you?” As he said it, he heard Tyzmon behind him swinging out of the cot.

“I'm not sure I should answer that question.” Tomika was being coy (?)

Icon sighed, turned to the long table of artifacts, grabbed a thin scallop-shaped pastel-purple object, he tossed it to her. Tomika caught it, fidgeted with it, there was a click, it opened. She looked and turned it

over, there was a small mirror and some stone powder. Tomika's eyes widened.

"The hell?!" She said.

"If I were to guess, I'd say you're seventeen," said Icon. He reached for the compact but she was staring at it and didn't notice his gesture.

Tomika was touching her face, her neck. Icon turned around and looked at Tyzmon, now dressed, and apparently looking through the stuff in the chest.

Tomika said something but Icon didn't hear. He turned back to her, she was holding out the purple thing. He took it, she said, *"it's a trick?"*

"No." He didn't know what else to say. He put the compact back on the table, letting his gaze fall on the *other Tyzlane Staff*. "Are we ready," he said, walking toward the door.

To: Alpha victims

As Icon had suspected, Tyzmon took the version of the *Tyzlane Staff* from the corner by the door without a second glance. He shook his head: *How had I never noticed that the stick wasn't the same stick twice?* He wondered who else knew.

Just a few steps outside Tyzmon's cottage, Apollonia, Radulf and a group of archaic humans met them. Indicating Ralph with her chin, she said, "he didn't want to wait any longer."

Radulf shrugged, *"I have met Tyzmon,"* he said with an edge to his voice. With a smile, Icon nodded.

Icon turned to Apollonia, "you've marked the locations?" She held up a binder and he took it. Then he thought again and handed it back to her.

"Lead the way," he said.

Standing on tiptoes, Tomika touched her nose and lips to Tyzmon's. She said, "gotta get back to the Talos," and left the group for the hospital and her barracks beyond. Icon imagined she skipped along with a certain youthful air, and maybe she did.

It did not take very long to locate the first victim. Apollonia was saying, "...actually, we were expecting a contingent of tourists that day. And were getting ready, the smaller creatures, those you call orcs, carry weapons that are really horrific. I understand your lieutenant had been exposed ...?"

Neither Tyzmon nor Icon said anything, so Radulf said, "that's what they said. It looked like a handle with a couple wires, silver polymer ... um ... plastic?"

"We thought they were metal. No one got a good look at one, I suppose. Anyway, seeing one close up may be the last thing anyone ever did." She chuckled, then frowned; she pointed and Tyzmon, apparently reluctant, stepped forward.

"Same weapon?" He said. Apollonia nodded. He crouched, arms up and turning a bit sideways, took a small step, then another. He inched forward with one arm out and the other up, almost blocking his face.

Apollonia said, "what's wrong?"

Icon laughed nervously; but Ralph said, "didn't you see what happened on the hillside – with the lieutenant?"

Her face changed. Apollonia's chin dipped in grave acknowledgment.

Tyzmon continued inching forward, suddenly there was a snap and a flash of ball lightning, he screamed, jumped back, clutching his forearm.

He shrieked, "it broke!" He screamed again, saying, "ow ow ow." Tears from his eyes, saliva from his mouth, Tyz dripped onto his boots. He rubbed his arm. He then appeared to recover his composure, at least. He grinned, opened and closed both hands.

Even though there had been a flash of light and whatever it was that broke Tyzmon's arm, there was no body, no person on the ground or anywhere nearby. He cleared his throat, stepped forward, looking more resolved.

Tyzmon put both hands out, as though he was going to hug someone, stepped up to and into the location where Apollonia had indicated. He appeared to be pantomiming pushing an invisible stone up a hill. His feet slipped against the paved, white, faux-stone roadway.

Nothing happened. Nothing happened at all.

Tyzmon was about to give up, he put his arms down, started to turn and, as though his legs were pulled from under him, he fell, hard, onto his hip. "The fuck?!" He said as he started to sit up.

But the drama was over. And there were three bodies laying on the road. Two men and a young woman – they were wearing costumes similar to the people who had been brought to the soldiers' camp before.

Apollonia helped Tyzmon up as Radulf and Icon went to examine the bodies. Radulf said, "did you know there were three?" Icon, and now Apollonia, were looking at the victims. She said nothing. They were dead. Tyzmon shooed them away. He sat on the road with the bodies and placed his hands on the necks of the males. They started to breathe, then to try to sit up, he held them down.

Apollonia said, "Joe?" There was a new sound in her voice, it caught

Tyzmon's attention and he turned to look at her. She said nothing and Tyz turned to the remaining body. He placed his hands on either side of her face.

Icon touched Apollonia's shoulder, "why are they dressed like that?" But she didn't respond, she was watching Tyzmon and the three people on the road as if her life depended on it. Nothing and no one else mattered. Behind her, museum personnel were pouring water into small cups.

The young woman choked a little as she was revived, but then she took a deep breath, let out a sigh, and said, "who's this?" She had taken Tyzmon's hands into her own. Icon and Ralph exchanged glances, Ralph stepped forward and lifted Tyzmon by the arm, pulling him away.

Icon said, "Tyzmon."

The young woman's eyes widened, she sat, then backed up, pushing herself away, she stood suddenly. "I ... I ..." she looked between Tyzmon and Icon, Apollonia and Radulf, "what ... what ...?"

The two men were less anxious, they were already standing and looking at Apollonia expectantly. "Something happened? It was morning." Joe said, pointing to the Sun.

"You were shot," Radulf blurted, "by an orc."

The female's mouth opened languidly, her eyelids fluttered. Apollonia gestured and another archaic human was immediately at the girl's side, he held up a small canister. Her eyes opened suddenly, she said, "yuck." But she seemed better. Someone handed her a cup with water.

The rest of the afternoon and part of the evening was spent like this, more or less. They – well, Tyzmon – revived nine archaic humans, half a dozen males and three females. Most of them were wearing their

“museum clothes” – the costumes.

Apollonia had a list, and now it was complete. Counting the three people sent up the hill, all dozen victims had been revived. Considering the overwhelming carnage in the valley proper, the museum staff had almost been spared.

Other than the usual thirst, these revived individuals didn't seem to have noticed anything was wrong. After a brief description of the events, they were left to continue their lives. None of them seemed willing to believe Tyzmon revived them from death, let alone from any kind of vaporized debris field.

Seeing is believing and not everyone saw.

Tre: The Daedalus Foundation

Apollonia disappeared after the last *alpha person* was revived and most of those museum employees who remained apparently went back to whatever they normally do. Icon, Radulf and Tyzmon stood in the growing dark with only two archaic humans and they seemed to be leaving. Icon grabbed one by the arm in a friendly way and whispered to him, the other man nodded and left with his companion.

“I asked him to send your girlfriend,” Icon said to Tyzmon. They found a kind of raised molded stone bench and sat along it. They discussed Tyzmon's powers and how his arm felt, how long it took for him to heal, *if it was healing.*

In less than five minutes, though, Tomika rejoined them, “gentlemen,” she said, waving from the long shadows of evening. Tyzmon stood up and crossed to her, but Icon and Ralph stayed seated. Tomika approached their location and shook hands, first with Radulf and then

with Icon. "You called?" She addressed Icon.

He said, "I'm sorry. Earlier you said I have a cottage or something?" When she didn't seem to understand, he continued, "we were talking about Tyzmon's windows and —"

Tomika cut him off, "oh, your place! You haven't been there? I find this almost as surprising as you seem to. The Daedalus Project papers make it sound like you built it yourself."

Radulf said, "Daedalus?"

Tomika shrugged, "our charter, this is Daedalus Museum #3," she used the same inclusive gesture that seemed to mean the entire planet, but could have just meant the village. "Without dictating the entire history of the region and museum and the Daedalus Foundation, which is freely available, I will say this. The Daedalus-Hertzprung field is what protects this region from celestial events, gamma rays, asteroid debris and secondary effects—such as blocking out the light from the Sun. We even have animals here that don't live anywhere else on Earth, they are unique. Some refer to this area as *New Madagascar*, but I'm unsure what that means; it just seems related to discussions of the animals here, especially the birds."

Tomika took a breath, made eye contact with Ralph, then Icon and finally Tyzmon who took her wrist and tugged her gently toward him.

She continued, "theory is, a high velocity impact occurred hundreds of millions of years ago, possibly as long as two billion years ago—as we have extracted irregular readings from the area. It is a giant bubble. It seems to be a chamber out of time and space. It's huge. If it were a structure, it'd be the biggest on the planet, it contains the entire area north and east of the bend in the coast where large cities always spring

up.”

She sighed, “I bore you? You want to see your cabin?” She turned, began walking away from Tyzmon's. Tomika said, “somehow I misunderstood, I thought you had been here before, both of you.”

Turning to Radulf, Tomika said, “if you're staying, we can make arrangements for you as well, like we did for their father when he was here.”

Icon turned ghost white, literally, translucent, smokey, but no one saw before he recovered. He did stop walking and Tyzmon stopped, then Ralph, then, and finally, Tomika. She faced him, “Icon?”

“He was here?” Icon's voice was barely audible.

Tomika shrugged, “yes, he was here. He was here when I arrived, in fact. We had a small festival when he left.” She hesitated, noticing, apparently for the first time, Icon's expression. “That was two months ago.”

Icon felt bolted to the ground. His eyes glued to the archaic human doctor from the golem-device, the giant machine. “He was here?” He said. Tomika said nothing, if she were Tyzmon, she may have blinked repeatedly, instead, her impressive patience.

Tyzmon turned to his brother, pulled him close and whispered something that Ralph could hear in the comm, but couldn't understand. When Tyzmon released his brother from what appeared to be a hug, Icon was weeping.

Icon said to Tomika, “he doesn't know, and I think you may not know. I feel I should warn you about our father.” He looked significantly at Tyzmon, “I always got a strong feeling he wasn't telling me everything.”

He squinted. "I ... I don't know." He put out his hands and made gestures as he spoke almost as though he were an alpha human, "it was a certain tone of voice, a certain look in his eyes. It was as though he was playing some kind of game." He turned to Tomika, "let's go there first, I want to see Macmillan's house first."

She said, "you call him Macmillan?"

Icon hesitated, held up a hand, to distract Tyzmon and keep him from speaking, "why? What does he call himself?"

Tyzmon broke in, "how do you know he is our father, anyway, if he isn't Macmillan, maybe he isn't *our Macmillan*?"

Tomika snorted, laughed, turned, gestured grandly with her arm – *follow me*. She said, "he looks just like you, that's how." She took several steps before continuing, "he looks just like both of you. You could be pictures from his personal album." She sighed as though they were playing a childish game and it was wearing on her.

Icon said, "he looks older than Tyz, then?"

Tomika stopped, turned around, "yes, of course. I don't know what you're trying to do, but pretending you don't know about your father is –"

Tyzmon cut her off, "he's not pretending. And I don't remember. And Ralph here," he gestured, including them all, "doesn't know anything at all of our family." Tyzmon moved to her side, said, "humor us if you don't believe me." Took a breath, said, "you didn't tell us his name."

"Well, *Daedalus*, of course. Come on then." She resumed walking. The three guys followed her.

It seemed they were going to leave the village behind them when they came upon a small cottage, still, bigger than Tyzmon's. It was round with

evenly spaced windows, no apparent door. It was tall, too, and had what appeared to be a thatched roof containing a small window peeking out between the reeds or sticks of its construction.

With enough light left in the day to see by, but barely, Tomika clapped both her hands twice in rapid succession and the area was immediately filled with light. She smiled. "This is Daedalus magic, your father's technology, these lights." She spun around, looking up and the light cast on her face was very bright.

Ralph walked up to the building and felt the light on his skin as you feel the Sun. "It's warm," he said, voice soft with wonder. He looked for an opening to the building. Tomika seemed to be enjoying the light as a tired traveler enjoys a warm Autumn shower.

Tyzmon began to walk toward the building but Icon took his arm, when Tyz turned, his brother was shaking his head.

"Where's the door?" This from Icon.

Tyzmon abruptly pulled free of his brother and walked up to Tomika who shrieked and fainted. Under the light, Tyzmon was, indeed, a lizardman.

Shaking his head, Icon placed a hand on his own face. He sighed, walked into the light as Radulf was turning around. Icon lifted Tomika into his arms, heard Ralph's exclaimed exhale of air behind him, carried her out of the light. "Tyzmon! Come."

Icon placed Tomika down. "Ralph, look for the entrance outside the light, I suspect there is another building or perhaps an underground tunnel."

Radulf smiled, seeing his friends in their true form was an unexpected surprise. On a whim, he clapped his hands together twice in succession. The area slowly darkened.

Tyzmon came over to Icon and Tomika, "what happened to her?"

"She saw you without the camouflage. Didn't you see when I picked her up?" Icon didn't bother to hide the irritation from his voice.

"Let me see?" Said Tyzmon as he pulled his brother from Tomika. Icon came, a bit reluctantly. Tyzmon looked around, looked at his brother, shrugged, "I see nothing."

Icon clapped his hands twice. The light returned. Had he been looking, Radulf would have seen two lizardmen arguing about listening and being bossy like brothers, very young brothers, everywhere from the beginning of time. But he wasn't, he was busy looking for another building or a hatch or trap-door on the ground. He found what looked like a poured stone shed, at a kind of terrible angle for a shed, with double-doors.

Under the light, Icon and Tyzmon were arguing. Or Icon was arguing and Tyzmon was being himself, which is to say cold and matter-of-fact but presenting no excuses, making no promises or defenses. "What do you think they did?" Tyzmon asked, interrupting his brother's verbal sparing.

Icon took a breath, sighed quietly, decided to let it go. "I'm not sure. But I highly doubt Macmillan would stand in this place, activated or not."

"So he wasn't here?" Tyzmon was thinking the situation through. "Who would pretend to be our father?"

"It's not even a question, Tyz. Who *could* pretend to be our father." They were both quiet, then Icon said, "and after all this time?" It was likely rhetorical.

"So Macmillan is or is not alive and out there somewhere, after all this time." Tyzmon's voice came almost mechanically. "... Or someone who

wants us to think it's him. He's been here, right here. He or someone else installed a machine that can disrupt our camouflage." Tyzmon was ticking these things off on his long, scaly green fingers. "And he's calling himself Daedalus." He clapped his hands twice. Again the light faded.

Icon began knocking against the side of the building, turning his face and listening as he struck it.

Tyzmon returned to Tomika, knelt and touched her gently on the forehead. She opened her eyes, saw him, screamed, tried to move, striking her head several times on the ground – *it was soft and covered with an artificial grass*. She rolled, managed to get feet on the ground, got up and ran away. Slowly, as he watched her go, Tyzmon scratched his chin, his jaw. He lowered his hood and rubbed the back of his neck.

"Guys!" *Radulf may have said it more than once.*

Tyzmon ran in the direction of Ralph's voice and Icon continued tapping the side of the building.

Icon stopped circling the building, focusing instead on a specific area. The windows were otherwise spaced evenly, but this location seemed to break the pattern and, the knock-noise was different. He started placing his hands against the wall and moving them up and down looking for a seam or a latch or switch.

The door opened and Radulf was standing before him.

"Hello." Radulf laughed. Tyzmon was behind him, looking at a bookshelf that spanned the entire interior.

While Radulf and Tyzmon were impressed with the books, the shelves of books, Icon looked for a way to go upstairs. There was a section of books on a shelf about as high as a man's abdomen which seemed to

follow a pattern after a room full of books of all colors and sizes and no pattern. Icon removed them and was rewarded with a machine, not a bare shelf wall as one would expect. "Guys, look," he said, but then began pulling the machine away from the wall. There were coils of soft tubes and flat ribbons that appeared to be multicolored wires pressed together and flattened. The machine didn't come all the way out of its cubbyhole.

As Tyzmon and Radulf watched, Icon activated the machine. There was a loud scraping noise that seemed to come from the walls themselves. It felt like the building shook. By the time the three had managed to brace themselves, it was over.

It was immediately apparent that the shelves had re-arranged as a result of Icon's tinkering. They were now a kind of spiral, or pattern, as though half-pulled from the wall. There were four pieces, and in spite of artfully working around the door and windows, they formed a convincing whole when closed, but were four semi-circles when opened. The room was, as a consequence, minutely smaller. Icon inspected the area behind the shelves and the opening nearest the door revealed what he expected, stairs. He went up, pushing the ceiling and opening a hidden door in the process.

Radulf and Tyzmon did not follow him up. They were taking down books and opening them somewhat haphazardly, randomly. Ralph said, "I can read some of these."

"I can read them all, or anyway, all the books I've opened so far, I can read," said Tyzmon, absently, distantly. He had stopped randomly plucking books and was standing holding one book, carefully in one hand, turning the pages with the other.

There were noises outside, voices.

Radulf went to the door. It was Apollonia and a few other archaic humans. Tomika was among them.

Tomika saw Ralph and moved to the front of the group, pushing Apollonia aside almost as though she wasn't there. The look on her face prompted Radulf to point over his own shoulder, into the building. Tomika turned, slipped past him and was inside. Tyzmon was still reading, but was fast running out of pages.

Tomika waited for Tyzmon to finish.

Apollonia and Radulf nodded to each other, he shrugged, she shrugged, he gestured for her and her people to come in. She did, they didn't.

Tyzmon finished the book, put it carefully back on the shelf. He didn't seem to know anyone else was in the room, he started putting the books from the floor back onto the shelves, then he was pushing the machine back into place and put the books Icon had removed back.

He stood, turned around, and noticed Radulf as though for the first time, *the soldier*. "You're the soldier," he said.

Radulf looked quickly at Apollonia then back to Tyzmon, "yes. And you revived me and," a moment passed.

"And we've had this conversation before."

Tyzmon said, "yes, you met Icon and me at the fire, he gave you roast fowl. We discussed your life, there were falling boulders ..." His voice trailed off, his eyes were filled with tears. He was moving his mouth, but no words came out, he sort of squeaked, instead. Radulf's heart broke, or that's what I'd say, he stepped over and took Tyzmon into his arms

and hugged the taller man.

"I'm OK now. It's OK now." Radulf wondered what the fuck was in that book.

Ralph disentangled himself from Tyzmon who seemed to have stopped crying. Tomika pushed between them and touched Tyzmon gently on the neck, on the cheek. "I'm sorry, Tyzmon." I'm pretty sure she was sincere. "I only distantly knew you weren't human." She leaned forward, tilting her head, "I didn't handle that very well, did I?"

Tyzmon said nothing. Tomika placed a hand on his chest, her other hand looped under his arm to take his shoulder, she pulled herself up, tiptoes, placing her forehead against Tyzmon's throat. Tyzmon said, "I'm sorry, we need my brother." He turned to the stairway, made a noise like the most piercing whistle you could ever have nightmares of hearing and said, "Icon! I need you."

Icon came down the stairs, he had a dark blue book under his arm, there was a shiny gold tassel dangling from it. "Yes, I understand." Icon started ushering people out, "come on."

Outside, Tyzmon and Icon stood together. Tyzmon said, "if you see our father again, try to get him to stand under this light." He clapped his hands, he and his brother were illuminated from an unseen source. They were identical lizardmen wearing different clothes. He clapped his hands again. "It'll be obvious, you'll find, if he's not who he says he is?" It sounded like a question. Tyzmon said to Tomika, "take us to my brother's house."

Fire: The Firehouse

Icon's house was much closer to *Daedalus's* than either of them were to Tyzmon's. Icon's cabin resembled Tyzmon's almost completely. It was

much bigger. Whereas Tyzmon's cottage was a room with walls to contain it, in a kind of rustic picturesque way, it seemed to come out of both the past and a child's imagination. Icon's was a variation on that theme, but was obviously several rooms, built on three levels, around a large tree.

Icon did not recognize it.

Ralph clapped his hands, nothing happened and Tomika and Apollonia snickered. "He doesn't have that." One of them said.

"I wouldn't want it," Icon was saying, "but I don't recognize this place, this architecture."

Tyzmon spoke: "You built it, but you haven't built it yet. You built mine too, but you haven't built it yet either."

Ralph scratched his head as though a script called for him to do it, he said, "now you're talking in riddles."

"No. Yes, yes, but no. Not riddles. The book I was reading details certain events which suggest that people can travel in time." He squinted, then closed his eyes hard, tilting his face forward. "You told of a man who taught you to throw fire," he was looking at his brother, "in the book, his name is Pip, you called him Philip." Tyzmon turned to Apollonia, "did our father have a man with him, a man who, perhaps, prefers green?" She didn't move, he gestured in Ralph's direction, "the way he likes purple?"

"The Green Man?" Apollonia and Tomika said it almost in unison. And they were echoed by Icon himself. He was holding up the dark blue book, on the cover was a man, almost a lizard himself, a blue-green, but wearing a leaf-colored shawl and nothing else.

Icon read the title of the book, "Welcome to the Mist." Then, after a moment, "The Guiding Hand."

Tyzmon said, "I think we are responsible for the light. At our father's place. I think you invented it, Icon. I think you invented it and installed it. I know it wasn't me and I doubt anyone else would." Tyzmon gestured to Radulf and the three of them went into Icon's house.

Tomika, Apollonia and the few other archaic humans stood outside a little unsure what to do. Tyzmon opened the door and said, "just give us a moment."

They were inside for less than ten minutes. Apollonia and her people were discussing time travel and were saying that it was impossible. "But other things are also impossible," Tomika said, "for example, giants and dragons."

When the door finally opened, it was Ralph, he came outside and closed the door behind him slowly descending the stairs. His head was spinning, unconsciously, he was rubbing the softer-than-soft handle of the purple blade. *Could it all have been orchestrated? And even if it could be, to what end? And why me?*

Icon opened the door, stepped out and Tyzmon was behind him. They were wearing different clothes, Tyzmon was dressed in a cloaking robe, had the same boots, and his *Tyzlane Staff* was much taller, and straighter. It was a touch thicker as well. Icon was wearing a material that is what a red metal would look like. Otherwise it appeared to have been designed by the soldiers who made Tyzmon's *resurrection services* uniform which was nowhere to be seen.

The Badger

Chapter XIII: Reunions

En: Unbroken

Icon stayed at his house and the alphas escorted Tyzmon back to his room. Tomika went in with him, she sat on the floor in the corner opposite the door. Tyzmon touched his ear, said something, touched his ear again. He was getting the hang of the communication earpiece.

He walked around the cot and crouched, then sat on the floor a little more than arm's length from Tomika. "Apollonia says she'll send us some drinks."

Tomika smiled, "indeed? That'll be nice." She scratched the back of her wrist absently, "I'm sorry, Tyz." Her voice caught and dragged at the end. "I really don't know what came over me when I exited the Talos ..."

Tyzmon said nothing for a longer time than he would have liked. Then remembered a conversation he'd had with his brother and Radulf in a bright room in a tent what felt like a million years ago – *and he would know*. He said, "the camouflage. The reason your people and Ralph's people don't see me as a monster, it –"

She cut him off, "Tyzmon." Her voice was soft. "You're not a monster."

"– as a lizard, then, the reason you don't see me as a large lizard, there is some trickery with light, as you know, considering what happened –" He was being more awkward than usual, which was pretty awkward indeed. "Something on the surface of my skin changes how light bends around it and how light reflects off it. I'm not sure how it works, but the light outside my father's house cancels it out." He paused, it was super dark in his room, he wondered if he had any kind of light or something. His

brother could just make a fire. He had *nothing*.

Tyzmon blinked, thought about the table, was about to look for something to make light when a rap at the door shook him out of it. "*Drinks, we've got hot water, coffee, chocolate.*" There was a bell noise, then again. Tyzmon stood up, carefully made his way back to the door, opened it. "I was sent with this," a small alpha male said. He was carrying a tray and pushing a small cart. Tyzmon took the tray; the man touched something on the bottom and squat legs unfolded under it. Tyz walked backwards until he could feel the cot on the back of his neck, he turned, walked around the cot and placed the tray/table on the floor. He returned to the door, the other man was lifting the cart. Tyzmon helped him put it inside the door.

"Do you have some light?" Tyzmon asked quietly.

"Sir, there's a button on the cart." The man gestured, Tyzmon heard it but didn't see. "And I have this," he handed Tyzmon a lantern. "The button is on the bottom."

He turned to go.

"Thank you," said Tyzmon. The small man turned at the waist, nodded his head, bowed slightly and walked off into the dark. Tyzmon heard crickets. He pushed the cart under the cot, turned on the lantern, sat back down opposite Tomika.

They made a ceremony, almost, of getting beverages. Tyzmon had coffee, Tomika had some kind of chocolate-coffee sludge.

Eventually they got back to their conversation. Snuggled in his arms, with her smile and easy laughter, she had returned to the Tomika Tyzmon had known before. Perhaps she would forget she ran from him in fear; perhaps they both would.

"What happened, I think, is that your medical-space-suit thing filters the air. Where I come from, I'm told, the animals, the people, have multiple levels of camouflage. The first line is chemical. I think," he paused. Tyzmon refilled his cup, adjusted the lantern.

Tomika said, "yes?"

"I think you came out of the machine and you were exposed to the chemical camouflage all at once. Under normal circumstances, a person will only get low doses, and as you get closer, exposure makes you a little immune, you see what your eyes and head tell you to see." He took a drink, put the cup down, rubbed her arm, "are you cold?" She wasn't.

He continued, "in your case, you were given a full dose at close-range." He let that settle, watched his cup.

"Did you really make me younger?" Her voice sounded far away, but maybe Tyzmon was feeling far away.

He said, "probably. My brother and I have done experiments on wounded soldiers and," he stopped. He thought about Clarke and Uta, but then he continued, "everyone in the group on the other side of these mountains is in their late teens. I don't know the customs of those you call epsilon, but I'm pretty sure it's not a coincidence." Then the pieces of information clicked together and he said, "yes, I revived a father after his daughter and they looked like brother and sister."

He didn't say anything about it, but he was thinking of museum people and how he'd shaken hands with them. *Did no one notice?* Was it perhaps not an immediate and dramatic physical change?

He had a sudden thought: "Tomika?"

"Tyzmon." She said it in a teasing way.

"I'm going to ask you to help me with a secret mission. Can you get away from the village in a couple days?"

He felt her move her head. She licked his neck, whispered in his ear, "anything."

They stood up and he helped her onto the cot. He turned off the lantern, pushed the cups along the wall and hopped into the cot himself. She tossed her clothes out and grabbed him and bit him like a wild animal.

To: Pest control

Colonel Warren, Lieutenant Kanin Scott Lutèce, his deputy—*the colonel's girlfriend*—Gisela Gnaver and another dozen elite soldiers arrived at the museum before the Sun peeked over the mountains to the east. Like Gisela's *retrieval team* before them, they made camp inside the hospital.

Last night, Icon had instructed Colonel Warren to move the MB1—Mountain Base One—four point oh two kilometers east as silently as possible, and to take it down from the mountains. *Something's going on and I'm afraid only Tyzmon knows.* He was tempted to say it out loud, into the comm, to the colonel, but decided against it. "I'm told to have you watch the pass we've been using; the one between Low Mountain and Eggshell Mountain."

Clarke and Uta had been in touch with Icon but the details were sketchy, cryptic. "Tyz was right." ... "We have to hurry." ... "See if you can borrow one of those graphite spheres you guys were talking about. The ones the archaic humans used to trap you." ... "Make sure you have decent armor." Cryptic and a little foreboding. Mostly they kept radio silence, just in case.

When Tomika woke the next day—*had she actually gone to sleep (?)*, that usually doesn't happen with Tyzmon around—he wasn't in the cot, he

wasn't in the building. She touched her ear, "Tyz?" But nothing.

Tomika's comm buzzed and Lauralee, the museum curator, said, "return to medical ASAP, prepare the golems—all of them, I hope you had some good sleep." She was gone before Tomika could respond.

Tomika's comm buzzed again. Apollonia this time, "Dr. Hapner, the epsilon people taking up residence in your biohazard ward need to be outfitted with our rifles and SRDs. This may turn out to be a very long day. I trust your squad of golems are in working order?" She was also gone before Tomika could respond.

Guess I'm going to work.

She got out of Tyzmon's cot and put on her clothes. She noticed the Tyzlane Staff on the table among the other artifacts, she lifted it, *heavier than it looks*, and took it with her out the door.

SRDs are Short-range-detonation devices. *The thing used twice by Apollonia to kill the orc.*

~

When Doctor Tomika Hapner entered the hurricane that was her biohazard ward, she found the ungainly *Mark V humans* in the most chaotic state. She was able to locate the *person in charge – Colonel Warren* – whom she instructed to follow her. She headed in the direction of the supply closet, but only because she was going around the gurneys and epsilon soldiers in various states of readiness. She cut toward the back of the room, clapped her hands suddenly and the back wall opened, splitting as two large, sliding, but silent, doors. The event effectively doubled the size of the room. The new section contained several huge glossy statues under spotlights.

She went to her own, slapped it twice and its lamp's color changed to emanate a slight cyan tinge. To Warren, she said, "bring your people in here and assign each of them two golems," she gestured, indicating the medical statues. "I'll return in twenty minutes to give instructions." She turned to go, but stopped, "not this one, Colonel," indicating her machine.

Alpha humans can barely fit in the biofilter-bots. Tomika, small, even by archaic human standards, was an exception, not the rule.

On her way past the point where the doors had been, she slapped the wall and the wall behind her lit up after a series of warm-up blinks. Colonel Warren had to shield his eyes.

On her way out of the building, Tomika touched the comm device, still feeling a little heavy on her ear, she said, "Apollonia." The call went through. She said, "have you seen Tyzmon, or his brother or that purple epsilon guy?"

"Doctor?" Apollonia cleared her throat, "you should talk to Lauralee, she's coordinating our operations with the epsilon team and Tyzmon's team." She disconnected before Tomika could say anything. *Damn that's getting frustrating.*

She tapped her ear, "Lauralee." She waited. Nothing. Tomika sighed.

Her ear chirped gratingly. *F—* She reached up and swatted it. "Hapner here."

"I trust you've instructed the epsilons already? Apollonia should be delivering your SRDs and the heavier rifles."

"Ambassadress!" Tomika shouted it. She can be excused for not knowing that the volume is controlled by the machines.

Lauralee was quiet, then said, "Doctor?"

"Have you seen Tyzmon, Icon or Radulf?" But the ambassadress had already signed off.

Grrr. I hate these machines. Tomika contemplated removing hers from her ear. She sighed. The grating noise again. She touched her ear, *how can they stand it?* "Doctor Hapner."

"Tyzmon told me to contact you. My name is Uta." The person on the comm was supernaturally quiet, Tomika actually leaned forward trying to hear.

"You're very quiet, how can I turn up the volume?" In an apparent mirror behavior, Tomika's voice also took on a whisper-like quality.

"I'm afraid you can't, and I can't speak louder." Uta was silent for two breaths, Tomika may have said something, but then Uta was back, "Tyzmon and Icon sent us west, toward the coast (?)" – *Possibly a question.*

"I know west," Tomika said.

Uta continued, *"we found an entire camp of orcs."*

Tomika almost urinated in her jumpsuit. "What?!"

Uta said, "quiet." But then said, "never mind. I'm sorry. We need you to take the rest of Colonel Warren's team to the north at least 10 kilometers, but you'll end up as much as thirty, thirty-five kilometers north, as you skirt the mountainous folds, then just head west. I can see the pass here, so we're nearly out of the *inclusion zone*. Tyzmon thinks the orcs can't leave. I'm sorry, I have to go now, we don't know if they can pick up our radio transmissions." ...and she was gone. And Tomika decided she didn't hate the ear-machines.

She'd been outside, wandering. Now she was outside Tyzmon's room, his

cabin. Quickly, she returned his stick, his staff, leaning it against the wall inside the door.

She hurried back to the medical compound, ran to the golem control centre. Doctor Hapner hopped up on a stage by the brightly-lit back wall. She put her thumb and first finger against her lips and made a loud, shrill whistle. "Listen to me!"

The epsilon group turned abruptly and Colonel Warren was smiling and laughing, she didn't pay attention to him, "I think we have to hurry. I only have time to tell you this once." She paused, waited a beat, continued, "to activate a golem, you slap it on the chest, to stop it, like in an emergency, slap it twice, anywhere."

She took a quick breath, "Colonel?" *In the crowd, he nodded.* "The machines can be controlled remotely." She was still addressing the colonel. "You open the hatch in the back, press heavily on the cushion, it should spring up, lift it out. Be careful, don't let the stool strike your face." Using Tomika's machine, the colonel was doing as she instructed.

"Underneath that is a controller device," Tomika continued, "you can use one to control as many golems as you need. Each of you should have been assigned two."

She turned around, facing the bright wall. Tomika walked to the wall, she touched it with her fingertips, using both hands. The room was filled with a noise like a fan starting up. It got louder, a wind-tunnel, then a storm.

Tomika was forced to shout into the air, her voice, translated over the comm: "I've programmed the coordinates, have your machines walk into the wall here. Walk into the wall yourselves, the remotes do not have much range."

Half of the Talos machines began to move. Tomika shouted into the comm, "you have to activate both machines! You have to push the button on the remote for both machines!" The soldiers apparently understood her, because in very short order, the remaining golems were marching toward the door. She said, "Colonel, I'll take mine. Apollonia has supplies for you, when you have what you need, walk into the wall." She felt a rush like nothing ever before, this might even be better than sex.

Tomika, jumping down from the platform where she had been addressing the soldiers, touched her ear, "Uta?" She could barely hear, "Uta? Tomika. I'm sending Colonel Warren's team. He and Apollonia will bring some additional supplies. In about an hour. Have you seen Tyzmon?"

In Tomika's ear, but barely audible, Uta replied, but Tomika couldn't understand. She heard enough to sense a negative, "I'm sorry, it's loud here and I understand, you have to whisper, I'll see you, I think, in thirty-five minutes." She touched her ear. She didn't hear the machine disengage. She went to her Talos machine, turned on the air filters, put the seat back, climbed inside. The cyan light flickered and went out, Tomika turned toward the vortex, her machine silent, marched into the whooshing noise, the bright wall. She felt the urge to whoop. "Whoop!" She didn't fight the urge and her Talos echoed, "whoop!"

Tre: Ghosts and Teleportation

As soon as she was through the wall, it was dead quiet. The sky was darker than it had been the last several months. Maybe it would rain. *Rain is always nice*, thought Tomika. She exited her Talos robot and touched her ear. "Your colonel and his group and our security team will arrive shortly." No one reacted. Perhaps she wasn't using the comm correctly. She raised her arms and waved them, the soldiers started to turn to look at her. She pointed to her ear.

One of the men walked to her, turned his ear toward her, made a gesture in a semi-circle. Tomika said, very quietly, "so I don't touch it?" The soldier nodded, returned to his bots without another word.

Doing as the soldier instructed, Tomika repeated, "Colonel Warren and our security force are scheduled to be here in about an hour. Get used to these machines." *God, I hope you don't get them all destroyed.*
(Possibly a prayer to Tyzmon himself.)

She touched her ear, "Uta."

A click and a whisper, "Uta here."

"Tomika. Hey, we're standing in the place you described."

"What? You ... you got there already?"

Tomika was about to say something but for the—now familiar—noise indicating the other person disconnected. She let out a grumbled sigh. But then she saw motion to the south-west. She got into her Talos and activated the visor. There were strange lizard-like creatures coming down from the mountains, but then they were gone and she couldn't find them.

She activated the golem's internal comm. "Uta," she said with a hard exhale.

"We're coming," Uta said but before she could turn the machine off –

Tomika barked: "Are you south and west of my location?"

"Yes, we're coming." She was about to disconnect again, but then said, "wait."

"Yes?"

"What made you ask?" Uta's voice was louder than perhaps it should have been, and more than a little suspicious.

"I saw – I thought I saw movement. Are you with someone?" Tomika decided to put her cards down.

"You saw us?"

"I saw two of Tyzmon's people." Tomika meant the lizard people. In her mind, a flash of Tyzmon under the lights, a dark-green man with a triangular face, scales, tall, long neck. *Nur mia sorto. Neniam havis tiel amuza, kaj estas kun lacerto.*

Uta didn't say anything, she closed the comm, ending the conversation. Ever since Doctor Mann injected her with Icon's blood, she could see Clarke but no one could see her. Tyzmon's touch didn't *undo* whatever *this* is. She decided Tomika saw something else and it was a coincidence. She touched her ear, "Tomika."

"Yes. I'm here." Tomika recognized Uta's voice – *the translation tried to match the voice-print.*

Uta said, "we're here." She slapped the solitary bio-bot which was Tomika's. The back was open, Tomika turned, putting a leg on the outside of the machine. She grabbed the edge, and pulled herself out. Even for her it was a tight fit. There was no one.

"Uta?" But the comm didn't sound normal.

"We're here, but you can't see us," Uta said.

An epsilon male's voice came from nowhere, "we did an experiment, it's a long story."

Tomika's heart beat twice its normal speed. "You're like ghosts."

"Like what?" It was Uta. "The translation hiccuped or something, *ghosts?* What?"

"You are voices in the air. Can we use the comm? This is too spooky." Tomika visibly shivered, *brr*.

She felt a hand take hers. It was large, soft, but she saw nothing. Tomika jumped back. She heard Clarke laugh, "I didn't mean to frighten you."

Tomika said, "it's very disturbing, your voices in the air."

Uta punched her father's wrist, touched her ear, "Doctor Hapner."

Tomika's comm buzzed, she touched her ear almost instinctively. "Yes, I think this is better."

"These machines," Uta spoke, there was an echo—but Tomika didn't speak the layered language of the soldiers—so she was more comfortable with this. Uta continued, "these machines move so fast?"

Tomika found herself studying the area around her Talos device. "I'm sorry, it's really freaking me out. I'm not sure it's better where I can hear you speak your language and then hear the translation in my ear." But then she said, "no, golems move only a little faster than we do, and we don't race them, call that a guess."

There was silence, but then the comm chirped. "This is Icon and we're moving along the spine of the range, we have a couple hours or so before we're in position."

Uta said, "Do you fools insist on doing your criminally negligent experiment?"

The comm crackled, then a sigh, and Tomika recognized that sigh, she

said, "Tyzmon?!"

Tyzmon was talking, "how many did you guys see?"

Clarke said, "easily a hundred, possibly as many as two hundred. It's like a nest or something."

Tyzmon said, "Ephen." Then he was silent, but as soon as you thought he wasn't going to say anything, "he wasn't a volunteer to close the door, he was a plant, either that, or a suicide mission." Tyzmon was addressing everyone with a comm in their ear, "the orc was sent to murder one of you, and go the other direction. I don't think they can go back, I'm not sure if they're planning on hiding or attacking."

People, epsilon soldiers, mostly, started talking on the comm, overlapping voices, there was a comm-initiated whirr. Tyzmon came back on the comm, "you'll want to stay quiet." But that wasn't all.

"So the orcs can generate the giants. But that orc didn't generate any giants. He let us take him. He let museum security kill him. And if not for me, you may have thought he was the last one. Courtney saw some of the orcs and dragons disappear into a *hole in the sky*. But something happened, not all of them went through it."

Tyzmon was silent again. The comm clicked, then clicked again, then Tyzmon resumed. "Colonel. Uta and Clarke are invisible and it is probably not reversible. Orc's blood causes burns on humans but it's worse than that, because it saturates their flesh, it becomes what they are." He paused, but was on a roll. "Icon and I were fighting a giant, Apollonia's people shot it and it disintegrated, but first it fell, it fell on me. There were two more giants, Ralph dispatched one, but security blocked the other with one of their spheres." He took a breath.

"I began reviving the fallen. People have told me I was crying, I think my

sweat and tears mingled with the substance of the giant that fell. I'm still unclear on how the projecting works. At first, I thought it was like microwaves, those ovens that use electromagnetic waves." He paused as though for breath, but was thinking. "Instead, I think they're doing something to the nuclei of atoms in the air." He was thinking (?) again, but then, "however they're projecting the giants, the residue is similar to the substance from the orc after he was killed by Apollonia.

"My brother and I conducted four tests with these birds. Any amount of orc goop caused severe burns and disability, just like Gisela and her team; most of those I had revived on Low Mountain."

The comm was quiet. Tyzmon finally came back on, "Uta and her father were injected with Icon's blood. I'm still a little surprised and impressed, Clarke took a syringe of my brother's blood and just injected himself after a vague reassurance from me that I'd try to tilt him off his shelf if it should go wrong.

"Doctor Mann and Uta were the only ones who knew and she volunteered to be another *secret agent*. I already suspected, before my *conversation* with Ephren, that he wasn't alone. I asked him questions that I hoped would get him to tell me I was right. He spent the time he had pretending to be afraid of me. But he did recognize me."

Tyzmon stopped his story-like narrative and said into the comm, "you guys want to hear this, right? Because Radulf, Icon and I have a couple more hours before we'll be in position."

The comm chirped with soldiers and archaic humans apparently urging him to continue.

"So the orc knew I wasn't from Earth, he even knew I wasn't from *this galaxy*. Now this is information that was rather new to me." He paused,

hoping the others would realize what he already knew, then continued. "So the orc had some power to read my mind. It was the second most likely scenario. The first being that he could see through my body's natural camouflage. But that wouldn't explain how he knew I was from another galaxy, especially which galaxy." He whistled softly, "even if he had a catalogue of all the creatures in *this galaxy*, he'd still have to get very lucky to guess the right one. Unless he wasn't guessing. There are two ways he could know without guessing. The first is if he had met my people before and that's possible, I don't know who he has and hasn't seen. But it occurs to me that it is slightly more likely that he could simply read my mind. I mean the explanation is simple, not that I can even imagine what that kind of power would mean."

Tyzmon stopped talking as he, Icon and Radulf navigated a less inviting area. "I've actually once met someone who could read my mind. He was quite good at it, too. And if he wasn't embedded in my own head, I'd probably wonder how he did it." He laughed, "the truth is, and I only barely remember, so this may sound far fetched: I once was assaulted by a man who claimed to represent an official government force from back in the Andromeda galaxy. He was quite good. He knew what I was going to do before I did it. I had to defeat him by letting him capture me. I won't bother you with the possibly troubling detail, but I was a little late and he attached to me or cursed me or left technology in my mind, one of these or something else. So I have a constant companion, this man, his name is Truth.

"Truth can read my mind but he only appears when I'm alone. He, whatever, it, seems to be trying to force me not to lie. Perhaps that's why he's called *Truth*. If I relax enough, and look into my own mind, I can find him there, sitting, as though on a stump, watching me with his hands on his waist in a most judgmental posture.

"I used to want to remove him, to get rid of him. I'd probably still like to, but I'm used to it now. I've even started seeing myself asking his advice, as though I may do so in the future." Tyzmon let out a breath, "what do you think, Icon, are we there?"

Icon was suddenly on the comm, but it crackled and hissed more than before, "give me a moment." There was a whoosh noise on the comm, and a silent explosion to the south, up the hill and slightly to the east.

Clarke spoke, "Yes, you're in position. We're still waiting. Colonel? Colonel Warren?"

"Warren here, yes, we're walking into your helvedes mareridt, the wind-storm wall, now." The comm clicked loudly and then Colonel Warren, Deputy Gnaver, and Lieutenant Kanin appeared, followed by Apollonia, wearing her *strike force clothes*, vest, helmet, the whole thing. Then the virtual small army of museum security, dressed almost the same as their leader, Apollonia.

A kind of multi-tiered cart covered with trays of SRDs and other supplies came from nowhere, security people started moving out around the Talos statues. Apollonia had a sphere in each hand and suddenly, mysteriously, they lifted out of her hands and vanished.

Clarke on the comm, said, "Uta and I have the spheres and we each took two of your orc euthanasia machines; give us twenty minutes to get into position."

Radulf said, "Check." Before he clicked away, his giggling filled the comm, most of the epsilon soldiers laughed along with him, but the alpha people did not appear to enjoy the untranslated sounds of epsilon human mania.

Twenty-three minutes and five seconds later...

Tyzmon said, almost dreamily, "I remember, when I was a boy, living in the valley on the other side of these mountains, there was a creature called a badger. It was said that a badger was fearless but seemed small and defenseless. But badgers had been known to take on and defeat whole packs of wolves, these were a kind of large dog." He paused dramatically and then, louder: "Long live the badger!"

Something in his voice? But everyone on the comm said, "long live the badger!" He said it again and they all said it together. Then they were quiet.

Uta, on the comm, "ready."

Clarke said, "almost there." ...And a minute later, "ready."

The badger strikes.

Chapter XIV: Orcpocalypse!

In case you haven't guessed, the *foolish experiment* was rather simple. Ralph was going to charge the orc camp. Tyzmon and Icon would take care of any orcs moving east. South and west were out of the *time envelope*, and Apollonia and her team waited to the north, and that's assuming Uta and Clarke didn't trap them all with their museum domes and/or "euthanize" them as they ran by.

Of course, if they could go out of the *inclusion zone* ... thus the use of the word *experiment*, I suppose.

Icon fired two bolts into the air, they exploded silently high in the sky, snapping and popping followed several seconds later.

Ralph held and pressed the handle of the purple knife. The Titan-Radulf projection loomed above, turned away from Tyzmon, Icon and his terrestrial counterpart, took a step, another and was standing over the orc encampment. The purple titan reached down, lifted the largest piece of mountain – the biggest rock – he could see.

As soon as he lifted it, he saw another and took it with his other enormous hand. The projection stood erect, holding large stones over its head. Radulf had an idea. He yelled, "Ahhhh!"

The purple titan bellowed, "Ahhhh!"

Titan Radulf, hands together over his head, flung them together, straight down onto the orcs, took a step, seemed to actually feel himself stepping on them. The orcs were scattering. Ralph's Colossus leaned low with his huge version of the plum blade, slicing individual orcs as they attempted

to escape. He rampaged through the camp. Then he started lifting the orcs and throwing them at the rocks or over the cliff into the pass.

Orcs' bodies coming into contact with the atmosphere outside the *orée* vanished undramatically, they were just, *piff*, gone.

Ralph, or anyway, the titanic version of Ralph giggled like the slightly insane man he was, he stomped on the orcs, he kicked them, he sliced at the ground, flung them into the nothingness over the side of the mountains.

Survivors of Radulf's attack were beginning to head east. Icon was shooting them with fireballs from his fists, *whoosh-pah, woosh-pah, whoosh-pah*. Orcs are decidedly not immune to the fire.

There were no giants; perhaps they were taken too much by surprise?

Icon and Ralph weren't the only ones granting sanity and morality a holiday. Tyzmon in amazing feats of acrobatics and swordplay, took out several orcs by Dragonfeather.

~

"Here they come," it was Uta speaking, orcs were leaving the area, heading slightly northeast, almost a dozen passed her and she threw her orb after them. A glass dome fit for museum pieces popped into existence, the orcs were trapped.

She had done well for a first-timer. She walked into the bubble-trap and began using her SRD to euthanize orc after orc. "One. Two. Three. ... Eleven." She picked up the orb, returned to her original post – it had served her so well.

Clarke was on his second set by this time, the first was only three, but he

was able to trap and kill seven more with this attempt.

Meanwhile, Apollonia and Colonel Warren were spreading out the museum security forces. The golems stood ready but looked like shiny statues. Tomika was ready.

They didn't see any orcs.

It was almost a let down after getting everyone into position. Apollonia talked to Colonel Warren on the comm; they decided to take their force south, close the gap a little ... the others may need them. They actually hadn't heard anything from any of *Tyzmon's team* since seeing Icon's star-bursts, they felt the slight rumbling of the ground, but that was all.

As Colonel Warren and Apollonia's joint force began moving south, Uta came onto the comm, "I'm inside a dome, this is the seventh one. There are less and less of them coming this way. You guys in the north, you should come south."

Warren quickly tapped his ear and confirmed, but they were already moving. The golems, the biobots, movements were the most fascinating thing: they were enormous, sleek, their metal and polymer construction and highly glossed finish made them appear to be stone or even bone, but they made no sounds when they moved. The epsilon soldiers learned that controlling them was incredibly easy, these huge robot-suits seemed to anticipate maneuvers and understood about staying in formation.

~

Tyzmon and Icon were moving closer to the version of Radulf that stood as a Titan above the ground, fewer and fewer orcs were coming east. They hadn't seen any in at *least* a minute.

Icon could see, over a slight rise, the virtual soup, the lake of orc goop

that titanic Radulf was wading through. Tyzmon flea-jumped onto the purple Titan's shoulder. Ralph laughed, the immense projection shook and Tyzmon, comically, nearly tragically, almost lost his footing. He jumped down, killed an orc, jumped back up.

Icon saw movement— *whoosh-pah* —lit it on fire, saw more movement— *whoosh-pah* —lit it on fire. But this, this dry mountaintop area, isn't exactly the ideal place to sear your victims. Behind him and to his sides the mountaintops were alive with flame.

I suppose the good news is that orcs wouldn't go that way. The bad news is that the mountain was on fire and the mountains were covered with dry, dead and dying grasses and trees.

Ralph – little, non-titanic Radulf – far-away expression on his face, stood with fire all around him. Icon finally realized what was going on and turned, rushing to Ralph's aid. Tyzmon, perched on the Titan's shoulder, also saw, hopped down, two more hops and he and Icon carried Radulf toward the area that had been the orc's camp. Radulf dropped the plum blade and his titanic doppelgänger vanished.

Tyzmon, turned, leaving his brother to carry Ralph briefly. He grabbed the knife, slotted it in the holster at Ralph's side and continued helping his brother carry their friend, choking from the smoke, but not burned. Just to be sure, Tyzmon touched his bare arm.

Fire was engulfing the entire area to the east, it would soon come over the mountains and into the Archangel Valley proper. Simultaneously spreading north, and possibly into the area that had been the campground the orcs had used. It was flame and smoke and sore eyes, choking and disbelieving.

Tyzmon lifted his staff – *fuck, I hope this works* – shouting to the

heavens, gritting his teeth, closing his eyes tight, tighter; there was a loud crack, the ground beneath him rumbled, the clouds above swirled. Flames ravaged the area to the east, just at the tops of the mountains, and it was spreading rapidly.

Soon, though, it was raining.

Colonel Warren, Apollonia and their joint strike force was steadily moving south, up the back of the mountain, they had started to see the smoke, started moving faster, fanning out.

...And it started raining. It rained more and harder, it was as if Tyzmon was wringing out the clouds themselves, and then it stopped: A five minute deluge. But what a rain storm!

And the sky was clear and blue, all the clouds had been juiced of their essence.

And, in the silently evaporating mists that were all that remained of the shower, a rainbow appeared.

Orcpocalypse 2: Revenge of the Possums!

Chapter XV: Armageddon!

Don't Panic

Possibly Tyzmon could have stood outside the orc camp for that fabulous display. Away from the busted and burst bodies of orcs, away from the carnage. Out of sight of their ooze-like goo.

But instead, he stood in a lake of orc juice and brought on the tremors and the rain and lightening, the whole beautiful show.

And-but-so the orcs were revived!

And the orcs weren't stupid. They stayed down. *They played possum.*

Tyzmon brought his arms down, it looked like his small deluge put out Icon's fire. He started to turn, to walk back to where he'd left Radulf and Icon but realized he wasn't standing in the little lake of orc guts.

"You guys," he said, touching his ear.

He started dancing around, hopping and high jumping, swiveling in the air. Icon also noticed that the lake of orc carnage was dry. He clapped his hand against his ear, "Tyzmon fucking revived the fucking orcs!"

Ralph, a moment ago, leaning against Icon like a winded or wounded man, suddenly stood up, took out his blade, squeezed the handle. A whoosh and the towering purple Titan was back.

But an orc was near Icon's feet; near the nearly comatose Radulf's feet. It stood while simultaneously jabbing its hand into Ralph's sternum. Those long, black, blade-like, wrong-angled fingernails, came out through Radulf's back.

Death was instantaneous. Radulf fell; he never even knew what hit him. The titanic version of Radulf fell forward but dissipated before it hit the ground.

By then, Icon had that orc by the neck; his hands flames. The orc was flailing like a fish, a giant ugly sucker-fish with teeth. Icon was kicking at it, spitting flames at its face, finally it was limp and he dropped it, a burning orc candle.

Icon was crying, flaming tears streaked his face, as though dripping kerosene from fiery tear ducts. His body was alight, a bonfire of brilliance, he was screaming, hysterical, sobbing, consumed by madness, consumed by naked flames.

Icon began hunting orcs, after the fire, after the deluge, a certain cool stillness had descended making it all the easier to spot orcs dumb enough to move. At least nothing would stay on fire. The mountains had been drenched and now they were soaked through.

And suddenly, coming over the rise from the north, dozens of security forces and robots and Colonel Warren's elite team. For awhile it seemed that everyone would get a chance to join the fray; and nearly everyone did.

And then it was over.

And then they searched.

They spent the rest of the daylight looking for orcs. They found none. Icon and Tyzmon, Uta and Clarke were plenty jumpy, though.

Apollonia and Colonel Warren helped Icon move Radulf's body away from all the splotchy, gooey orc remains to where Tyzmon may be able to revive him without further incident.

Tomika and Apollonia inspected this epsilon soldier – this Mark V human – in case he had any trace of orc sludge on his body, touching his skin. Not seeing any, they gave Tyzmon a gesture he interpreted as favorable and he, weeping, knelt. Then, taking his friend's face once again, he felt Radulf slide down from his shelf into his hands once again. And he silently apologized over Radulf's body ...again.

He helped Ralph to his feet, again.

And Ralph, like before—like every time—said nothing.

The Magic of the Tyzlane Staff

Chapter XVI: Genesis Andromedans and Hidden Truths

And it was time to exit the infernal edge, to bid the inexplicable goodbye. Time to return to the valley and time to leave the terrible valley once and for all. But smart, thinking men and women, soldiers who had been paying attention, made a special note in the backs of their minds, notes that would tug at them, notes that would come to them in their dreams:

Be sure to be buried in the Archangel Valley.

~

The teleportation vortex, whatever that wall of wind – crazy – nightmare was, is a one-way trip. They had to walk back to the village, to the *museum*. Tomika and her league of epsilon soldiers returned the remote controls under the seats of the robot soldiers which were not soldiers. ... but they were soldiers—upending their true purpose of saving lives—tugging rudely at anyone's notions of ethics... But then –

Gonna install more powerful lasers, thought Tomika.

The robots were linked in a formation and given a command and they walked. The walk would take all night. The silent statue army crossing east in the still darkness, through the mountains to their museum, their sanctuary in the back half of the biohazard ward where they'd sit under spotlights until needed, if they were needed, again.

Radulf, resurrected, *again*, got back to the village, the *museum* the

fastest.

"Don't worry, my brother," he said to Icon as he pushed the handle on *Plum, The Giant Killer*, "don't worry, everybody's alive!" And the titan leaned close—breathing airless, silent breath on Icon—he plucked his smaller self up between little finger — *bigger than the body of an ox* — and thumb. Titan-Radulf held the tiny, normal-sized Radulf in an enormous fist and walked to the village in twenty minutes? Less? Had he tried, had he known, Tyzmon could have beaten him, no tricks. But that's another story.

Tyz and Icon, instead, took the slow route, and they mostly retraced their own steps from earlier. Earlier, when Tyzmon was the only one, not counting people who are invisible and don't get a vote, who knew a battle was brewing. Earlier when the badger slept. Or didn't quite exist yet.

Tomika walked with her lover and his brother almost as high as one can walk in the Archangel Mountains, and about as far south before you start to come back down the other side.

Colonel Warren and Apollonia walked with Gisela and Lt. Kanin and a mess of security forces from the museum and the Brigade of Five Stars. None of them had eaten for most of the day but no one realized they were hungry. I'm sorry, they didn't *walk*, they *marched*. I'm sure there was a *debriefing* they needed to get to. Maybe they'd have breakfast pastries ...in pinks and purples; soft blues and yellows.

If Ralph took twenty minutes to get back, the army and superheroes took several hours and the silent army of robots took all night and would appear in the morning with the cock.

If roosters hadn't gone extinct hundreds of millions of years ago, that is.

Some roosters may exist still, phase 1 humans expanded into the stars,

but they didn't go alone. This museum was a testament to man's curiosity about the universe and his love of home, the forever need to look back and wave at mom and say her name: Earth. Certainly it's not unreasonable to think they may have taken pieces with them; pieces of home, even animals, as mementos.

After getting back, and though Tyzmon could have easily touched anyone already touched by fatigue, everyone, even Tomika, opted to go to their own beds and sleep. Icon went to his house and Tyzmon sat alone, thinking in silence on his brother's front porch steps, head leaning on his fist, right elbow on his thigh, left forearm on knee.

Tyzlane Staff all but abandoned on the landing above.

With the kiss of the Sun, soldiers and security agents still slumbered as well as certain medical professionals but people were awake and moving around, alpha people, museum employees from the distant corners of the Milky Way. The museum was open, it was always open. Most of the people passing the silently thinking Tyzmon were dressed in what they believed to be period costumes from half a billion years ago. Some people thought Tyzmon watched.

And this, among other things, big and small, was what Tyzmon silently thought about: the Moon. Between Icon, the museum personnel, the cognitive dissidence between his memories of them and the mountains themselves, just little pieces and big, evidence here and there, the Moon was in the wrong place. Even the Sun itself! The Sun was an enormous ball in the sky, the planet cooked under her gaze. But it had been a well-established fact, that he had learned in the valley as a small child, the Moon was moving away from the Earth. Something *must* have happened!

But he couldn't fathom what. Could the humans, alphas, betas, gammas, or deltas have moved it? Certainly it wasn't the non-spacefaring epsilon people. Perhaps it suffered a collision – and perhaps it happened so long ago that no one remembers it. Maybe everyone knows and it just didn't come up. The Moon is where the Moon is and that's that.

He thought about how the Sun had also grown significantly, shouldn't he remember, even a little bit, the gradual process? But, again, the time scale boggled the mind, even the mind that had survived it all. *This planet is doomed.*

While Tyzmon was chasing his tail and worrying his cynical bone and sniffing out the logical steps or missteps that put the Moon in the sky, he was being watched, silently, from peaks all around. Creatures which could smell him on the air over vast distances and had come for him, time and time again only to finally, after all this time, *finally* catch him, surround him...

And he just sat there!

Icon emerged from the door behind him. The silent robots were almost back. Guests to the museum, if they were mischievous or lost, could have come around a corner at any moment. Icon took his stairs and as he passed, Tyz stood, took up his staff and accompanied him.

They walked to Tyzmon's room-cottage and went inside. Icon said, "*You spoke of a demon on the comm yesterday?*"

Truth, thought Tyzmon, "I don't know if it's a demon, but its name is *Truth*." He blinked, thinking about the giant fiery orb in the sky, the one which was so much smaller and still caused severe burns.

"What happened? You didn't have a demon before." Icon was prying

open a can with soft sensitive fingers but he didn't realize it at the time.

I've always had my demon; Truth has always been here. Tyzmon leaned his staff in the corner, and was about to say something when he saw another staff on the floor by his table of artifacts. He leaned down and lifted it up. He put it in the corner with the first one and, standing on his toes, looked into the cot where Tomika slumbered like a coma victim.

He turned, stared at the *two* Tyzlane Staffs. *Two.*

"Two." He whispered.

"Two," Said Icon. Who then said, "and a million or twenty million or four hundred million or two: Two billion. Two billion more."

"I do not understand (?)" Said Tyzmon, a bewildered look covered his face like a drawn shade.

"You make them. It's you. They aren't magic, you are. Or whatever you are, it appears to be magic and the stick glows, but it's you." Icon hadn't really thought through how he would talk about it.

Tyzmon said, "it's not magical? It's just a stick with drawings on it?" Tyzmon's hand found the back of his neck where he rubbed silently, touching hair which was a touch too short.

"It's your name, man. Somehow, somehow you remember your name." Icon's voice betrayed him, but it didn't matter, tears flowed down his cheeks. "Iapyx."

And there, on the branches, written for anyone to see, again and again, on Tyzlane Staff after Tyzlane Staff, through the ages, while animals evolved and went extinct, while the Moon itself moved away and back like a cosmic yo-yo:

"The demon and the orc called me *Shadow...*" Complained Tyzmon.

Icon laughed, and was about to say something but Tyzmon said, "you said I was, what did you say? You said I was somewhere I didn't quite fit and that I couldn't be in both places or something."

Icon stopped laughing, "*Shadow* means 'enemy', Tyzmon."

If this was 500 million years ago, Tyzmon would have said, "Oh fuck me!" Instead he said, "no." But he knew it was true and the knowledge left an impression on his face.

Icon said, "I think we have to find our father."

Tyzmon said, "he isn't alive, you said so yourself."

"I didn't say he wasn't alive! I said—I don't remember what I said—but I said you and I are the only people capable of impersonating him ... *if one of us is the judge*. The only real limit on the person, the people who could pretend to be him or one of us, is the knowledge of the observers."

Tyzmon said, "people have to know us for someone to impersonate us. But I thought you were saying it was one of us who impersonated our father ... I specifically read about this very thing. *There are people who can travel in time*. They may be using Andromedan technology, but they're here, and they're responsible for us, for you and for me."

"It doesn't matter, Tyzmon." *And anyway* – "And anyway, even if one of us did impersonate our father, it doesn't mean he's not out there, somewhere." Icon exhaled and focused, "tell me about this demon, this *Truth* character."

"I don't want to." Tyzmon's mind was spinning. Suddenly, he blurted,

"what happened to the Moon?"

"What? What?" Icon didn't understand the question. "The Moon? The Moon is the Moon."

"It should be much farther away." Tyzmon shook his head. "You know what, I'm not sure I care."

"The demon, Tyzmon, tell me about the demon." Icon was speaking in a kind of percussive rhythm. "Tell me about the damn demon already."

"The dominoes fell. The two men watched each other from across a field. One would not survive, but the other would be maimed, crippled, ruined." Tyzmon's eyes were far away, his voice was monotonous.

Icon said nothing, expecting Tyz's story to continue, but it did not.

Tyzmon finally said, "the mind-clamp wasn't compatible. In another species, perhaps in another of our species, but however, not in me, in another, perhaps, the machine would invoke compliance and honesty."

Truth! Thought Icon, "it worked, you know, at least, it seems to have worked a little bit." Icon thought about what his brother had said, "I wouldn't exactly call you *compliant*, but I wouldn't argue with someone who did. And do you remember the last time you *lied to someone* about anything?"

Tyzmon's eyes were full of tears. Tomika was stirring on his bed. "Yes. Yes, I remember," the quietest voice anyone has ever used, barely more than the motion of moving his lips.

He suddenly opened the door and Icon, after a brief look into his brother's weeping eyes, turned and walked toward Daedalus's cylinder library house with the bizarre roof. "I'll meet you at lunch, Man." The door closed. Tyzmon was naked and Tyz and Tomika were straining the

ropes holding the cot to the corners of the ceiling ... *again*.

Der er en frood der virkelig ved, hvor hans håndklæde er.

Chapter XVII: A Return to the Valley

En: Actually a Party

The sex was good, I'm sure, but there was a party and they had to go to it. It's a little impolite to miss a party when you're either the host or the guest of honor. Oh, but the tiny alpha human tasted so good.

~

...Anyway.

A room adjacent to the foyer of the main museum building had been converted to a banquet hall. Alphas *and even a few beta humans* were either preparing the room or coming into it with a smile of delight, or—*and this is true*—some did both.

Alphas were expert at avoiding class and occupation asymmetry. After their infancy in their home eon, time and time again, stumbling over themselves as group after group indulged its heady greed at the expense of distant—and not-so-distant—slaves, humanity—phase 1 humanity—could finally, mostly, see eye-to-eye with its own self.

...But practically all differences had been bred out, but that's beside the point, mostly.

It also helps if there's no such thing as money...

Before all the soldiers—the epsilon humans—could return to the valley, before Icon and Tyzmon and their friend, Ralph, could leave the valley for points beyond, a party and an exchange of information.

The soldiers had come into the valley to learn about the *Inclusion Zone*

and these museum people had come back to learn and teach about Earth and the epsilon—phase 5—humans.

I believe it's the kind of thing ya call a win-win.

Maps of the valley and the “fold” were presented to a smiling Colonel Warren. He presented awards for various things related to bravery and quick thinking. Also, I think he may have been a little drunk.

Tyzmon, Tomika and Icon and Radulf had a special table that was up on a stage-like platform; Apollonia, too. Alpha people had “transcended” their *carnivore*, their *omnivore* roots and now, eating was almost as pure an art as ballet or genetic manipulation of domestic cats.

OK, it was boring. I would have left. Fighting with an orc in a hole would have been more fun *and it was*. But ... you sometimes do what ya gotta do.

Icon left and returned with his own meat. And Tomika who, two days ago, would have been shocked and sickened, ate one of the birds. She awkwardly, yet enthusiastically, crunched parts that experienced carnivores tend to avoid. But she was expanding her mind and that's what the afternoon was about. I guess. *Can we skip this crap?*

Fine. They ate, they played games, they got and gave awards. They delivered brief speeches about the battle with the orcs, they repeated—and mangled—Tyzmon's narrative describing how he knew there were more orcs and how Uta and Clarke had found them. They drank and then they drank more and then—some of them anyway—stood in line for more drinks.

Tyzmon was virtually buried in gifts. And as annoyed as I am to talk about the endless back-slapping and mutual hand clapping, Tyzmon

soaked it up. This, having a room full of beings all talking about him, all aware that he existed and that it was a good thing—not the kind of thing that gets a person dissected—this was a fulfillment of his silent and possibly unknown wish.

If people could see him through the chemical veil, through the light-bending refraction-confusing camouflage, they would have seen a small happy child who was grateful to no-longer be alone.

A happy child covered with tiny, dense dark green, almost blue, scales.

Some of the beta humans were introduced to Tyzmon and he vaguely recognized these marsupials. To them, though, he was a legend. He was *the silent magician*, which Tyzmon thought didn't sound like him at all. As you may expect, it was clear they thought he looked like them and he didn't protest, didn't correct the misapprehension.

If your camouflage is working, is staying silent dishonest?

Somehow these betas had less fur than the alphas. Maybe there was a trend. But who knows, evolution doesn't necessarily explain itself in an autobiography. And there are always key fossils that will forever be lost because the right animals didn't accidentally fall to their death in soft mud right before a volcanic event conveniently drops a nice layer of ash.

A certain tall beta female scandalized Tomika by offering to show Tyz her pouch. Tyzmon didn't seem to be kidding or playing along when he started to stand to take her up on the offer. Icon gave him a look and he stayed. But *marsupial humans!* I'm telling you, I wouldn't pass up the opportunity. He should have gone.

To: A parade with a big finish

I'm not going to say the party seemed to last forever. Tyzmon certainly did enjoy the attention and recognition and the happiness of those around him. Even if he *was* deprived of seeing a marsupial human's pouch.

But the robots were marching and museum employees were returning to their duties, last of which, possibly were Apollonia and Tomika who went to oversee the return of the bio-suits.

It was still nominally a party. The Mark V human guests — the soldiers; epsilons — were still here, as were our core group, Radulf and Icon and Tyzmon. A large group had actually come in for a scheduled tour; some of them were here, in fact, but the normal work of the village — the museum — continued. And the guests of honor — specifically, the modern human soldiers and their possibly alien, superhero friends—The Immortal, The Fireman and the Titan — were preparing to leave.

Colonel Warren and his soldiers were preparing to reconvene in Tomika's biohazard ward — which is where the silent statue army was heading. And Tyzmon, too—carried away in conversation with the colonel and his soldiers—but also to see Tomika who worked there.

Icon had a mysterious mission and was quietly discussing details on the comm; he left first. Radulf went with Tyz and his friends, supposedly a soldier too, after all.

Outside the hospital, there was a huge group of museum personnel and visitors, they were held back from the walkway by guide posts and museum *special exhibit* tape. Tyzmon and Colonel Warren were behind the main contingent of soldiers, but Gisela was ahead of them and was taken by surprise.

When the soldiers first became visible the crowd exploded in a chorus of shouts and hand waving, clapping and whistles. Gisela didn't know what was going on at first, but the party itself had opened her eyes. She put her arms into the air, open hands, waving and smiling. "OK OK OK," she was saying, as she waved and turned and continued walking to the hospital.

The soldiers behind her were quick to resume marching in formation and also got into the public-minded, crowd-chasing spirit, "whoop! Whoop! Whoop!" And a pause and then, again, "whoop! Whoop! Whoop!"

The crowd positively exploded cheering and clapping.

Behind Tyzmon and Colonel Warren, Tomika's robots were silently returning. They got louder, indeed, when they saw the colonel and Tyzmon. Who would have guessed he was the kind of person who would immediately become an entertainer when the moment arrived?

Tyzmon threw The Dragonfeather into the air and caught it on the tip of a finger. He threw it into the air, end-over-end, then flea-jumped and *caught it in the air*—in his teeth(!)—before it even reached its apex.

He began doing acrobatic jumps and flips, flashing Dragonfeather in the waning light of the afternoon. The spectators gobbled it up like starving puppies, if there were any puppies left in the universe.

An eyewitness would have thought the crowd couldn't get louder, would probably have expected the crowd to collapse from the sheer energy it was expending. That person would have been proven quite wrong when the *deafening roar* that accompanied people's first sight of the Talos suits. Colonel Warren and Tyzmon, by this time, had reached the entrance to the hospital, turned as they entered to wave to a crowd that was no-longer even watching them.

Colonel Warren cleared his throat, he and Tyz went inside where the absolute quiet was like jumping into a deep pool of chilled water – or oil. The ground shook and the colonel turned to look out the door, but was pulled out of the way by Tyzmon.

Tomika had apparently prepared the 'bots for their triumphant return to their home, they were *dancing*. There was music on some kind of over-head announcement system and the Talos bio-filtering suits were dancing to it. Too bad Tyzmon and Warren missed it. More ground shaking. The last Talos; the final bio-bot was Tomika's and she was standing on its shoulders, clapping and waving at the crowds on either side of the entryway.

And the ground shook and shook some more.

...because behind the dancing robots, that is, behind Tomika, standing on the shoulders of her giant, was an enormous epsilon human wearing a shiny purple robe-like uniform and carrying a large knife.

...and straddling that knife, *and likely holding on for dear life*, was Radulf, who managed to wave his short sword in the air. Or maybe he was trying not to fall.

But the crowd managed to make even more noise upon seeing him and the Titan-Ralph had to limit his performance because his stride put him at the hospital entrance much much too quickly. The enormous projection lifted Radulf off his knife as though he were a rodent or possibly, just an ant, and carefully placed him on the ground a few feet behind Tomika's Talos as she and it were about to go through the doors.

The Titan vanished and Radulf bowed, all grins and laughter. He turned, bowed again, and went inside. A few minutes later, the music volume

lowered and returned to silent. And a few minutes after that, the crowd started to break up.

Tre: The Rest of the robots

Inside, Radulf was just in time to see the spotlights turn off and the wall close, leaving the room full of medical robots to rest until they were needed again.

Actually the hospital was getting busy. Crowds bring accidents and injuries and fake accidents and injuries, especially from the type of enterprising people who realized it'd get them a closer view of the robots or the superheroes and soldiers. Come to think of it, there should have been more of those.

Museum security agents and Colonel Warren's people were completely socializing as though they weren't completely alien races that didn't even speak the same language. This sight started wheels turning...

Warren was thinking about guiding tours into the valley to visit the museum and looked over the heads of his people for a sight of Apollonia who, being a smaller, *alpha human*, could easily disappear in a crowd of them. He didn't see her, but a hand clapped his shoulder and he turned, raising his glass. *Yes, it was another party, I didn't mention?*

"Colonel Warren!" It was Apollonia.

"Sargent Laurentia!" He grinned, "I was just going to call you on my," he gestured with his free hand to the wrong ear, "comm."

Apollonia was smiling and she winked. "I felt you."

Colonel Warren leaned down, "what?"

She started grinning and laughing, "nothing, my people would have found

that funny.”

“Oh. Oh, I think I understand.” He made a kind of quarter-turn so she could see past him. “Everyone seems to be getting along wonderfully, wouldn't you say?”

“I came here to discuss that with you, our ambassadress, too, should be joining us shortly.” She was still smiling, her drink glass clinked against her teeth.

Lauralee emerged from between Colonel Warren's men, carrying a strangely-shaped glass containing a liquid consisting of multiple colors, it had a straw. She sipped, said, “Lovely. Lovely party.” Looking to the colonel, she became suddenly serious and said, “you brought my mate and my daughter back to me. I am forever in your debt.”

Apollonia, the stalwart leader of museum security kind of broke and released an unusual exhale. A single tear dripped down her cheek. She turned suddenly to the colonel and embraced him.

Colonel Warren, caught off guard, almost fell backwards. Fortunately, she wasn't very large and, anyway, there were other soldiers behind him. He had nothing else to do besides hug her back.

When she relaxed and let him go, her tear streaked face was completely clear and he almost would have thought he imagined the whole thing. She took his empty hand and said, “yes. Thank you.”

Warren took a cleansing breath—*he didn't want to cry!*—and decided to change the subject.

“I was just about to ask Apollonia, in the spirit of information exchange and peace and education of the young, if she would endorse an idea I've had.”

Both ladies nodded, smiling. Apollonia turned her free hand over and gestured for him to continue.

"Well," started Warren, "as you may know, my group here, we all died down south, in the valley there. Technically none of us are affiliated with the armed forces for this province. Usually, dying will disqualify a person from military service."

Both ladies laughed but Warren wasn't smiling, they looked at each other, looked at him, stopped laughing. Lauralee dipped her head, said, "you're not kidding?"

Colonel Warren laughed, "oh! Oh, no, I wasn't. But I see. Yes, yes, that's funny. But we're used to it now, I guess. People, soldiers, though, have died and been resuscitated by medical personnel in the past. We, our culture, take it kind of seriously. Anyway, there haven't been any wars in hundreds of years and besides certain exploratory or training missions, we don't have a lot going on. Certainly there's no fighting. Not on any kind of scale."

They were politely silent, but at least their smiles had returned.

"Anyway, so this group, the larger group at our camp on the side of the mountains to the south and myself are all, kind of, retired. Or we soon will be, if anyone finds out what happened. ...and there's no reason to keep it a secret." He stopped talking, he had lost the thread of what he was thinking.

After an awkward moment, Lauralee said, "you were going to tell us your educational, peace and information exchange idea...?"

"Yes, right. Thank you. I was thinking we, that is, my people, the population of Earth, should come to this museum, should visit the valley. I and my team will be at loose ends, us being retired from military service

on account of not being alive to serve.” He chuckled.

Taking his small laugh and smile as a cue, both women laughed.

Apollonia pointed at him and nodded. All three laughed. Lauralee said, “as curator of the museum, I should say, I recommend your idea completely.”

Apollonia said, “there are conditions, safety restrictions, that I'm thinking about, but it's perfectly fine with me if it's fine with Lauralee.”

Both women shook his hand. And the deal was done.

They continued talking but the evening was approaching and the next day they'd return to the valley, well, most of them would.

But the party extended into the night without any sign of letting up.

Fire: Tomika and Tyzmon; Tyzmon and Tomika

Tyzmon and Tomika had managed to sneak out. Whatever it was that he did to a person that variously made them less tired, not hungry or revived them after they'd been exploded into a billion pieces also made them have endless supplies of energy.

She was on top.

Tomika held his body between her knees, bent to embrace him and, as she settled into a rhythm, whispered, “must you go?”

Tyzmon's eyelids flickered like candle light. He was apparently unaccustomed to talking during sex. He moaned a little, but managed to say, “I can ... do ... what I wish.”

She pressed forward and down, grinding into his very being, or so he'd say if you asked him. She said, “must you go, so soon?”

He bit her chin when she brought her face close enough to his. He said, "I can return. But there are some ... things ... outside the ... valley." He lost his concentration, his eyes glazed a little, but then he said, "outside ... the valley ... that I ... [deep breath] ... must check on."

She purred, she bit his neck, he tasted like fruit, tonight. She didn't even stop to think about how he had tasted like pastries their first time together. "But will you return, really." She let out an ecstatic moan, "will you return to me?"

Probably not even Tyzmon understood the implications of his *demon*. But it is worth mentioning that he hasn't broken a promise of this kind in a couple *hundred* million years.

"I will return to you, my decadent warm-blooded lover. I ... will ... return ... to ... *you*." He grabbed her, her hips, her ass, his orgasm, as always, knocked him unconscious, she rocked against him, clenching her teeth in an uncontrolled smile and collapsed on top of him. But then, recovering rapidly, as she always did, she began to trace patterns on his chest until his eyes opened and she could get him started again.

...And they spent the night like that.

Fem: Loci evening camp on mountain top.

I'm thinking it won't surprise you that it wasn't until late the following night that those hiking ahead of the group finally reached their, top of the mountain, temporary camp.

Most of museum security and a few of the medical personnel accompanied the epsilon soldiers—and *their unique friends*—to the top of the mountains.

Apollonia, a straggler—perhaps an outsider would think her so—was at

least twenty minutes behind the main contingent.

Tomika and Apollonia clung to Tyzmon, Icon and Radulf. Gisela, the not-so-dead Lieutenant Lutèce were also in the group, as was Colonel Warren.

The chain of command, the hierarchy was slowly dissolving and soon would exist in history and memory only. There were spontaneous shouts of '*whoop!*' and other excited, humorous utterances, as the soldiers and alpha humans told stories and relived what would probably be taken as fairy tales should anyone outside the valley ever hear.

And those people were destined to hear: Even if the soldiers all decided to keep it secret; there's always me and my beautiful pen.

...And the inkwell is far from empty.

But that's OK, none of them were especially good at keeping secrets and Tyzmon, as we've seen, couldn't keep a secret to save the lives of those around him. He, of all people, would never need to, I suppose.

So it was quite late when they reached the top of the mountains. The nice, unusual, flat spot favored on previous crossings as a camp site. Most everyone was still acting jubilant, likely they'd seem drunk to a sober person. Oh well, they had nothing to apologize for.

And good news: the main camp had relocated itself to their campsite. So, when they came to the final stretch of the simple and ancient path leading between Eggshell and Low Mountains, even with just the light of the Moon, it was evident that they were not alone. Sentries met them as they rounded a final bend and there were happy shouts and the stories and jubilation continued.

Soon generators were active and lights on poles were lit and the party

started anew. Drinks were served and whoops were whooped. And if you were listening for nighttime wildlife you would have gone away disappointed.

Now the soldiers involved in the final battle(s) with the orcs got to tell it again! Even though the main camp already knew what had happened. But their excited cohorts, along with their alpha counterparts, now their guests, began it all again. Telling ... of the great battle, the great fire, the embarrassing situation when Tyzmon inadvertently revived the orcs after they'd all probably been dispatched to their shelves where everyone can hope they slosh for eternity.

Tomika and Tyzmon took advantage of the noise and distraction to find an out-of-the-way location which was suddenly the most romantic spot on Earth and the most romantic spot in history.

Colonel Warren, departed, urged into the crowd by Gisela.

Apollonia hooked her arm in Ralph's. He giggled — *what would you expect?* — she smiled and they joined the soldiers and security people and disappeared into the night, the crowd and the party.

~

When the Sun brought the wonder of the dawn to the mountains, the party, mostly, continued. But morning has always been the death knell of parties the world over from the beginning of time.

The morning light brought the extinguishing of party lights. Bed rolls were placed out in the open and some of the luckier ones had or had found partners to enjoy a cuddle upon the mountains and probably the deepest sleep next to death. And this was a group who could most certainly inform upon the subject.

Some large hawks with red tail feathers were making the most

miraculous call. Tyzmon, naked and holding Tomika's hand, came out from underneath secret bushes to see them again for the first time. He blinked away happy tears which glistened and sprayed and made small rainbows against the morning Sun.

With Tomika at his side, a lover and a student at once, he pointed at lizards and wildflowers and rodents and those *red-tailed hawks* and other animals and plants. And he gave them names that were the names from millions and millions of years ago and that only he could know were accurate; and perhaps they were.

Seks: Farewell my small canescent friends!

They spent the following night in the same place – at the epsilon soldiers' camp – enjoying another evening in the mountains. A lot of standing or sitting around in small groups talking, making plans, frequently plans together. But the party this time was more constrained, formalized, almost bittersweet.

For tomorrow a parting of ways.

Icon made a large fire and Radulf helped other soldiers set up benches around it. People, individuals, couples and groups, consisting of mixes of the two types of Earthlings, came out of the dark, sat on the benches and talked and warmed themselves by the fire.

Tyzmon and Tomika were not exceptions. This night they did more talking than – whatever it is they normally do – Tyzmon shared some epsilon words and phrases; she practiced her pronunciation; Tomika talked about Robots and medicine, programming and anatomy – she talked about a future in which she was an expert on alpha, beta and epsilon humans, culturally, and anatomically.

So there *is hope*. The best, smartest human from the farthest future can talk to a demigod – *or the scion of an alien race from another galaxy*.
Whatever.

As darkness came and lights on poles were brought online, although dimmed from their setting of the night before, individuals, couples and groups who wandered off didn't come back and eventually, the fire, untended by a sleeping Fireman, also went and didn't come back.

Tonight you could hear crickets if you were awake to do so.

And the night with its wonderful view of a Moon that was closer and brighter than it should be and Tyzmon still didn't know why, or how – *if that's the proper question* – but he'd forget anyway, so it probably doesn't matter.

~

In the morning, Icon rekindled his fire, was helping to make pastries and coffee.

After they ate and the museum staff started preparing to leave, Tomika gave Tyzmon a hug he wouldn't soon forget. We'll just pretend that's true. She smiled a good deal, but between us, I think she was acting brave.

Tyzmon had been talking to Radulf about something and before she could start down the hill, Radulf called Apollonia back, "can we borrow you today, can you wait?"

Apollonia called Tomika, already starting down the slope, and she came back with speed you'd never believe so I won't try to describe it. Apollonia said she was going to spend the day with Radulf and Tyzmon,

Icon and some of the soldiers but would have to return and didn't want to go back alone.

Of course Tomika could stay!

But the rest of the lightly furred archaic humans trudged down the hill, most of them solitary, but a few couples and groups. The days were getting a little colder in the mountains.

...and everyone's alive.

Chapter XVIII: Exodus and Revelation

En: The Ancient Cemetery

After the museum people were out of sight along the path, back down the back of Low Mountain, Tyzmon was put back to work reviving found bodies. Apollonia and Tomika were invited to be *pretty much anywhere else* ... and Tyzmon did what needed to be done for close to ninety people before noon. Some of them weren't soldiers, either.

After that, most of the soldiers stayed at the camp, they were briefing those recently revived and continuing to do whatever it is soldiers do when you aren't looking.

Tyzmon had an idea and led a smallish group down the hill and into the valley, he was looking for an area Icon should also recognize. Near the school was an old human school and near that school were older buildings and among them, in a large field, was a cemetery.

Apollonia and Tomika, Icon and Radulf, Colonel Warren and Tyzmon – and his dozen bodyguards – all started the journey a couple hours after the Sun was at its apex. They had camping gear and water, they hiked at a good and steady pace.

When the Sun was at 20° above the horizon, they stopped for a meal and to camp for the night. Tomorrow would be another day of walking.

~

Tyzmon and Tomika disappeared and the bodyguards spent the evening “protecting” Icon, Radulf, Warren and Apollonia.

With the Sun in the morning, Tyzmon and a smiling Tomika returned and they all ate a breakfast of—well—more cooked bird.

But the location they were looking for they had reached.

"When we were students, there was a park here," Tyzmon was saying, including Icon in the 'we'. "And the children called it *Dead Man's Park*. But it was really, or anyway, officially, "Founders Memorial Park". I learned the kids called it what they called it because it had been an old cemetery, converted to a park."

"What we're going to do," Tyzmon continued, "is, we're going to revive those ancient people. Or anyway, I'm going to try." He stopped talking, seemed to think about something, rubbed his nose slightly, then, addressing Apollonia, said, "you wanted to learn about the past?"

Icon started corralling people away from Tyzmon, almost far enough that they couldn't see him. Tyzmon was standing tall, his arms up and separated, his feet almost shoulder-length apart.

As they tried to see what Tyzmon was doing, there was a tremor. The ground shook violently, much much more violently than ever before during one of these *demonstrations*. The sky, earlier clear as could be, suddenly black with shadow, black with angry cloud. Lightning exploding from the ground into the sky and from the sky to elsewhere in the sky but also down to the ground and into Tyzmon himself.

And the rain. Oh the rain! It felt like it had to piss for a decade and was only now finally allowed to go. And it was warm too.

It rained and rained. The sky bubbled and boiled. The thunder was deafening, but you didn't worry about that, because the earthquakes were constantly putting you on edge, at risk of falling or having the world itself fall on you or swallow you up!

...and then it ended and the sky cleared supernaturally fast and birds were chirping again.

And then they could see Tyzmon, standing in what looked like a lake, standing up to his hips in water. Tyz was swinging his arms, faster and faster and then he took a step and then another step and his arms moved faster and he stepped up and, for a moment anyway, stood on the water, but then he lost his balance and fell and splashed, going completely under.

The water slowly subsided.

Tyzmon was standing, dripping, in the Sun, the day was beautiful. He stood alone. He started walking back to his assembled "safe distance" group.

At first, it seemed like nothing was going to happen.

But then the ground started to shift, the water, still running off, started to do so in distinct rows. The ground was moving, as though a giant cat was on the other side kneading the underside of the blanket that is the Earth's crust.

And then Tyzmon put his hands up again. And the rain came, again. And the bumps, the kneading Earth, were skeletons and then they were ghastly ghoulish bald and desiccated corpses. And then the dead were digging themselves out of the mud, surrounding Tyzmon, closing in on him and he kept his arms up.

The rain was a torrent, the worst rain storm ever. The people who had come down the mountain with Tyzmon were standing chest-high in water. He appeared to be in the center of an attack of hideously deformed, dead, but animated bodies, they mauled him, climbed on him, pulled him down, dragging him into the mud.

Then it was a pile of these bodies and the rain stopped and they kept

climbing, they climbed over themselves and there were so many of them. Their clothes had probably disintegrated long long long ago.

Corpses were still coming out of the ground. And those that were out were dragging their bodies across the mud-covered ground, in a large circle of bodies. Presumably under all those bodies was Tyzmon. But there were so many.

Icon could barely stand the sight. He wondered distantly if the others were having the same difficulty he was having. But they appeared transfixed, fascinated.

The grotesque scene lasted so long that it became the thing they were watching, bodies coming out of the ground to little-by-little drag themselves to the middle of a circle where they'd climb over other bodies, writhe and squirm and be parts of bodies, a tribute to all the nightmares of all the people with the best, most creative, scariest nightmares from the beginning of time.

And then the ground was still and the last bodies hauled themselves out of their long-forgotten holes and the pile was as tall as a moderate-sized building.

But then!

People began to emerge from the pile of bodies. They were nude, but they weren't the shiny horrific color of the dead, instead they were a kind of extra-pale version of Apollonia and Tomika. Those that walked out of the pile, as if through a veil, walked directly toward the group from up the mountain and over the mountains. Tyz's epsilon bodyguards assembled between the former residents of the Earth and the present residents of the Earth.

When these formerly dead people met the line of bodyguards, they were

proven harmless by speaking gibberish and seeming bewildered. Plus it's difficult to take a nude person seriously as a danger.

Colonel Warren touched his ear, "Liza," he said "we're going to need *hella* uniforms." There was a pause and then he said, "hella," as though it was an answer to a question.

Apollonia, sensing an emergency population problem, started hiking back in the direction of Low Mountain; the bodyguards herded the newcomers after her and then there was a river of people. There were just so many.

Three hours later Apollonia stopped walking, turned and looked. There were people behind her, single-file, as far as she could see. If she wanted access to archaic humans for historical purposes, Tyzmon certainly delivered. This is like a backyard gardener wanting rain and getting a tsunami. Under her breath, she remembered an idiom she'd read about long ago in an "ancients" anthropology class: "When it rains, it pours." Truer words were never known.

She didn't have food for a river of people and tried to be discreet as she continued walking and ate on the way. She activated her own comm, now integrated with that of the museum, "I'm going to come back with the best exhibit you can imagine." I don't know the recipient of the message.

To: The Longest Goodbyes

Even with most of the population of the valley circa 500 million years ago, the hike back up to the summit camp on Low Mountain only took 7 hours and that, only, because Apollonia kept turning around and looking in awe and wonder at the spectacle.

Liza had 39 uniforms produced when Apollonia returned to camp followed by an uphill-flowing river of ancient *alpha* humans. She decided to

decline the uniforms and just take the group back to the museum where they had better technology for clothing the masses.

Her legs hadn't had such a workout in thirty years, but then – how many times had Tyzmon casually touched her in the past several days? Even that one hand shake would have done it, if she understood. So it wasn't really a surprise to her that she had such endurance.

But then she was very excited. This was the biggest archeological find since the mines on Tau Ceti *double-prime*.

At Supply and IT, Liza told her that Tyzmon had commed ahead, “these people are called 'Quakers' you'll get to learn about that, they're the *society of friends*. That sounds pleasant enough, ja?”

“Ya,” Apollonia agreed. She refilled her water canister, shrugged and started back down the north slope toward the museum with a half turn, a smile and a wave for Liza of Supplies and IT. She touched her ear, “Liza ... ?”

“Yah?”

“Do you want the radios back?”

“No, we don't need them. We had to build most of them after Tyzmon did *whatever it was he did*, and anyway, you probably know, we'll be decommissioned as soon as we report in. Dead soldiers don't have to return equipment.” Liza laughed and the sound, to Apollonia's ears was a female Radulf, but she did recognize it as laughter.

Apollonia laughed and the comm cut off. The river of ancients flowed down the north slope of Low Mountain, relentlessly following Apollonia Laurentia, security chief for Daedalus Museum number three, and about to be a *very* famous person in this, the Milky Way galaxy.

Except for Apollonia, everyone else waited for the river of nude bodies to pass, waited for Tyzmon to emerge.

They had a long wait.

But finally, he came, he resembled, except for his clothing, the group he was a part of, at least, he did to Tomika. Radulf, Colonel Warren and his bodyguards saw Tyzmon as much taller than those he had revived. Also, there were a good hundred more behind him.

These people were, like all those before them, instructed to follow their own up the mountain, Tyzmon worried about them getting a sunburn, but there were too many for him to do much about it.

To Radulf, Tyzmon said, "About this Hamlet of Helgen Ynez – where is it? Is it closer to head straight there, or is it over the mountains?"

Radulf shook his head, for a moment not quite sure he heard what Tyzmon said, "you want to know where I was born?"

"We're going to get Lucy." Tyzmon said, as though reading a foreign language.

Radulf looked north, then east, away from the coast, he said, "it is on the other side of the mountains, but it's more around them than over them. It's east, *then* north."

"And this is the same direction for where you had Lucy buried?" Tyzmon allowed a smile to break his lips.

"Aye, yes, yes it is. You don't intend to return to the camp?" Radulf's voice was quivering.

"Not if it's out of the way," said Tyzmon with finality.

Tomika's eyes were watering hard, she grabbed Tyzmon's hand almost involuntarily. He closed his fingers around hers. "Yes, yes, it is goodbye for now. I'll see you soon, go with the colonel."

Warren had activated his comm when he heard the other start talking, so he understood. "Radulf!" He turned, arms open, the two men embraced, Warren slapped Ralph's back hard enough that everyone heard the noise.

"Yes, me too," said Ralph, "me too." They disengaged, Radulf dipped his head down in a kind of armless salute and the colonel did the same.

Tomika jumped into Tyzmon's arms, holding him with all four limbs, later she would be surprised at how emotional she had been. Tyzmon walked with the river of ancients and the bodyguards and the colonel for another twenty minutes and then he had to untangle his tiny alpha love-toy and send her back to her life in the biohazard ward of a museum in the mountains. He made his promise that they'd see each other again. And she made him say it, so he said it, "soon."

And then there were three. It was an anti-reunion, of sorts. It seemed like so long ago that Tyzmon and Icon discussed life and memory around a fire not that far from here and had a visitor in the night.

A soldier.

Tre: The ride

After four hours of walking, Tyzmon suggested they take a break. The walk out of the time envelope by going east and cutting north was no small feat. It means a trip around the Archangel Mountains in the south, cutting out of the valley proper and arching north into the elevated desert beyond. They'd cross out of the *zone* sometime tonight if they walked constantly.

Fortunately, for Radulf, anyway, Icon was very good at catching and cooking food. The current population of the planet, those the museum people called *epsilon*, were not vegetarians and made no apologies for whatever pain or fear went through the nervous systems of the creatures they ate.

This was going to take three days, easily.

Tyzmon touched his ear. He was already used to the comm, it was an extension of himself. "Colonel Warren," he didn't even wait for it to connect, "did you ever find your records?"

"Oh, yes, Tyzmon, ja, we found Ralph. He volunteered. But, Tyz ...?"

Tyzmon waited a moment, then said, "Yes?"

"You volunteered, too." Warren dropped it like a bomb. A comic bomb, but a bomb nonetheless.

"I...? I what?" Tyzmon turned his head as if to hear better; obviously Colonel Warren didn't see.

"You volunteered for the mission into the valley, you're one of us, my friend." He chuckled.

"That's *interesting*. I don't remember." He tried to concentrate, to remember. Something caught at his memory. In his head, papers shuffled almost too fast for his mind's eye to see; it couldn't read anyway and only looked at the pictures. "I wasn't dressed like you." He said it before he realized he was going to say it.

Icon waved his hand and, looking at Radulf, touched his ear, Ralph did likewise. Tyzmon repeated, "he said we both volunteered. Warren, Ralph and Icon have joined us on comm."

Warren said, "you are listed only as *special envoy*. I assume there's more information, but most of our equipment had to be built or, at least, rebuilt after you revived us. I'll call you in a couple days and tell you if there's more information...(?)" *It sounded like a question.*

"OK. Did Apollonia have any trouble with the Quakers?"

"Well, Tyz, the thing is, she just commed, she's already down at the museum. They're using a couple of our *learning machines* to try to learn the archaic language a little faster, but mostly to get all those people settled. You revived almost 2000 people, you know? ...the final count Sargent Laurentia gave me was one thousand nine hundred ninety-two." The colonel paused, "you fellas alright?"

Icon cleared his throat, said, "we're enjoying the day pretty well, you, Gisela? The um others?"

Warren hesitated minutely, said, "Oh, we're fine, pulling up stakes, as we speak."

Tyzmon again: "Let me know if you need anything, yes?"

"We will." The comm turned off.

"Radulf?" Tyzmon seemed to be looking at his crotch.

Ralph looked down, saw nothing, said, "what? What is it?"

"Why don't you just," he pointed, "carry us?"

Radulf's grin was huge, he giggled, he laughed. He took out the plum blade and turned away from Tyzmon and his brother. He pressed the handle, something clicked and a loud whoosh and there, almost a mountain itself, the Titan-Ralph.

The titanic Radulf carefully approached where the three men were

standing, put the knife blade down on the ground like a gang-plank. Icon walked up it. He thought it was slippery, but he managed well enough, bent over awkwardly, hands down and waddling. Tyzmon wrapped his hand around non-titan Ralph's hand, holding the purple knife. He put his other arm around Ralph's ribcage, held tightly and flea-jumped right into one of the enormous pockets in the Titan's robe.

And then they fell to the ground and the knife flew out of Ralph's grasp as he broke several bones in one of his arms. He probably twisted an ankle, too. Tyzmon stood up, dusted off primly.

Icon came running over, said, "What happened?"

Ralph could barely talk through the pain, but said, "I just learned that, ow, apparently, I have to be able to see."

Tyzmon leaned over and touched Ralph's forehead. "I'm sorry."

Ralph ran and grabbed the purple knife. "Let's try that again." And he pushed the handle and the Titan returned.

The Titan grabbed Tyzmon abruptly and placed him up on its ear. "Hold on." Then Icon, clutching a seam up on Titan-Radulf's neck. Finally, and carefully, the enormous robed figure plucked its tiny doppelgänger from the ground holding him securely in a crease between thumb and finger.

~

It still took three hours to exit the valley. But going by Titan sure beat going by foot. The mountains in the north, the Archangels were evening out and the huge man stopped moving. It put Ralph down. Then it put Icon down. Radulf, the enormous projection, laughed a low, loud bellow and Radulf, the normal-sized human dropped the knife and Tyzmon fell from that colossal height. "Revenge," Ralph said, between laughing fits.

Tyzmon smiled. He stretched. He turned north, the Sun barely at its apex, the best way to know north was still the mountains. Tyzmon said, "there's an old landmark I'd like to check out, if you two don't mind(?)"

Fire: The Archangel

"The barrier is near, I'm pretty sure." Icon was speaking, the three of them had been walking toward the mountains for a few hours. Icon turned to his brother, he said, "you know, Tyz."

Tyzmon looked at him.

"You didn't have to leave your stick, your—um—staff, behind." Icon's hand made a gesture like he was using a pole to help him with his hiking.

"Well, if I forget, maybe I'll just make myself another one." He smiled, they all laughed. "We should stop. You two should have a snack. I've got to find something."

And he was gone!

Icon and Radulf looked at each other with a little shock. Icon shrugged, Ralph shrugged. Icon said, "let's get that food, come on."

The two men hunted like all guys have always hunted from the beginning of time, all over this and any other planet suitable to hunting. They talked, laughed, found and lost sight of edible fowl and deer. Icon wouldn't have wanted to take a deer anyway, it would be a lot of meat, very heavy; very wasteful. In the end, it was quail, like always.

It still wasn't very late; it wasn't particularly cool either, but Icon built a fire anyway. Ralph joined him as he admired his enormously, fabulously too-big fire. "Tyzmon's coming back," he gestured toward the mountains, which were now mostly west. Sure enough, there was Tyzmon.

"You vanished, my brother?" Icon said languidly.

"Vanished?" Tyzmon sounded genuinely puzzled by the word.

Ralph said, "you disappeared, *piff!* You were there, then you weren't."

"Ah," Tyzmon smiled. ...and he was gone again!

Two minutes later, "Tyzmon's coming back," Radulf gestured west, toward the mountains.

"I know," said Icon, biting into a charred bird that looked like a fist-sized piece of coal.

Tyzmon was trudging toward the fire. He waved, "helloa!"

Ralph said, "what was that supposed to prove? You just did it *again*, why?"

Tyzmon said, "I don't know how to make myself invisible," *not yet*, "but sometimes I can move really fast."

Tyzmon was silent while the two men ate. And for a few minutes after that. There was a dog or coyote off in the distance... He kicked one of his exquisite boots against the dry ground, "did you guys want to see the Archangel?"

Icon did. He started putting out the fire. When he was finished, the three guys walked toward the mountains.

~

"This structure was carved by what Tomika's people would call *epsilon humans*, your people, Ralph." Tyzmon sounded like a lecturer.

Radulf and Icon were duly impressed. This was a carving of a winged man onto the face of the mountain itself. It was larger than the Titan-

projection caused by the plum blade. It was obviously quite old, yet the detail was holding up pretty well.

The carving was made in the rocks forming a kind of alcove which served to shelter the work from weathering but also to effectively hide it. You had to approach straight on, or you'd miss it completely.

The angel's face had been rendered looking slightly down so that if you were between a dozen and two dozen meters away, it appeared to be looking at you. In one hand was a scroll; but in the other hand was the grotesque deformity of an undeveloped (epsilon) fetus.

There were impressions that could be interpreted as flames, cut near the angel's feet.

"The scroll says something like this," Tyzmon pointed, "'Proceed against the bastards and the reprobates, and against the children ... of the Watchers' ..." He paused, then, apparently finished reading, "there's more."

Tyzmon exited the alcove and after a few seconds, Icon shrugged and they followed him out. Tyzmon was following the outside of the alcove which looked like a dark-gray hood.

"Here." He was standing at a kind of podium on a base. Tyzmon turned and faced Icon and Radulf. He began reading:

*Do not think me mad, these are the four that I saw that day.
The first is Mike. He suffers but he has empathy. Raf is
number two. He can set the bones, clean wounds and bind
against infectious diseases. He is known to be kind to children.
Third and best is Gabriel, depicted within. He controls all of
the powers. Fear him. Do not take this warning lightly. Fael,
the forth and final demigod, or archangel or eaglebeast,*

watches those who feel guilt after their crimes. It is from him that we get hope and eternal life. I have heard their voices. I certify these statements and carve them here.

They were all quiet. Tyzmon motioned with his arm, "come, there's a picture."

Ralph and Icon joined Tyz on the dais. Ralph pointed, "Tyzmon? It's you."

"Aye, but I do not know who these other characters are, these two," he was touching the flat, tilted top of the podium-like structure, the image, "or the big one in there." He shook visibly. "It seems like something I'd remember."

Icon said, "how did you know this was here?"

"I've visited this shrine before, possibly many times." He took a deep breath, shivered again, sighed, "I don't remember more. When I came looking earlier, today, the only thing I remembered was the large carving." He wiped the podium surface. He looked intently, but only momentarily, at the image pressed into the glossy stone using a technology with which he was unfamiliar. "Can either of you guys read this?"

But they shook their heads. "I want to go." It was Tyzmon, his voice airy and soft and far far away. "Something important has happened, or more crazy people. Either way, it's unpleasant."

Fem: The barrier

They followed the mountains, which curved in their bumpy, mountainous way, north and west and north. Tyzmon, whose stride was usually long and quick, causing others to kind of skip or run to keep up, was

beginning to slow down as though using a battery that was fast running out of power.

Radulf slapped him on the back, "Tyz?"

Tyzmon looked up, at nothing in particular, the darkness coming with the night, perhaps? Then turned to face his friend and his brother. "It is here. We're about to exit the area."

Icon felt nothing unusual. He touched his ear. "Colonel Warren please." A moment passed, then, "sir, you said Tyzmon *volunteered* to come into the valley?"

Colonel Warren's voice sounded a little strained, but he said, "I have documentation to that effect, it says he is listed and assigned. And before you ask, we haven't found anyone who remembers him or Ralph. We've been marching southwest toward *the city*. We're about to make camp on the southern hills, we should be exiting the valley tomorrow, noon, I guess(?)"

Icon: "We're about to exit now, Sir."

"Did you guys make good time!" Colonel Warren may have thought Icon was wrong.

"Ralph, he ah, the Titan. He carried us." Icon was *actually gesturing with his hands*.

Warren's lips made a smacking noise, "oh! Oh, ho ho, Oh, I see. Good, good plan." After a moment, "but you commed me?"

"Yes," Icon hesitated, a beat, then another, "I'd really like to know what happens to Tyzmon when he exits the Inclusion Zone."

Colonel Warren said, "the only information I have is that nothing unusual

happened to him coming *into* the valley from the *outside*. Does that help?"

Icon sighed with relief, "Yes, I think so, I think that helps. Thank you, Sir."

"We can talk if we're both in or both out of the zone, let me know if you need anything." And he was gone.

Seks: The Last KnifeHunter

Tyzmon had stopped walking and when Icon or Radulf attempted to guide him, he brought one foot up, maybe two and then was stone-still. Icon helped Ralph lift Tyzmon onto his shoulder. Tyzmon, it turns out, is much lighter than he looks.

They had to carry him out. They took turns. It was quite late when they stopped for the night. They'd kept up hope that Tyzmon would snap out of it or that they'd encounter a town—something.

Icon dropped his brother like a sack of root vegetables and began making a fire. Radulf sat with Tyzmon, checking his vital signs periodically.

"He's OK." Icon would sometimes say.

Soon the two men were eating roasted quail by a bonfire with a passed-out Tyzmon. It was like the time when they met.

Syv: The fork in the road

In the morning—and the two men did sleep, they were exhausted—Icon prepared breakfast over a resurrected fire, not quite the size he'd like, but large. Radulf was quickly slapping Tyzmon's cheeks or shaking him gently by the shoulders. He seemed alive, but he didn't move.

Radulf had an idea, "I should use the knife, put him in a pocket, we could

make great time.”

Icon was eating. He said, “I'm not sure. I think we should do it the hard way and just walk. If you're not up to it, I'll carry him. Maybe we can arrange it so his hand brushes my skin or something.”

They talked like this for a whole hour or more. They also spoke of other things, mostly related to Radulf's biography and their near future. Icon started putting out the fire and making the area appear as though they hadn't ever been there.

“I'll take the first turn,” said Radulf, heaving Tyzmon up onto his shoulder.

~

About twenty minutes out of camp, they found themselves on a path and the path got wider. Radulf didn't exactly know where they were going but a road is always a good thing. If he started to remember things, he'd start guiding them.

But this was a problem, because there was a fork in the road.

Radulf saw it coming, and Icon was slightly ahead of him. Radulf decided to follow Icon but that if he were asked, he'd suggest going right.

Otte: The Wisdom

In Tyzmon's own head, though, he was arguing with *Truth*. “No, I cannot abide that.” This was Tyzmon.

“Oh, but it isn't up to you, Tyzlad, now is it?”

Tyzmon said, “I don't know why I even brought this to you! What are you even doing here? What *are* you anyway?” They've had this

conversation before; they'd likely have it again. Tyzmon was frustrated, he couldn't even remember what they were arguing about.

Tyzmon's frustration made his face turn red. Abruptly and without thinking, he lifted his Tyzlane Staff and brought it down, hard, upon Truth's stalwart head. This motion resulted in a surprising series of events.

Truth fell, but didn't fall all the way to the ground, he kind of crouched, a little weary, a little afraid. He even put up his hands, to guard against another blow.

Tyzmon's eyes changed, he switched his grip on the staff, swung it as a sword, hitting Truth in the face. He swung it again, but changed direction minutely, Truth feeble, unable to block, a crack as what could only be construed as a wrist bone breaking.

Tyzmon proceeded to beat the demon with the Tyzlane Staff. He still couldn't remember what they had been arguing about. In fact his whole being was screaming out for revenge, for blood, for the agony of another entity.

But he didn't know why. And his whole being, his whole life was a mystery.

But he beat that demon with the thick and straight and heavy Tyzlane Staff anyway.

Ni: The narrow path

Tyzmon woke.

He took a deep breath. He was alive and he knew he was alive. Alive. Alive and breathing. He decided to try to get a look around. The pain in his arms was receding to a dull strain and he no longer felt he was nailed,

through his biceps, to the ground.

How bad were the wounds, he wondered. Apparently not bad enough: he was conscious. He could hear nothing but flinched, twice – bending to look – once for the pain, and once for fear that he'd made a loud noise and would bring an enemy to finish the job.

Did he cry out in pain? He couldn't be sure. But still, nothing, no movement, no other sounds.

His hands were covered in a hot red gel, it was blood. His Tyzlane Staff was covered with the stuff. There was an unrecognizable corpse nearby. Tyzmon decided to stand up and was able to get his feet under him without much trouble. There were no sounds. The air was too still, the environment too – too white. He picked up the staff and followed a narrow path past the pulpy blood covered body.

~

Tyzmon opened his eyes, the guys were carrying him, his arms were around their necks. He stumbled, trying out his own legs and then Radulf laughed and Icon was putting him down. He stood on his own two feet.

Icon and Radulf quizzed Tyzmon about the events of the last two weeks, his life in general and Tyzmon seemed fine. He didn't tell them about the beating.

He didn't tell them that he'd left a bloodied demon body and taken a path out of a bright white room to join them.

Radulf, Tyzmon and Icon continued walking. The valley behind them.

Ti: The dragons?

“What about the dragons: Do you think he was lying about the dragons, that orc guy – thing?” This from Radulf.

"That they're big? You saw one close up, *are* they big?" Icon said this, but was laughing before the end.

Tyzmon said, "no, if he was lying, he probably would have said they were 'dragons' or 'small dragons', he said 'large'."

"So we don't know?" Ralph was giggling.

Icon and Tyzmon exchanged a look, Icon said, "I guess not. I suppose they could be projections like your Titan, and the Giants. Or they could be the same kind of projections as my fire." He paused, considered.

"Yes, some kind of hybrid technology. And I have no idea how they fly unless the – unless the density is variable." But he was thinking and his voice was so quiet they didn't know if he was talking or if he was moving his lips to the silent reading in his own head. "But what about ..."

Mumbling, lips moving, then, "and the distances involved ..."

Exitus.

Epilogue

They fielded a couple comm calls from Colonel Warren and other soldiers as that group also exited the valley. The three men passed a few small villages, mid-sized towns and had walked straight down the middle of a large city.

They were following Radulf now, for the most part, so I'll let him pick up the reigns. You'll pardon me, I hope? I only wanted to discuss the events in the valley; the person Tyzmon and his acquaintances.

I hope you enjoyed the story as much as I enjoyed putting beautiful pen to glowing paper to write it all out for you.

I leave you here, dear reader. For I must sleep.

AFTERWORD

Curtain Call

En: The Last BladeHunter

Tyzmon was last seen heading northeast along an ancient road with his brother and Ralph. They were going to find Lucy, Ralph's childhood love who died of an infection in the process of losing their child.

But since no one knew where they were going, they wandered, hoping that soon Radulf would begin to recognize things.

It isn't like there was any hurry. And, it isn't like they couldn't call Warren—probably by now, no-longer a colonel—or Sasha or any of the soldiers. They'd find a place to rest, perhaps a store; buy a map.

To: The Titan

No one remotely challenged Radulf over ownership or use of the plum blade.

Perhaps Tyzmon had felt guilty or maybe he had no other entertainment ideas, Radulf wouldn't ask and so would probably never know. He may never know even if he did ask, but he felt impossibly grateful to Tyzmon and his brother for accompanying him back into his past.

"We never went back to the pit(?)" It was Radulf and his tone of voice made it sound like a question.

Tyzmon scratched his chin, "The pit with the orc?"

"You said you were going to have to revive the guy with the bandages all over his body." This was Icon, "you said Ralph was still in danger and we'd have to beat it out of him, who hired him, like that."

"Oh yeah." Tyzmon scratched his forehead, his hand sneaked into his

hood and he scratched the back of his neck. “Well. Well, guys, if we're threatened, or you're killed, I can only say, I hope I can revive you and we can get your answers from the replacement assassins.”

Tre: The Demon

Gone.

Or in some kind of dormant state.

But gone.

Fire: The Fireman

Icon had only ever left the valley before he died the first time. It wouldn't matter anyway: Hundreds of millions of years – the continents had converged and broken apart again and were beginning to re-converge again.

He was among friendly people, Radulf and his brother, and was useful, the cooking of food and making of light and heat by way of preparing fires.

What more could a man want?

Fem: The Colonel

Warren was a decommissioned soldier and so no longer held any rank at all. He was fine with that. But he was also, physically, twenty-three years old, he'd had a mitochondrial DNA test done and a telomere analysis for confirmation: *He was a young man.*

It was as though someone had taken his life and cut it into thirds and gave him one. The big mystery that none of the participants really wanted to confront was how they could remember anything at all. Various cultures have idioms to handle this situation.

"Never look a gift horse in the mouth." Is one.

Now ask Tyzmon and Icon what a 'horse' is.

Seks: The Mummy

They never went back for the assassin-in-black who had infiltrated the camp, refused to cooperate with Tyzmon, recognized Radulf and, finally, wrapped himself from head to toe like a burn victim.

So my guess is he's worm food.

Worms could do better.

Syv: The Chief and Joe

Perhaps Apollonia learned her lesson.

After Tyzmon revived him, she told Joe how she felt, how she didn't know she felt before. If they lived half a billion years earlier, in this very location, they likely would have gotten married.

Some of their new guests, the *archaic alpha humans* could probably educate them on the matter.

Who knows it could be the first wedding of *Homo sapiens* in half a billion years.

So let's just say it was.

Otte: The Doctor; The Girlfriend; The Robot Commander
Never trust a demigod.

Tomika didn't really expect Tyzmon to return. But he filled her erotic dreams and fantasies for the rest of her life.

The good news was that the memories were quite vivid and always worked ... well.

The bad news was that mere humanity wasn't enough for her.

...but she had her bio-bot army.

What more could an active fifty year old woman in the body of a seventeen year old need?

Still, if Tomika could have left the orée, she would have. Unfortunately, Sol had grown too bright for *first wave* humans, they were only safe if wearing extensive radiation suits and with portals made of gold. They were safe inside the fold – the *inclusion zone* – but the rest of the planet was pretty much off-limits.

In her dreams she walked out of the mountains and found her demigod who held her in his careful arms and never said 'no'. ...and she'd wake up sweating but happy.

And once in a while, the comm inside her bio-suit would chirp an unusual chirp. She'd hold her breath, but no one was calling.

Ni: Two Captains

Ivan and Callam.

Callam and Ivan, the dual captains Colonel Warren set as Tyzmon's completely and totally unnecessary bodyguards around the time revived soldiers were realizing that they had died and that Tyzmon was – well – whatever he was and that he was to thank for their—whatever you want to call it—their *afterlife*.

Originally hoping and fully expecting to resume military life, both of these men became embodiments of Warren's prediction of *retirement from*

military service upon death (even if you're revived and 'feel fine').

Being cut off from the thing they were most experienced at, but having bodies young and strong, they knocked about for awhile; possibly misspending their second youth. Not together, their assignment to Tyzmon was their only tie to one-another.

Eventually, they reconnected with Warren, now administrating a world-wide historical tourist and adventure company. He brought them – and any other soldiers who had found life (and death) in the valley – on and gave them the rank of *captain* but it meant nothing, not really.

Ivan was last seen dressed as a exploratory soldier in a re-enactment of some of the events in the Archangel Valley. But not actually in the Archangel Valley. He was promoting the travel agency regionally. *To us, it would appear to be a traveling circus.*

Callam was more the administrative type. It came as a surprise to him, too, truth be told. If you need him, he's probably filling out forms somewhere or hiring someone to clean toilets or build municipal gardens or some weird thing like that.

Ti: The Ghosts

Uta. Uta and Clarke.

The—mostly—unsung heroes of the largest orc battle, and the only one, really, that had been won. But that may be because it was the only true battle. As it is still possible the whole thing was an accident, a misunderstanding, a failing of technology.

If you don't know what you're doing with your technology, or see from the corner of your eye, possibly you'll notice motion where there shouldn't be motion. Or maybe something will be misplaced, but not by

you.

No one really knows what happened to Uta and Clarke after the battle. Icon and Colonel Warren spoke to Uta on the comm during “the big parade” and again as they hiked up the mountain to the south on the way to the long party on the flat summit of Low Mountain. But that day, the day after the party, mostly everyone was asleep or hung over. Well, at least until Tyzmon, with appropriately rolling eyes, touched their cheeks or the afternoon brought them to consciousness and attention to the details of hygiene.

Attempts to raise either Uta or Clarke on the comm met with the static of an unassigned comm code. Bob, hysterical, weeping, apparently more emotionally attached to his coworkers than anyone knew, eventually had to be taken care of by relatives who were once younger than him but now looked much older.

Bob, having to be physically restrained so he didn't get lost in the mountains after wandering in a forgotten valley north of *the city*, the madness consumed him as a candle in the night.

"Out there, they're out there."

Once or twice in a year, friends who had been in military service with him would visit their sad visits, share an øl or even two, going out, to a bar in town, or not, and leave him, feeling older for the effort.

He told younger relatives stories of dragons and giants and monsters called orcs and they had nightmares. When they were older, he told stories of impossible heroes who brought the dead to life, who shot fire—pew pew pew—from their fists, who, with the help of a magical blade, became Titans, giants compared to giants, giant killers.

He told of whole armies killed by flying rocks being brought back to life by a demigod.

He recounted the march of the silent statues, and talked of a parade with jugglers and robots and supermen and brave women.

Dramatic and impossible tales of people in romantic relationships with deities.

He also told macabre stories of disease and destruction from within. One such story concerned an infection that could not be cured, that caused paralysis and coma and would likely end in death. A permanent death, as the magic that brought his characters back to life was either absent or impotent to the power of this plague, this burning on the skin. Over games involving boards or cards, or at night, with the crackle of a campfire, *"the only solution was to kill the victims, blend their bodies, add water and filter the resulting liquid. Only then could the healer revive the sufferers who wouldn't really ever know the ghoulish treatment they'd had to endure."*

His stories always brought delight and a sense of adventure, assuming those listening weren't children, of course.

But the truth is, no one knows what happened to Uta and Clarke. Perhaps they're out there, somewhere, unseen, but watching.

Elleve: The Ambassadors and Courtney

And Erick, Courtney's father and Lauralee's mate...

Erick and Courtney continued entertaining visitors from around the galaxy (and, now, the Earth, too) dressed as much more accurate pre-galactic-pioneering – *ancient* – alpha humans.

Who doesn't love to play dress-up? Who would pass up the chance to

pose as people from when the world and humanity were young?

Lauralee, museum curator and ambassadress had more duties and responsibility now that *Epsilon Humanity* had taken to visiting the museum. But keeping those same people from forgetting the “fold” existed was someone else's job or no one's job but somehow Earth's people did keep visiting.

And, as a consequence, Mark V humanity began its slow reach – *its almost accidental push* – into astronomy and space flight.

Another hundred years and they'd join their ancestors, their Earthly cousins as *galactic citizens*. Assuming something didn't destroy all life on Earth first.

Mark I humans are known for being sympathetic so maybe they'd mount a rescue mission, I mean, *if it was necessary*.

Tolv: The Green Man and His Watchers

Don't worry about the books in Daedalus's bizarre house, his library.

It's also possible that he commissioned some fiction; who doesn't like a good story? Or that, somehow, Icon really did build the thing.

Who knows?

Tretten: The “Orcs”

So was Ephem the orc lying about his people's presence here? Could it have been a thwarted invasion? Were they really from the Milky Way? It *is* vast, certainly there is the odd corner that remains unexplored even after half a billion years... Unfortunately, it's a little difficult – and dangerous – to answer these questions.

There were no further encounters between Earthlings – of any era – and

those bizarre little creatures who claimed cohabitation of the galaxy. Perhaps it really was some kind of accident that brought the two groups into contact in the first place. Possibly it was all a gross misunderstanding.

...And it's also true that translation software, even in situations where both languages are known very well, isn't necessarily always 100% accurate.

Maybe it's just a sad testament to the fallibility of machines; *sometimes people die.*

And sometimes those people are revived and take their revenge.

Twice.

Acknowledgments

Cheerleaders / Test audience AKA #aVolunteers

(Alphabetical by Twitter handle)

αALPHANANO IS THE YELLOW DRAGON, OMAR ZABANEH ✕ αATHEISTARAB,
αATHEISTMUMMY, αATHEISTRPGURL, ROBBIE J MENDEZ ✕
αBADANIMAL1975, CALLAM THOMPSON ✕ αCALLAMTHOMPSON,
αCOURTNEYHAMMETT, αDACROSSE, αERICKESHEPHERD,
αFRANK__IS__FREE, αGEOLOGYGEEK,
IVAN NIMES ✕ αIVANATHEIST, KRIXWELL ✕ αKRIJAC98, MY MOMMY ✕
SUSAN SOTO, αMUSICROOTSS, αPANSY4THOUGHTS, MDS ✕
αPARADISELOST17, RIXI ✕ αQX, ROBERT PAUL MANN ✕ αROBOBMANN,
MICHAEL ✕ αS__DOLE__MELIPONE,
STEVE PARIS ✕ αSJPARIS, αSLAGOFFTWITS, αSTEVORCOMPTON,
αTHEDAVEWHALEY, αTSH1118, ANDREA STEELE, KRIS JONES ✕
αWELSHKRIS87

...Finally, KEVIN who doesn't use Twitter like
some kind of anti-social Luddite.

ADDITIONAL THANKS:

**JOSH ◇ @SECULARDAD, LITTLE LIONESS ◇ @KELSTHESECULAR,
MNEMONIXS ◇ @MNEMONIXS**

SERIES ARTWORK, GRAPHICS, COVERS:

DOMINIC ◇ @DOMINICVFX

TRANSLATING, FOREIGN LANGUAGE VOLUNTEERS:

**SASHA ◇ @GIRLSOUTSBAND, @JANMAGNOR,
JENS HARTMANN ◇ @TONGOTONGO_AU**

VOLUNTEER EDITING STAFF:

JAKE ◇ @BIBLERELOADED, LADY VANILLA ◇ @NAKEDLAUGHING

ADDITIONAL SCIENCE CONSULTING:

LAURA HUBBARD ◇ @LAURALEEBIOLOGY

FINALLY, RADULF OWES HIS LIFE TO LAURA M CIHOCKI.

~

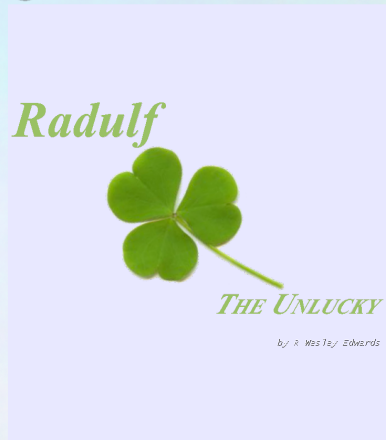
Coming soon...

"This Is Book 2" :: Razor: The Steel Edge & Radulf: The Unlucky

r wesley edwards



&



Razor: The Steel Edge
Radulf: The Unlucky